

NOT EVERY HERO
WEARS A CAPE...
SOME CARRY
A NATION.

A STORY OF WAR,
LOVE, SACRIFICE
AND A PROMISE THAT
NEVER DIES.

RUDRA
THE SHADOW

ARYA
THE HEART

RIDHI
THE STRENGTH

THE FALCON P R O T O C O L

The War. The Truth. The Rescue. The Promise.
One Man. One Mission.

One Love.

"WE DON'T
CHOOSE THE WAR...
THE WAR
CHOSES US."

PEACE WAS JUST
A PAUSE...
THE STORY **NEVER**
REALLY ENDS."

FALCON • 001

RED ALERT
FALCON PROTOCOL ACTIVATED

A NOVEL BY YOU
THE EPIC JOURNEY OF ARYAN, RUDRA, ARYA & RIDHI

Preface

War is often remembered through victories, medals, and the names written in history books.

But war is more than that.

It is the promises made before a mission.

The friendships forged in impossible circumstances.

The sacrifices no one sees.

The people who wait for someone to come home.

And the battles that continue long after the gunfire fades.

This story is about loyalty, brotherhood, loss, love, and the courage to keep moving forward when the world asks you to stop. It is about soldiers who stand between chaos and the innocent, and the people who give them a reason to fight.

But above all, this is a story about hope.

Because no matter how long the night lasts, no matter how difficult the road becomes, there is always something worth fighting for.

A promise.

A family.

A future.

A home.

So as you turn these pages, remember one thing:

Not every war is fought to be won.

Some wars are fought so that others may live in peace.

— **SilentMemories**

Chapter 1

The Last Calm

Part I

Mumbai rewarded those who never stopped running.

Every morning, before the sun had fully claimed the sky, millions of people stepped into a race they could neither win nor leave. The city moved with relentless purpose—cars flooding highways, cranes piercing the horizon, glass towers rising where old buildings once stood.

Among those towers stood the headquarters of **Sharma Group of Industries**.

Forty-eight floors.

Twelve thousand employees.

Projects spread across three countries.

An empire built over three generations.

And now, one heir.

At twenty-five, **Aryan Sharma** sat at the top of a company most people spent entire lifetimes trying to build.

Yet if someone entered the boardroom that morning without knowing his name, they would never have guessed he owned the company.

Because ownership demanded attention.

Aryan preferred control.

The boardroom occupied the entire forty-eighth floor.

Floor-to-ceiling glass walls overlooked the Arabian Sea. Sunlight reflected off the water and poured into the room, illuminating a polished conference table around which some of the most influential people in the country were seated.

Government representatives.

Senior directors.

Investors.

Industry experts.

People who controlled projects worth thousands of crores.

Yet every few minutes, their eyes drifted toward a single seat.

The head of the table.

Aryan Sharma.

Dressed in a charcoal-black suit, he sat with quiet confidence, a leather folder open before him. His expression revealed nothing. No excitement. No boredom. No impatience.

Only focus.

The presentation continued.

"Based on current projections, the Western Corridor Project is expected to generate record profits within the first three years," a senior director announced confidently.

Graphs appeared on the massive screen.

Revenue projections.

Expansion plans.

Future investments.

The numbers were impressive.

Very impressive.

Most people in the room seemed satisfied.

Aryan closed the file in front of him.

The sound was soft.

Yet the director immediately stopped speaking.
Across the room, a few board members exchanged knowing looks.
They had seen this before.
Whenever Aryan closed a file before a presentation ended, someone had made a mistake.
The only question was how big.
"Is there a problem, Mr. Sharma?" the director asked carefully.
Aryan leaned back slightly.
"Page forty-seven."
The director frowned.
"What about it?"
"Projected steel costs."
The director blinked.
"Our estimates have been verified."
Aryan nodded once.
"They're still wrong."
The room fell silent.
A government representative lowered his pen.
One investor stopped typing.
The director forced a smile.
"With respect, sir, our research division spent months—"
"They assumed stable pricing."
Aryan's voice remained calm.
"No market remains stable for three years."
The smile disappeared.
Aryan continued.
"If prices rise by six percent during phase two, profitability drops below sixteen percent."
Several people immediately began checking calculations.
Laptops opened.
Documents flipped.
Numbers were reviewed.
Thirty seconds later, the director's face changed.
A minute later, the investors were whispering among themselves.
Two minutes later, everyone arrived at the same conclusion.
Aryan was right.
Again.
The director slowly sat down.
The elderly man beside him shook his head in disbelief.
"I don't understand how you keep finding these things."
Aryan reopened the file.
"I read it."
Laughter spread across the room.
Even the director couldn't help smiling.
It wasn't arrogance.
Everyone knew that.
Aryan never pointed out mistakes to embarrass people.
He pointed them out because mistakes cost lives, careers, and sometimes entire companies.
One reason the board trusted him so much.
Another reason Sharma Group had continued growing even after tragedy struck the family years ago.
An elderly board member adjusted his glasses and smiled.
"Your father used to catch details like that."
The room quieted.
Almost instantly.
Nobody intended to make things awkward.

It simply happened.
The mention of **Vikram Sharma** carried weight.
Founder.
Visionary.
Legend.
And gone far too soon.
For the briefest moment, something flickered across Aryan's face.
Gone before anyone could identify it.
He simply nodded.
"Let's continue."
No one mentioned it again.
Some wounds healed.
Others merely learned how to hide.
The meeting resumed.
A few minutes later, the doors opened and a young woman entered carrying a tablet.
Nidhi Kapoor.
Aryan's personal assistant.
Twenty-four.
Sharp-minded.
Efficient.
And completely incapable of hiding her admiration for her boss.
She approached his chair.
"Sir."
Aryan didn't look up.
"Yes?"
"Coffee?"
"No."
"Tea?"
"No."
"Fresh juice?"
"No."
Nidhi folded her arms.
"You reject every beverage known to mankind."
Aryan signed a document.
"I drink water."
A few directors laughed.
Nidhi narrowed her eyes.
"One day, Mr. Sharma, I am going to make you smile."
Aryan looked up.
His expression remained unchanged.
"Focus on achievable goals."
The entire room burst into laughter.
Even one of the government officials nearly choked on his coffee.
Nidhi stared at him.
"You know, that's rude."
"It's realistic."
More laughter.
Nidhi groaned dramatically before walking away.
This routine was familiar to everyone.
Every week she tried.
Every week she failed.
Not because she wasn't attractive.
She was.

Not because Aryan didn't notice.
He did.
The problem was that Aryan noticed everything.
And ignored anything he considered unnecessary.
Including attention.
Including praise.
Including admiration.
The meeting continued for another twenty minutes.
Project approvals were discussed.
Budgets revised.
Deadlines finalized.
The atmosphere had returned to normal.
Until a security officer entered through the rear door.
Most people didn't notice him.
Aryan did.
Immediately.
His eyes found the man before anyone else.
A habit developed through years of discipline.
Years of training.
Years of learning that the smallest detail could change everything.
The officer walked directly toward Nidhi and whispered something into her ear.
The smile vanished from her face.
Instantly.
Aryan noticed that too.
Nidhi turned toward him.
There was concern in her eyes now.
Real concern.
"Sir."
Aryan looked up.
"What is it?"
Nidhi hesitated.
Something about her expression caused several board members to glance over.
The room slowly grew quieter.
The security officer stepped forward carrying a sealed black package.
No company markings.
No delivery label.
No sender information.
Nothing.
Just a plain black package.
Aryan's gaze settled on it.
The room watched silently.
"What is this?" he asked.
The officer swallowed.
"We don't know, sir."
A pause.
"Who delivered it?"
"No identification."
Aryan studied the package for several moments.
Something about it felt wrong.
Not dangerous.
Familiar.
A feeling he couldn't immediately explain.
The officer shifted uneasily.

Then added the one detail that changed everything.

"Sir..."

Aryan looked up.

The officer's voice lowered.

"It arrived through military clearance."

For the first time that morning—

Aryan Sharma stopped reading.

The boardroom fell completely silent.

And somewhere deep beneath years of discipline, responsibility, and carefully buried memories—

An old instinct began to wake up.

Chapter 1

The Last Calm

Part II

Nobody spoke.

For several seconds, the only sound inside the boardroom came from the distant hum of the air-conditioning system.

Military clearance.

The words lingered in the air like an invisible shadow.

The security officer stood motionless.

The board members exchanged uncertain glances.

Most of them had spent decades in business.

A few had worked closely with government officials.

Yet even they knew military clearance was not something that appeared in ordinary corporate meetings.

Especially not at Sharma Group.

Aryan's gaze remained fixed on the black package.

His expression revealed nothing.

But Nidhi noticed something.

She always did.

The slightest tightening of his jaw.

The subtle shift in his eyes.

The tiny changes most people missed.

For the first time that morning, Aryan wasn't thinking about the meeting.

He was thinking about the package.

And that alone was enough to make her uneasy.

"Sir?" she asked carefully.

Aryan looked away from the package.

"Continue the meeting."

Several directors blinked.

One of them cleared his throat.

"Mr. Sharma, should we postpone—"

"No."

His answer was immediate.

The director nodded.

Nobody argued.

Nobody ever argued when Aryan used that tone.

The discussion resumed.

Or at least it tried to.

Numbers continued appearing on the screen.

Forecasts were discussed.

Approvals were signed.

But the atmosphere had changed.

Everyone could feel it.

Even Aryan.

His attention remained divided.

A rare occurrence.

Very rare.

Then his phone vibrated.

Once.

A small sound.
Barely audible.
Yet the moment Aryan looked at the screen, the world seemed to pause.
It wasn't his corporate phone.
It wasn't his personal phone either.
This device was different.
Black.
Compact.
Unmarked.
The kind of device no one in the room had ever seen before.
An incoming call flashed across the display.
Unknown Number.
Encrypted Connection.
Aryan stared at it for a second.
Then answered.
"Sharma."
Silence.
The room watched.
Then a distorted voice emerged from the speaker.
Only one word.
"Commander."
The title echoed through the room.
Several directors frowned.
Commander?
Aryan's expression hardened almost imperceptibly.
The voice continued.
Too low for anyone else to hear.
Aryan listened.
Not once interrupting.
Not once reacting.
Twenty seconds.
Thirty.
Then he spoke.
Three words.
"I'm on my way."
The call ended.
Silence returned.
Aryan slowly placed the phone on the table.
Closed the file before him.
And stood up.
The room immediately froze.
Because Aryan Sharma never left meetings unfinished.
Never.
Not once.
Not in six years.
A government representative adjusted his glasses.
"Mr. Sharma?"
Aryan looked at him.
"The approval?"
The representative gestured toward the project proposal.
"This requires your final authorization."
Aryan picked up the black package.
"If there was a problem, I would've found it already."

Nobody had a response.
The elderly director smiled.
"Just like your father."
This time Aryan didn't react.
Didn't nod.
Didn't speak.
He simply collected his coat and walked toward the exit.
Nidhi hurried after him.
"Sir."
No response.
She increased her pace.
"Sir."
Aryan stopped.
Turned.
Nidhi suddenly realized she hadn't actually planned what to say.
"What happened?"
For a moment he simply looked at her.
Then came an answer she never expected.
"I don't know."
Four words.
Simple.
Honest.
Terrifying.
Because Aryan Sharma always knew.
Always.
Yet for the first time since she had worked for him—
He sounded uncertain.
The realization sent a chill down her spine.
Aryan checked his watch.
"I'll be unavailable."
"For how long?"
"I don't know."
Nidhi frowned.
"Should I reschedule tomorrow?"
Aryan considered the question.
Then shook his head.
"Cancel everything."
Her eyes widened.
Everything?
That had never happened before.
Not once.
Without another word, Aryan entered the elevator.
The doors closed.
And disappeared from view.
Ten minutes later.
Sub-Level Three.
Restricted Access Parking.
The underground facility was nearly empty.
Only security personnel occupied the area.
A black SUV waited near the far end of the garage.
Beside it stood a man in military uniform.
Colonel Arvind Mehra.
The moment Aryan approached, the officer handed over a sealed classified folder.

No greeting.
No formalities.
Just business.
Which meant the situation was serious.
Very serious.
Aryan opened the folder.
The first page contained a photograph.
Old.
Damaged.
Partially burned.
His eyes narrowed.
Snow-covered mountains.
Military vehicles.
Temporary command tents.
A forward operating base.
A place he hadn't seen in years.
A place he wished he had never seen again.
Slowly, he turned the page.
The next sheet contained only a single sentence.
No explanation.
No signature.
No source.
Just seven words.

WE FOUND THE ORIGINAL FALCON FILE.

For a moment, everything else disappeared.
The parking garage.
The city.
The noise.
The present.
Gone.
Only the words remained.
Falcon.
A name buried beneath seven years of silence.
Seven years of unanswered questions.
Seven years of grief.
Officially, the operation was history.
Officially, the investigation had ended long ago.
Officially, there was nothing left to find.
Yet somebody had just discovered a file that was never supposed to exist.
Aryan continued reading.
His pulse remained steady.
His expression unchanged.
Only his eyes betrayed him.
Colonel Mehra spoke quietly.
"We thought it was destroyed."
"So did I."
"There is more."
The Colonel handed over a small evidence envelope.
Aryan opened it.
Inside was an old military flash drive.
His gaze shifted to the evidence tag attached to it.
The date printed there made his blood run cold.
It was the exact day Operation Falcon had failed.

The exact day everything changed.

Aryan stared at it.

Unmoving.

Silent.

Then Colonel Mehra handed him one final item.

A folded note.

Nothing more.

Aryan unfolded it.

Read the message.

And for the first time in seven years—

The past came rushing back.

The note contained only two words.

PROTOCOL ACTIVATED.

Far above them, Mumbai continued moving.

Millions of people carried on with their lives.

Completely unaware that a ghost buried seven years ago had just returned.

And this time—

Aryan Sharma intended to uncover the truth.

Chapter 2

Blind Hunt

Part I

The Northern Command Operations Facility was one of those places that officially did not exist.

It appeared on no public map, carried no visible insignia, and was protected by enough layers of security to discourage even the most determined intruder. Located deep within a restricted military zone, the facility served as a nerve center for operations that were never discussed outside classified circles.

At 0530 hours, a black military SUV passed through the final checkpoint and entered the compound.

Aryan Sharma sat in the rear seat, his attention fixed on the classified folder resting beside him. He had barely slept since leaving Mumbai. The photograph, the recovered flash drive, and the handwritten note had occupied his thoughts throughout the night.

Protocol Activated.

Two words.

Yet those two words had dragged a seven-year-old ghost back into his life.

The vehicle came to a stop outside the Operations Wing. Before the driver could step out, Aryan was already moving.

The cold morning air greeted him as he exited the SUV and headed toward the main building.

The reaction was immediate.

Soldiers standing near the entrance straightened instinctively. Officers paused their conversations. Several personnel saluted as he walked past them.

"Good morning, sir."

Aryan acknowledged them with a brief nod and continued forward.

He had never enjoyed attention. Respect was useful. Recognition was not.

Five minutes later, he entered Briefing Room Three.

The room was already occupied.

Intelligence officers sat around a large oval table surrounded by digital displays. Satellite imagery filled the central screen while analysts worked silently at their stations. The atmosphere carried the familiar tension of an operation that had developed faster than the available intelligence.

The moment Aryan entered, every conversation stopped.

Several officers stood automatically.

"At ease," Aryan said.

The officers sat down.

A senior intelligence analyst activated the main display. A satellite image appeared, showing a remote mountainous region in Jammu and Kashmir. Snow-covered ridges stretched across the screen while dense forests occupied the lower elevations.

"Forty-eight hours ago, sir, military intelligence intercepted a series of encrypted communications originating from this sector."

The map zoomed inward.

A red circle appeared.

Aryan studied it carefully.

The highlighted zone covered a significant area.

Too significant.

The analyst continued.

"Signals intelligence suggests the presence of an unidentified hostile network operating within this region. Multiple transmissions were intercepted over the last week."

A collection of communication logs appeared beside the map.

Aryan remained silent.

The room waited.

He had developed a reputation over the years. Not because he spoke often, but because when he did, people listened.

"Continue," he said.

The analyst nodded.

"We believe the group may be using abandoned mountain routes to move personnel and equipment across sectors."

"Believe?" Aryan interrupted.

The analyst hesitated.

"Sir?"

"You said you believe."

The room grew noticeably quieter.

Aryan's gaze never left the display.

"Do we know they're using those routes?"

The analyst glanced toward a senior officer before answering.

"No, sir."

Aryan nodded slowly.

"Enemy strength?"

"No confirmation."

"Weapons?"

"No confirmation."

"Leadership structure?"

"No confirmation."

"Supply routes?"

"No confirmation."

The silence that followed was uncomfortable.

Every person in the room understood what those answers meant.

Incomplete intelligence.

The worst kind.

One of the senior officers finally leaned forward.

"We know they're there."

Aryan looked at him.

"And that's all we know."

Nobody disagreed.

Because it was true.

The briefing resumed, but Aryan's attention had shifted. Something about the information bothered him. Not the lack of intelligence itself. That happened often enough.

It was the pattern of the missing intelligence.

Experienced militant groups left traces. Supply movements. Communication patterns. Heat signatures. Human activity.

Here, there was almost nothing.

Too little.

Far too little.

The analyst switched to thermal surveillance imagery collected over the previous seventy-two hours.

Aryan stood up.

The room fell silent once more.

Without saying a word, he approached the main display.

For nearly a minute, he studied the imagery.

One image.

Then another.

Then another.

The analysts exchanged uncertain glances.

Nobody interrupted.

Finally, Aryan pointed toward a narrow valley running between two ridgelines.

"What is this sector?"

The analyst enlarged the area.

"Natural terrain feature, sir."

Aryan continued staring at the image.

"No."

The analyst frowned.

"Sir?"

Aryan folded his arms.

"Show me the thermal overlays from all three nights."

The images appeared side by side.

The room watched carefully.

At first glance, there was nothing unusual. Scattered heat signatures appeared throughout the region, consistent with wildlife movement and occasional human activity.

Then Aryan noticed it.

A pattern.

Small.

Subtle.

Easy to miss.

Yet impossible to ignore once seen.

"Zoom in."

The analyst complied.

Several officers leaned forward.

Aryan pointed toward three separate thermal signatures located hundreds of meters apart.

"Those aren't random."

The analyst stared at the display.

"They could be."

"They aren't."

Confidence filled Aryan's voice.

Not arrogance.

Certainty.

The difference mattered.

He turned toward the room.

"If this were a traditional militant camp, activity would concentrate around a central location. Storage, communications, personnel movement, logistics—they create patterns."

He pointed back toward the screen.

"This doesn't."

The room remained silent.

Several analysts were already rechecking the data.

Aryan continued.

"The signatures are deliberately dispersed. Small enough to avoid attention. Far enough apart to prevent detection through conventional observation."

A senior intelligence officer slowly nodded.

He was beginning to see it too.

Aryan returned his gaze to the map.

"They don't have a camp."

The analyst frowned.

"Then what are we looking at?"

Aryan didn't answer immediately.

Because he wasn't entirely sure.

And uncertainty irritated him.

Finally, he spoke.

"We're looking at a layer we haven't identified yet."

The room became silent once again.

"Sir?"

Aryan's eyes remained fixed on the screen.

"Someone wants us to see these positions."

Nobody moved.
Nobody spoke.
Every person in the room understood the implication.
A trap.
Or a deception.
Or something even worse.
The intelligence officer swallowed.
"You think we're missing something?"
Aryan looked back at the satellite imagery.
The feeling returned.
The same feeling he had experienced when the Falcon file first landed on his desk.
The sense that something important existed just beyond reach.
"We're missing a lot more than something," he said quietly.
Then he turned toward the operations team.
"We're preparing a mission with incomplete intelligence, unknown enemy strength, unknown weapon systems, and no confirmed defensive positions."
The room remained silent.
Because everyone knew he was right.
For the first time since the briefing began, Aryan allowed himself to acknowledge the truth.
Alpha Team wasn't heading toward a target.
They were heading toward a question.
And questions had a habit of becoming dangerous.

Chapter 2

Blind Hunt

Part II

The briefing room remained silent long after Aryan finished speaking.

No one challenged his assessment.

Not because of rank.

Not because of reputation.

Because over the years, experience had taught them a simple lesson: if Aryan Sharma said something felt wrong, there was usually a reason.

The problem was that this time even he couldn't identify exactly what was wrong.

The map still occupied the main display.

Red markers indicated suspected enemy activity.

Communication intercepts appeared on a secondary screen.

Satellite images rotated through different angles and timestamps.

Yet despite the volume of information, the room felt blind.

Aryan returned to his seat and opened the mission folder once again.

Every page raised more questions than answers.

The intercepted transmissions contained no names.

No identifiable callsigns.

No confirmed command structure.

Even the communication patterns appeared deliberately inconsistent.

Whoever they were hunting knew exactly how intelligence agencies worked.

That alone made them dangerous.

A senior signals officer broke the silence.

"Sir, should we postpone deployment until additional reconnaissance becomes available?"

Aryan looked up.

"How long would that take?"

The officer hesitated.

"Three to five days."

Another analyst immediately shook his head.

"We may not have three days."

A new image appeared on the screen.

This one had been captured less than an hour earlier.

A thermal signature.

Brief.

Unclear.

But definitely human.

The room studied it carefully.

"We believe movement has increased during the last twelve hours," the analyst explained.

Aryan folded his arms.

"They know we're getting close."

Nobody argued.

The possibility had already crossed everyone's mind.

If the hostile network had detected surveillance activity, delaying the mission could mean losing them entirely.

The room once again found itself trapped between two bad options.

Move with incomplete intelligence.

Or wait and risk losing the target.

Neither choice was ideal.
The door suddenly opened.
Several heads turned.
Four men entered the room without speaking.
The atmosphere shifted instantly.
Even the intelligence officers sat straighter.
Alpha Team.
India's most classified operational unit.
The team rarely appeared outside active deployments, and whenever they did, it usually meant somebody was about to have a very bad day.
The first man through the door was impossible to miss.
Tall.
Athletic.
Sharp-eyed.
A permanent smirk resting on his face.
Rudra Rathode.
Twenty-three years old.
Second-in-command of Alpha Team.
One of the few people capable of arguing with Aryan and surviving the experience.
His gaze immediately moved toward the main screen.
"Looks bad."
Aryan looked at him.
Rudra studied the satellite images for a few seconds before adding,
"Actually, forget that. Looks worse."
A few officers exchanged amused glances.
Trust Rudra to walk into a classified briefing and say exactly what everyone else was thinking.
The remaining team members entered behind him.
Without ceremony.
Without introductions.
Each one immediately focused on the mission board.
Professionals.
No unnecessary questions.
No unnecessary conversations.
Rudra pulled a chair beside Aryan.
"What do we know?"
Aryan closed the folder.
"Very little."
Rudra blinked.
That answer alone was concerning.
When Aryan admitted they knew very little, it usually meant they knew almost nothing.
"Enemy strength?"
"Unknown."
"Weapons?"
"Unknown."
"Positions?"
"Unknown."
Rudra stared at him for a moment.
Then slowly nodded.
"So we're blind."
Aryan didn't answer.
He didn't need to.
The silence confirmed everything.
For several seconds nobody spoke.

The reality of the situation settled heavily across the room.
Alpha Team had executed hostage rescues, counter-terror operations, high-value target eliminations, and deep infiltration missions.
But every successful operation depended on one thing.
Information.
And right now they had almost none.
Finally, Rudra leaned back in his chair.
"So what's the plan?"
Aryan looked toward the map again.
The question had occupied his thoughts since the briefing began.
Normally he would already have three different operational approaches prepared.
This time every option carried unacceptable risks.
The enemy could be twenty men.
Or two hundred.
The valley could contain supply caches.
Or minefields.
The thermal signatures could indicate observation posts.
Or decoys.
Every conclusion led to another uncertainty.
Every answer produced three more questions.
Then something clicked.
Not a solution.
A possibility.
Aryan stood.
The room immediately focused on him.
"They want us looking at the valley."
The large screen remained illuminated behind him.
"They've created enough activity to attract attention but not enough to reveal anything useful."
Several analysts nodded.
That matched their findings.
Aryan continued.
"So we stop looking where they want us to look."
The room became quiet.
One officer frowned.
"What are you suggesting?"
Aryan zoomed out the map.
The valley became smaller.
The surrounding terrain became visible.
Mountain ridges.
Forested slopes.
Narrow access routes.
Then Aryan pointed toward an isolated section nearly six kilometers away from the suspected activity.
"We insert here."
Several officers looked surprised.
"There is nothing there."
"Exactly."
The words hung in the air.
Aryan's finger remained on the map.
"If I wanted to hide an operational network, I would draw attention somewhere else."
Rudra's smirk slowly disappeared.
Now he understood.
The enemy had created a visible layer.
Aryan wanted to search beneath it.

A dangerous strategy.
But perhaps the only one available.
The operations commander studied the proposal.
"You're basing this on instinct."
Aryan met his gaze.
"No."
A pause followed.
Then he added,
"I'm basing it on experience."
The difference mattered.
Experience had kept Alpha Team alive for years.
Eventually the commander nodded.
"Approved."
The decision was made.
Fast.
Clean.
Final.
The room immediately came alive.
Analysts updated maps.
Logistics officers prepared transport requests.
Communication specialists established encrypted channels.
Within minutes the briefing room transformed into a deployment center.
Alpha Team was moving.
Aryan watched the controlled chaos around him.
Despite the activity, the uncomfortable feeling remained.
Something was missing.
Something important.
He could feel it.
But he couldn't see it yet.
That bothered him more than he cared to admit.
Two hours later, the team stood inside a military airfield.
The rotors of a transport helicopter thundered against the cold morning air.
Ground crews moved quickly around the aircraft.
Equipment was loaded.
Weapons checked.
Final clearances confirmed.
Rudra adjusted his tactical vest before glancing toward Aryan.
"You look like you're thinking."
Aryan looked at the helicopter.
"I am."
"That's usually when people start shooting at us."
A faint smile almost appeared on Aryan's face.
Almost.
Rudra noticed.
"Well, that's terrifying."
The helicopter crew signaled for boarding.
One by one, Alpha Team climbed aboard.
The engines roared louder.
Dust swirled across the tarmac.
Aryan took one final look toward the operations building before stepping inside.
The ramp closed behind them.
A moment later, the helicopter lifted off the ground.
The base quickly disappeared beneath them.

Ahead lay Jammu.

An unknown enemy.

Incomplete intelligence.

And a mission built almost entirely on questions.

For the first time in years, Alpha Team was heading into an operation without knowing who they were really hunting.

And somewhere in the mountains waiting for them—

Someone was counting on that.

Chapter 3

Into The Dark

Part I

The helicopter disappeared into the darkness long before anyone on the ground could hear it.

Its mission was simple.

Insert Alpha Team.

Leave.

Forget they were ever there.

At 0217 hours, six figures emerged from the shadows of a dense pine forest nearly twelve kilometers from the suspected operational zone.

The temperature had dropped below freezing.

A bitter mountain wind moved through the trees, carrying with it the scent of wet earth and pine resin. The moon remained hidden behind heavy clouds, leaving the valley drenched in darkness.

For most people, the terrain would have been impossible to navigate.

For Alpha Team, it was just another night.

Aryan Sharma moved at the front of the formation.

His night-vision optics painted the world in shades of green as he scanned the forest ahead. Every few seconds his gaze shifted between the terrain, thermal readings, and movement indicators displayed inside his tactical headset.

Nothing.

No heat signatures.

No movement.

No signs of human activity.

Which only made him more cautious.

Behind him, the remaining members maintained perfect spacing.

No unnecessary conversation.

No wasted movement.

Every footstep was measured.

Every shadow examined.

The mission had begun less than an hour ago, yet something already felt wrong.

Aryan couldn't explain it.

The feeling wasn't based on evidence.

It wasn't based on intelligence.

It was instinct.

The same instinct that had kept him alive through years of operations where a single mistake meant death.

The forest around them seemed too quiet.

At first glance, everything appeared normal.

The wind moved through the trees.

Branches shifted overhead.

Occasional rocks rolled down distant slopes.

Yet beneath those familiar sounds was an absence that continued to bother him.

The absence of life.

No insects.

No birds.

No movement from small animals.

Nothing.

The mountain felt empty.

As if something had driven everything away.

A hand signal flashed through the darkness.
Formation tighten.
The order moved silently through the team.
Within seconds, their spacing adjusted.
Nobody questioned it.
Nobody needed an explanation.
If Aryan signaled caution, there was a reason.
Rudra Rathode, covering the rear sector, increased his pace slightly until he came alongside Aryan.
"Still don't like this place?"
His voice remained low enough that only Aryan could hear it through encrypted communications.
Aryan kept moving.
"I liked it even less ten minutes ago."
Rudra sighed.
"That's not reassuring."
"It wasn't supposed to be."
A faint grin appeared beneath Rudra's tactical mask.
Some things never changed.
Not even on operations.
The team continued advancing through the forest.
According to satellite imagery, they were now approaching the outer boundary of the valley that had attracted military attention.
The same valley that appeared repeatedly in intercepted communications.
The same valley where thermal signatures had been detected.
The same valley that Aryan suspected was hiding something much larger.
Or perhaps hiding nothing at all.
That possibility bothered him more.
An obvious enemy could be fought.
A hidden enemy was different.
Hidden enemies controlled the battlefield.
And right now, Alpha Team was operating almost completely blind.
Thirty minutes later, the terrain began changing.
The forest grew denser.
Visibility dropped.
Large rock formations emerged between the trees, creating natural blind spots in every direction.
Perfect ambush terrain.
Aryan slowed his pace.
The others immediately followed.
A narrow ridgeline appeared ahead.
According to the mission map, crossing it would provide visual access to the valley.
The objective lay beyond.
Aryan raised a clenched fist.
Instantly, six operators froze.
The movement was so synchronized it appeared almost unnatural.
Silence consumed the forest.
Nobody spoke.
Nobody moved.
Aryan lowered himself toward the ground.
Something had caught his attention.
At first glance it appeared insignificant.
A patch of disturbed soil.
Partially hidden beneath fallen leaves.
Easy to miss.
Almost impossible to notice while moving.

Rudra crouched beside him.
"What is it?"
Aryan brushed away a layer of dirt.
The answer appeared immediately.
A boot print.
Fresh.
Very fresh.
Rudra's expression hardened.
The others quietly shifted into defensive positions.
Aryan examined the impression carefully.
The tread pattern was clear despite the terrain.
Military grade.
No doubt about it.
But not Indian military issue.
He checked the dimensions.
Large.
Heavy.
The kind of boot designed for extended field operations.
Whoever left it behind knew what they were doing.
More importantly—
Whoever left it behind had passed through recently.
Very recently.
Aryan scanned the surrounding ground.
A second print appeared several meters away.
Then another.
Then another.
His eyes narrowed.
Something wasn't right.
Rudra noticed immediately.
"What?"
Aryan remained silent.
The pattern continued for nearly twenty meters before disappearing completely.
No return trail.
No continuation.
Nothing.
Just a series of prints appearing from nowhere and ending nowhere.
That was impossible.
Even the best operators left signs behind.
Yet these tracks simply vanished.
As if the individuals responsible had walked into the forest and ceased to exist.
Rudra studied the ground.
"I don't like that."
Neither did Aryan.
The tracks suggested movement.
But not destination.
Someone wanted them to find these.
The realization settled heavily in his mind.
Because there was a significant difference between discovering evidence and being shown evidence.
One happened naturally.
The other was intentional.
His gaze shifted toward the darkness ahead.
The valley lay less than a kilometer away now.
Close enough.

Too close.
For several seconds, nobody spoke.
Then one of the operators quietly transmitted a message.
"Commander."
Aryan turned.
"What is it?"
The operator pointed toward a nearby tree.
At first Aryan saw nothing unusual.
Just another pine tree standing among hundreds of others.
Then his night-vision optics focused.
And he saw it.
A mark.
Carved into the bark.
Old.
Weathered.
Deliberate.
Aryan approached slowly.
The others followed.
Nobody spoke.
The symbol had survived years of exposure to wind and rain.
Yet its shape remained recognizable.
Painfully recognizable.
For a moment, Aryan simply stared at it.
His pulse remained steady.
His expression unchanged.
But something cold settled in his chest.
Because he had seen that symbol before.
Not in the forest.
Not on a battlefield.
Inside a classified file.
Inside a photograph recovered less than twenty-four hours earlier.
The same symbol.
The same design.
A falcon.
The forest suddenly felt much colder.
Rudra stepped closer.
His eyes fixed on the carving.
The color drained from his face.
Because he recognized it too.
Neither man spoke.
Neither needed to.
One question echoed through both their minds.
How?
Operation Falcon had been classified.
Its existence buried beneath layers of secrecy.
Very few people even knew the name.
Yet the symbol stood before them in the middle of a remote valley hundreds of kilometers away.
Waiting.
As though someone had placed it there specifically for them to find.
A gust of wind swept through the trees.
Branches shifted overhead.
Shadows moved across the forest floor.
Then a faint sound crackled inside Aryan's earpiece.

Static.

He froze.

Every member of Alpha Team noticed immediately.

The transmission channel was encrypted.

No one should have been able to access it.

The static grew louder.

Then a voice emerged from the darkness.

Calm.

Male.

Distorted.

And unmistakably directed at him.

"You're looking in the wrong valley, Commander."

The transmission ended.

Silence returned.

Nobody moved.

Nobody breathed.

Aryan slowly lifted his head and looked into the darkness beyond the ridgeline.

For the first time since entering the mountains, one fact became terrifyingly clear.

The enemy wasn't hiding from Alpha Team.

The enemy was watching them.

Chapter 3

Into The Dark

Part II

For several seconds after the transmission ended, nobody moved.

The forest remained silent.

The wind continued drifting through the trees.

Yet something had changed.

The feeling was impossible to describe.

It was the sensation every experienced operator recognized instinctively—the moment when a mission stopped being a hunt and became something else entirely.

A trap.

Aryan's gaze remained fixed on the darkness ahead.

The voice had known two things.

His position.

And his identity.

Neither should have been possible.

Not here.

Not in the middle of a classified operation.

Not on an encrypted military frequency.

Slowly, he raised a hand.

The team immediately shifted into defensive formation.

Weapons came up.

Thermal optics activated.

Every sector was covered.

Still nothing appeared.

No heat signatures.

No movement.

No visual contact.

The mountains remained empty.

Which somehow made the situation worse.

Rudra crouched beside him.

"Tell me I imagined that."

Aryan didn't look away from the treeline.

"You didn't."

"Great."

Rudra adjusted his rifle.

"That's exactly what I wanted to hear."

One of the operators began scanning communication logs through his wrist-mounted terminal.

"Commander, no intrusion detected."

Aryan finally turned.

"What do you mean?"

"The channel shows no breach."

The operator looked confused.

"No foreign signal."

"No unauthorized access."

"No transmission source."

Silence.

That wasn't possible.
Every signal left a trace.
Every transmission originated from somewhere.
Yet according to the system, the voice technically didn't exist.
The realization settled heavily over the team.
Someone was playing a game they didn't fully understand.
Aryan looked back toward the falcon symbol carved into the tree.
His instincts screamed that both events were connected.
The carving.
The transmission.
The valley.
None of it felt random.
Someone wanted them here.
The question was why.
He stepped closer to the tree.
Years of weather had damaged the bark, but the carving itself remained visible.
Deliberate.
Professional.
The cuts were precise.
Made by someone with patience.
Not a hurried message.
Not a random marking.
A symbol meant to survive.
Rudra joined him.
"You thinking what I'm thinking?"
Aryan nodded slightly.
"Someone expected this to be found."
Rudra's jaw tightened.
"Recently?"
"No."
Aryan ran a gloved finger across the edge of the carving.
"The wood's too old."
"Then how?"
That was the problem.
Neither explanation made sense.
If the carving was recent, the weathering shouldn't exist.
If it was old, someone had known years ago that Alpha Team would stand in this exact location.
Both possibilities sounded ridiculous.
Neither could be dismissed.
One of the operators suddenly raised a hand.
"Movement."
Every weapon shifted instantly.
The forest froze.
"Direction?"
"North-east."
Aryan activated thermal optics.
The display scanned through trees, rocks, and uneven terrain.
A faint heat signature appeared.
Then disappeared.
Not human.
A mountain fox emerged from the undergrowth and vanished between the rocks.
Several team members relaxed slightly.
Aryan didn't.

The interruption had revealed something important.
The forest wasn't dead.
Wildlife still existed here.
Which meant the unnatural silence earlier wasn't environmental.
It had been temporary.
Created.
Again, something wasn't adding up.
He turned toward the valley below.
The ridgeline offered a partial view of the area intelligence had been monitoring for days.
Through night vision, the landscape appeared empty.
No fires.
No patrols.
No camps.
No movement.
Nothing.
Exactly what he had expected.
The valley was too obvious.
Too visible.
Too perfect.
If hostile operators were actually present, they wouldn't choose a location this exposed.
Not unless they wanted attention.
The realization triggered another thought.
A dangerous one.
Aryan knelt and unfolded a digital terrain map.
His eyes moved across contour lines, elevation markers, and natural routes.
Then he saw it.
Not something present.
Something absent.
The map showed three natural approaches into the valley.
All three were visible.
All three could be monitored easily.
All three practically invited surveillance.
Which meant any competent force would avoid them.
His eyes shifted farther west.
Toward an area intelligence had largely ignored.
The terrain there looked terrible.
Steep.
Rocky.
Difficult to traverse.
Exactly the kind of route most analysts would dismiss.
Exactly the kind of route an experienced enemy would use.
Rudra noticed the change in his expression.
"What did you find?"
Aryan zoomed the map.
A narrow mountain corridor appeared.
Hidden between two ridgelines.
Almost invisible unless someone specifically searched for it.
Rudra frowned.
"That route leads away from the valley."
Aryan nodded.
"I know."
"Then why are you looking at it?"
For several seconds Aryan didn't answer.

Because a disturbing possibility was beginning to form.
Everything about the operation so far pointed toward misdirection.
The thermal signatures.
The intercepted communications.
The valley.
Even the mysterious transmission.
Every clue directed attention toward one location.
Which raised an uncomfortable question.
What if that was the entire purpose?
What if the enemy wanted them focused on the valley because the real objective was somewhere else?
The thought lingered.
Growing heavier with every passing second.
One of the operators checked his watch.
"Commander, sunrise in four hours."
Not much time.
They needed answers.
Fast.
Aryan stood.
Decision made.
"We move west."
Several heads turned.
Even Rudra looked surprised.
"We're abandoning the objective?"
"No."
Aryan folded the terrain map.
"We're looking for the real one."
Nobody argued.
Not because they completely understood.
Because they trusted him.
Every member of Alpha Team knew the same truth.
Aryan rarely acted on guesses.
If he was changing direction in the middle of a mission, there was a reason.
The formation reorganized immediately.
Within minutes they were moving again.
This time away from the valley.
Away from the location everyone expected them to investigate.
The forest became denser as they advanced.
The terrain grew steeper.
Progress slowed.
Yet with every kilometer they traveled, Aryan felt increasingly certain they were heading toward something important.
What exactly that was, he couldn't say.
Not yet.
Then, forty minutes later, the lead scout stopped abruptly.
The entire formation froze.
Aryan moved forward.
"What happened?"
The scout pointed ahead.
At first Aryan saw nothing.
Then the darkness shifted.
Not movement.
A shape.
Artificial.
Hidden among the rocks.

His pulse quickened.
Slowly, he raised his binoculars.
The image sharpened.
And for the first time that night, he found undeniable proof that someone was operating in the mountains.
Half concealed beneath camouflage netting stood a reinforced steel door built directly into the mountainside.
No roads led to it.
No markings identified it.
No satellite image had ever reported its existence.
Yet there it was.
Hidden in plain sight.
Aryan stared at the structure.
The pieces finally began falling into place.
The valley had been a distraction.
The transmission had been a warning.
And whatever they were actually hunting—
It was behind that door.
Far behind them, unseen in the darkness, a distant figure lowered a pair of binoculars and smiled.
Alpha Team had finally found the entrance.
Exactly as planned.

Chapter 4

The Door Beneath The Mountain

Part I

For nearly thirty seconds, nobody spoke.

The reinforced steel door stood silently against the mountainside, partially concealed beneath camouflage netting that had blended so perfectly with the surrounding terrain that even trained military observers would have missed it from a distance.

Aryan lowered his binoculars.

The discovery raised more questions than answers.

According to every intelligence report they possessed, there was supposed to be nothing in this sector.

No military installations.

No abandoned facilities.

No underground structures.

No recorded construction activity.

Yet an armored blast door nearly twelve feet high stood before them.

Which meant one thing.

Someone had gone to extraordinary lengths to keep it hidden.

Alpha Team advanced carefully.

Weapons remained raised.

Night-vision optics scanned every angle.

The possibility of an ambush could not be ignored.

Whoever built the facility understood concealment.

People like that rarely left surprises unattended.

Aryan reached the outer perimeter first.

The structure appeared even more unusual from up close.

The door wasn't new.

Years of exposure had left faint signs of wear across the steel surface.

Yet unlike abandoned military installations, there was almost no corrosion.

No structural damage.

No visible weakness.

Someone had maintained it.

Recently.

He crouched near the lower edge and ran a gloved finger across the ground.

The soil told its own story.

Compressed earth.

Disturbed gravel.

Faint impressions.

Traffic.

Not heavy.

Not frequent.

But enough.

The entrance had been used.

Rudra appeared beside him.

"You seeing what I'm seeing?"

Aryan nodded.

"Recent movement."

"How recent?"

Aryan examined another mark near the doorway.
"Within the last few days."
Rudra looked back toward the forest.
The realization settled heavily between them.
Someone was here.
Or had been.
Very recently.
One of the operators moved toward the left side of the structure.
"Commander."
Aryan turned.
The operator pointed toward a section of exposed metal partially hidden beneath moss and dirt.
At first glance it appeared insignificant.
Then Aryan saw it.
A faded marking.
Barely visible.
Almost erased by time.
He stepped closer.
The marking consisted of only four characters.
FP-07
Silence.
The cold mountain wind swept through the clearing.
Nobody spoke.
Rudra stared at the code.
Then slowly looked toward Aryan.
The expression on his face said everything.
FP.
Two simple letters.
Yet after the events of the last forty-eight hours, they carried dangerous implications.
"Tell me that doesn't mean what I think it means," Rudra said quietly.
Aryan continued staring at the marking.
The logical part of his mind immediately rejected the conclusion.
FP could mean anything.
Facility Point.
Forward Position.
Field Post.
Hundreds of possibilities existed.
Yet another part of him refused to dismiss it.
Because coincidences were becoming increasingly difficult to believe.
First the recovered Falcon file.
Then the carved symbol.
Then the transmission.
And now this.
FP-07.
Too many pieces were beginning to point in the same direction.
"I can't confirm anything," Aryan finally said.
Rudra exhaled slowly.
"That's not the answer I wanted."
"It wasn't meant to be."
The team resumed their inspection.
A direct breach was immediately ruled out.
Explosives would certainly open the door.
They would also alert anyone inside.
Assuming someone was inside.

And if the structure contained intelligence, a careless breach could destroy valuable evidence.

Aryan wasn't willing to take that risk.

Not yet.

The team spread out around the entrance.

Thermal scans.

Structural analysis.

Electronic sweeps.

Every possible method was used.

The results only deepened the mystery.

No active security systems.

No visible cameras.

No detectable power source.

Nothing.

The facility appeared dormant.

Almost dead.

Almost.

An hour passed.

The sky remained dark.

The temperature continued dropping.

Finally, one of the operators called out.

"Commander."

Aryan crossed the clearing.

The operator pointed toward a section of rock partially concealed behind overgrown vegetation.

At first glance it appeared natural.

Then Aryan noticed a straight line.

Nature rarely created straight lines.

He knelt and cleared away several layers of dirt and moss.

Metal emerged beneath.

A concealed panel.

Rudra immediately crouched beside him.

"Please tell me that's a keypad."

"It isn't."

The panel swung open with surprising ease.

Inside sat a mechanical control system.

Old.

Extremely old.

Yet remarkably well preserved.

Several levers.

A pressure wheel.

Emergency locking controls.

No electronics.

No digital interface.

Purely mechanical.

Which explained why surveillance equipment had failed to detect it.

Whoever designed the facility knew exactly what they were doing.

Aryan studied the mechanism carefully.

Military engineering.

Without question.

The craftsmanship was too precise.

The design too deliberate.

This wasn't the work of militants hiding in the mountains.

This was the work of professionals.

The uncomfortable thought returned.

If militants hadn't built it—
Who had?
Rudra broke the silence.
"You thinking government?"
Aryan didn't answer immediately.
Because the answer frightened him.
Eventually he shook his head.
"No."
Rudra frowned.
"No?"
"This is beyond a standard government installation."
The operator standing nearby looked confused.
"What does that mean?"
Aryan's eyes remained fixed on the mechanism.
"It means whoever built this expected secrecy to last longer than their own existence."
Nobody spoke after that.
Because nobody knew how to respond.
The statement sounded less like an observation and more like a warning.
Aryan placed his hand on the primary control wheel.
Years of dust shifted beneath his glove.
For a brief moment, the mountain seemed to hold its breath.
Then he turned the wheel.
Nothing happened.
At first.
A low metallic sound echoed from somewhere deep within the structure.
Ancient gears groaned.
Locks disengaged.
Heavy mechanisms awakened after years of silence.
The entire mountainside seemed to vibrate.
Every member of Alpha Team instinctively raised their weapon.
The sound grew louder.
Deeper.
Closer.
Then the massive steel door began moving.
Slowly.
Reluctantly.
As if the mountain itself resisted revealing what lay beyond.
Darkness greeted them.
Not the darkness of night.
Something deeper.
A darkness untouched by sunlight for years.
Cold air escaped from the opening.
Stale.
Motionless.
Ancient.
Aryan stared into the void beyond the entrance.
Every instinct he possessed warned him to proceed carefully.
Because whatever waited inside—
It had remained hidden for a very long time.
And secrets buried that deeply were rarely harmless.
The door finally stopped moving.
The opening was large enough for the entire team to enter.
Yet none of them moved.

Not immediately.

Because far inside the darkness, beyond the reach of their night vision, something faintly reflected the light from their optics.

A small metallic glimmer.

Barely visible.

Almost impossible to notice.

Almost.

Aryan's eyes narrowed.

The reflection hadn't appeared naturally.

Something was there.

Waiting.

And for the first time since arriving at the facility, he had the unsettling feeling that opening the door might have been exactly what someone wanted them to do.

Chapter 4

The Door Beneath The Mountain

Part II

Nobody entered immediately.

Years of training prevented that mistake.

The moment the steel door finished opening, Alpha Team established a defensive perimeter around the entrance.

Weapons remained raised. Thermal optics swept every visible angle. Two operators shifted to elevated positions while another deployed a portable surveillance drone.

The drone disappeared into the darkness beyond the doorway.

Everyone waited.

The feed appeared on Aryan's wrist display.

A narrow corridor.

Concrete walls.

Dust.

No movement.

The drone advanced deeper.

Still nothing.

No heat signatures.

No active electronics.

No signs of human presence.

The facility appeared dead.

Yet Aryan trusted appearances less than ever.

"Clear?" Rudra asked.

Aryan continued watching the drone feed.

"No."

Rudra sighed.

"I had a feeling you'd say that."

The drone traveled another fifty meters before entering a larger chamber.

Rows of metal shelves emerged from the darkness. Several storage containers lay scattered across the room. Most had rusted with age.

Then the signal suddenly flickered.

Once.

Twice.

And disappeared.

Static consumed the display.

The drone feed was gone.

The operators exchanged looks.

"Technical malfunction?"

One of them checked the control unit.

"No."

"Battery failure?"

"No."

The operator frowned.

"The drone is still transmitting."

Aryan looked up.

"Then why can't we see it?"

Nobody had an answer.

The signal should have remained stable.
Instead it had simply vanished.
As though something inside the facility had swallowed it.
For several seconds, the silence returned.
Then Aryan made a decision.
"We move."
Nobody objected.
The team activated weapon-mounted lights and advanced toward the entrance.
The temperature dropped immediately.
The difference was noticeable.
Outside, the mountain air had been cold.
Inside, the facility felt frozen.
As if sunlight had never touched these walls.
The corridor stretched ahead in complete silence.
Concrete reinforced with steel.
Military construction.
Professional.
Expensive.
The deeper they moved, the more obvious it became.
This wasn't a hideout.
This wasn't a bunker built by militants.
Someone had invested enormous resources into creating this place.
The question remained the same.
Who?
The corridor eventually opened into the chamber visible on the drone feed.
Aryan's light swept across the room.
Dust covered nearly everything.
Storage crates.
Metal cabinets.
Workstations.
Most had remained untouched for years.
Yet something immediately caught his attention.
There were no cobwebs.
No signs of decay.
No water damage.
No structural deterioration.
The facility was old.
But it had been maintained.
Recently.
Rudra noticed it too.
"This place should be falling apart."
"It isn't."
"Which means?"
Aryan's gaze moved across the room.
"Someone has been here."
The statement settled heavily over the team.
Not someone decades ago.
Someone now.
Someone who knew the facility existed.
Someone who possibly knew Alpha Team was here.
The thought lingered in everyone's mind.
Then one of the operators called out.
"Commander."

Aryan turned.
The operator stood beside a large metal cabinet built into the wall.
The doors hung partially open.
Inside sat dozens of files.
Hundreds, perhaps.
Most covered in dust.
Several labeled with faded military codes.
Rudra approached first.
His flashlight moved across the shelves.
"Either we just got very lucky..."
His voice trailed off.
"Or very unlucky."
Aryan pulled out one of the folders.
The paper inside had yellowed with age.
Official reports.
Deployment records.
Personnel files.
Everything classified.
Everything military.
Yet none of it appeared in any database he had ever accessed.
Which was impossible.
Even highly classified projects left administrative footprints.
These files seemed to exist outside the system entirely.
A hidden archive.
The realization disturbed him more than he expected.
Governments kept secrets.
That was normal.
But hidden archives within hidden facilities?
That belonged to a different category entirely.
His attention shifted toward the far wall.
Something was mounted there.
A symbol.
Faded.
Partially obscured by time.
Aryan moved closer.
The others followed.
The symbol wasn't military.
At least not any military insignia he recognized.
A circle intersected by several geometric lines.
Simple.
Clean.
Deliberate.
Rudra frowned.
"Know it?"
Aryan shook his head.
"No."
That answer alone worried him.
Aryan rarely forgot symbols.
Particularly military ones.
Yet this was completely unfamiliar.
As if it belonged to an organization that officially didn't exist.
The room suddenly felt much smaller.
One of the operators continued searching nearby cabinets.

A few moments later he found something else.

"Commander."

Aryan crossed the room.

The operator held a sealed folder.

Unlike the others, this one appeared preserved.

Protected.

Important.

The cover contained only two words.

PROJECT VEIL

Nobody spoke.

The title meant nothing.

Which somehow made it worse.

Aryan carefully opened the folder.

The first few pages contained technical reports.

Satellite images.

Research documents.

Operational assessments.

Then something slipped free and landed on the floor.

A photograph.

Old.

Black and white.

Aryan bent down and picked it up.

The moment he saw it, his heart stopped.

Not literally.

But close enough.

Rudra stepped beside him.

Then froze.

Neither man spoke.

Because both recognized the faces instantly.

The first was Vikram Sharma.

Aryan's father.

The second was Captain Aditya Rathode.

Rudra's older brother.

Standing beside them were four unidentified officers.

All smiling.

All alive.

All apparently working together.

The photograph had been taken inside a briefing room.

Several maps covered the walls behind them.

Documents lay scattered across a large operations table.

At first glance, it appeared ordinary.

Then Aryan noticed the date.

His grip tightened.

The photograph had been taken three months before Operation Falcon officially began.

Silence consumed the room.

According to every official record in existence, Falcon didn't exist at that time.

The planning phase hadn't started.

The team hadn't formed.

The operation wasn't supposed to be real yet.

And yet the photograph proved otherwise.

Someone had lied.

For years.

About everything.

Rudra's voice emerged quietly.

"What the hell is this?"

Nobody answered.

Because nobody knew.

Aryan slowly turned the photograph over.

Handwritten notes covered the back.

Most had faded beyond recognition.

Except one.

One sentence remained visible beneath years of wear.

The words were written in black ink.

Simple.

Direct.

Terrifying.

Aryan read them once.

Then again.

Certain he had misunderstood.

But the sentence remained unchanged.

FALCON WAS NEVER THE OBJECTIVE.

The room fell silent.

Somewhere deep inside the facility, a metallic sound echoed through the darkness.

A door closing.

Far below them.

And suddenly Aryan realized something that chilled him more than the photograph ever could.

Alpha Team was no longer alone inside the mountain.

Chapter 5

The Ghost In The Mountain

Part I

The metallic sound echoed through the facility for only a few seconds.

Yet it was enough.

Every member of Alpha Team reacted instantly.

Weapons came up.

Lights shifted.

Defensive positions were established without a single spoken command.

The underground chamber that had seemed abandoned moments earlier suddenly felt alive.

Aryan remained motionless.

Listening.

The sound had come from deeper inside the mountain.

Not close.

Not far.

Somewhere beyond the sections they had already explored.

For several seconds, absolute silence followed.

No footsteps.

No voices.

Nothing.

The facility appeared dormant once again.

But the illusion had already been shattered.

Someone was here.

The realization settled heavily across the room.

Rudra slowly lowered the photograph.

His eyes remained fixed on the darkness beyond the chamber.

"You heard that too, right?"

Nobody answered.

Nobody needed to.

The tension in the room said enough.

Aryan carefully folded the photograph and slipped it inside a secure pouch attached to his vest.

Questions could wait.

The mission couldn't.

He looked around the room.

"Status."

One operator checked the surveillance feed.

"No movement on upper approach routes."

Another reviewed thermal readings.

"No heat signatures."

Rudra snorted softly.

"That's becoming my least favorite sentence."

Normally thermal systems detected everything.

Humans.

Animals.

Machines.

Yet since entering the facility they had repeatedly encountered situations that should have produced heat signatures and somehow didn't.

Aryan didn't like it.
The absence of evidence wasn't evidence of absence.
Someone intelligent enough to build this facility would understand surveillance.
And intelligent enemies rarely played fair.
He turned toward the corridor extending deeper underground.
"We move."
The team immediately reorganized.
The archive room was secured.
A digital marker was placed on the location.
Then Alpha Team advanced.
The corridor beyond the archive chamber appeared older than the sections they had already explored.
Concrete walls stretched endlessly into darkness.
Exposed steel pipes ran along the ceiling.
Emergency lights, dead for years, hung motionless overhead.
Every footstep echoed through the passage.
Every sound seemed amplified.
The deeper they moved, the stronger the feeling became.
Someone had been here recently.
The evidence appeared gradually.
A door partially open.
Dust disturbed in unusual patterns.
A maintenance hatch that had clearly been accessed.
Small details.
Easy to miss.
Impossible for Aryan to ignore.
Twenty minutes later, the corridor split into two separate directions.
Aryan halted the team.
One route descended deeper underground.
The other continued horizontally.
Rudra studied the map displayed on his wrist terminal.
"Which one?"
Aryan crouched near the floor.
His light swept across the concrete.
Then he saw it.
A footprint.
Fresh.
Unlike the tracks outside, this one was clear.
Undeniable.
The tread pattern remained sharp.
Almost untouched by dust.
Rudra stepped closer.
The moment he saw it, his expression hardened.
Military boots.
Not civilian.
Not militant.
Military.
Professional.
Someone had passed through recently.
Very recently.
One of the operators checked the print's depth.
"Less than twelve hours."
Silence.
The footprint changed everything.

This was no longer an abandoned facility hiding old secrets.
This was an active location.
Someone still used it.
Someone who knew exactly how to avoid detection.
Aryan followed the trail.
Another print appeared.
Then another.
The path led toward the lower corridor.
Deeper into the mountain.
Without hesitation, Aryan stood.
"We go down."
The team moved immediately.
The air grew colder as they descended.
Their lights revealed more signs of activity.
Not enough to explain.
Just enough to disturb.
An empty water bottle.
A recently opened maintenance panel.
A faint scratch mark on a security door.
Each clue pointed toward the same conclusion.
Someone was moving through the facility.
Someone disciplined.
Someone careful.
After nearly fifteen minutes, the corridor opened into a much larger section.
The architecture changed immediately.
The walls appeared cleaner.
More advanced.
Less industrial.
Aryan stopped.
His light moved slowly across the chamber.
Rows of workstations emerged from the darkness.
Computer terminals.
Communication equipment.
Data consoles.
Most covered in dust.
Most inactive.
Yet one thing immediately stood out.
A faint blue glow.
Near the far side of the room.
Rudra saw it too.
"What the hell?"
The team approached cautiously.
Weapons remained trained on the shadows.
Every corner was checked twice.
Every angle covered.
Finally they reached the source.
A computer monitor.
Active.
The screen emitted a soft blue light into the darkness.
Nobody spoke.
The rest of the facility appeared dead.
Yet somehow this monitor remained operational.
After all these years.

Aryan slowly stepped forward.
The display contained no files.
No security feeds.
No system information.
Only two words.
Large white letters against a black background.

WELCOME BACK

The room became silent.
Rudra stared at the screen.
Then looked toward Aryan.
Neither spoke.
Because both understood the problem immediately.
The message wasn't random.
It wasn't automated.
It was personal.
Someone had expected visitors.
More specifically—
Someone had expected *them*.
One of the operators began scanning the terminal.
"No active network."
"No external connection."
"No recent logins."
Rudra pointed at the screen.
"Then how is this possible?"
Nobody answered.
Because nobody knew.
Aryan studied the message carefully.
The feeling of being watched returned stronger than ever.
Not fear.
Awareness.
The unsettling realization that every step they had taken since entering the mountains might have been anticipated.
The transmission.
The falcon symbol.
The hidden entrance.
The photograph.
Now this.
Each discovery felt less like an investigation and more like instructions left behind by someone guiding them forward.
A low noise suddenly echoed through the chamber.
Not mechanical this time.
Movement.
Real movement.
Somewhere beyond the room.
Every weapon snapped toward the sound.
The noise came again.
Brief.
Fast.
Human.
Aryan's eyes narrowed.
For the first time since entering the facility, he wasn't looking at clues anymore.
He was looking at a target.
And whoever was moving in the darkness had just made their first mistake.
They had let Alpha Team know they weren't alone.

Chapter 5

The Ghost In The Mountain

Part II

The sound came again.

A brief scrape.

Then silence.

Every member of Alpha Team froze.

The movement had originated somewhere beyond the operations room, deeper inside the facility. It was faint, almost imperceptible, but there was no mistaking it.

Someone was there.

Aryan immediately killed the light mounted on his rifle.

The others followed.

Darkness swallowed the room.

Only the pale glow of the monitor remained.

WELCOME BACK

The words seemed almost mocking now.

As if whoever had left the message knew exactly what would happen next.

Aryan raised two fingers.

Split formation.

The team separated instantly.

Three operators moved left.

Two moved right.

Aryan and Rudra advanced through the center.

No one spoke.

No one needed to.

Years of training had transformed communication into instinct.

The corridor beyond the operations room narrowed sharply.

Concrete walls closed around them.

The air felt colder here.

Stale.

Motionless.

As though the mountain itself had sealed away this section from the outside world.

The deeper they moved, the more obvious it became that someone had passed through recently.

Dust was disturbed.

Several footprints crossed the floor.

A maintenance door stood partially open.

Tiny details.

Yet together they painted a clear picture.

The facility wasn't abandoned.

It had never been abandoned.

The realization unsettled Aryan more than he cared to admit.

For seven years he had accepted certain facts.

Operation Falcon had failed.

The investigation had ended.

The people lost during the mission were gone.

Those facts had become part of reality.

But every discovery inside this mountain chipped away at that reality.

Slowly.
Relentlessly.
Ahead, the corridor opened into another chamber.
Larger than the previous one.
Rows of storage containers stretched into darkness.
Most appeared untouched.
Some had been opened.
Aryan scanned the room carefully.
Still no heat signatures.
Still no visual contact.
Yet the feeling remained.
Someone was watching.
Rudra moved beside him.
"Either this guy is a ghost..."
His voice remained barely above a whisper.
"...or he's enjoying this."
Aryan didn't answer.
Because he suspected the second possibility was closer to the truth.
A sudden metallic clang echoed somewhere ahead.
This time it was louder.
Closer.
The entire team reacted instantly.
Movement.
Fast.
Human.
A dark figure appeared briefly at the far end of the chamber.
Then vanished behind a row of containers.
"Contact!" one of the operators whispered.
Aryan was already moving.
The chase began immediately.
The figure knew the facility.
That much became obvious within seconds.
Every turn was precise.
Every movement efficient.
No hesitation.
No uncertainty.
Whoever they were, they had navigated these corridors before.
Aryan accelerated.
The distance between them remained frustratingly constant.
Not increasing.
Not decreasing.
Almost as if the figure wanted to stay visible.
Wanted them to follow.
The thought irritated him.
Nobody led Alpha Team anywhere.
The corridor suddenly split.
The figure disappeared around the right side.
Aryan followed without hesitation.
His boots hammered against the concrete floor.
The sound echoed endlessly through the mountain.
Ahead, a heavy security door stood open.
The figure passed through it.
Aryan followed.

Then stopped.
The room beyond was empty.
Completely empty.
No exits.
No windows.
No visible escape route.
Nothing.
The team entered moments later.
Weapons raised.
Confusion spread immediately.
"Where did he go?"
No one knew.
The room measured barely twenty feet across.
There was nowhere to hide.
Yet the figure had vanished.
Rudra checked every corner.
Every wall.
Every shadow.
Nothing.
Then Aryan noticed something.
A faint draft.
Cold air.
Almost impossible to feel.
He turned slowly.
His eyes settled on a section of wall near the rear of the chamber.
At first glance it appeared identical to every other surface.
Then he saw the difference.
A barely visible seam.
Hidden.
Deliberate.
A concealed passage.
Before anyone could react, a mechanical sound echoed from behind the wall.
The hidden passage was closing.
Fast.
Aryan lunged forward.
Too late.
The mechanism sealed shut with a heavy metallic thud.
Silence returned.
Rudra stared at the wall.
"You've got to be kidding me."
One of the operators immediately began searching for an access mechanism.
Nothing.
No controls.
No visible panel.
No obvious way through.
The person had escaped.
Again.
But not before leaving something behind.
A small object rested on the floor near the wall.
Aryan picked it up.
A patch.
Black fabric.
Worn from years of use.

Everyone recognized the symbol immediately.
A falcon.
The exact same design they had seen carved into the tree outside.
The exact same design recovered from the Falcon file.
The room grew silent.
The implications were obvious.
Whoever had just escaped wasn't connected to Falcon by coincidence.
They were connected directly.
Rudra's expression darkened.
"He's leading us somewhere."
Aryan nodded slowly.
For the first time since entering the facility, he was certain of one thing.
The mysterious figure wasn't trying to kill them.
At least not yet.
He wanted them to keep moving.
Wanted them to keep discovering things.
Wanted them to follow the trail.
The question was why.
One of the operators suddenly called out from the opposite side of the room.
"Commander."
Aryan crossed the chamber.
A small locker stood partially hidden behind old equipment.
The lock had already been broken.
Inside were several folders.
Most empty.
Most damaged.
Except one.
The folder appeared newer than everything else around it.
Almost untouched.
Aryan opened it carefully.
The first page contained a personnel record.
His eyes moved across the document.
Then stopped.
For a moment he genuinely thought he had misread the name.
He looked again.
The words remained unchanged.

DR. ADITI SHARMA

The room seemed to shrink around him.
Rudra stepped closer.
"What is it?"
Aryan didn't answer immediately.
His pulse remained steady.
His expression unreadable.
But inside, something had frozen.
Because according to every official record in existence—
According to every report he had ever read—
According to everything he had believed for the last seven years—
Dr. Aditi Sharma was dead.
She had died during Operation Falcon.
The file in his hands disagreed.
And as Aryan turned the page, a recent photograph slipped from between the documents and landed on the floor.
The photograph had been taken less than six months ago.
The woman in the image was older.

Tired.

But unmistakable.

Aryan stared at the face.

Unable to look away.

Because the woman smiling faintly at the camera was his mother.

And she was very much alive.

Chapter 6

The Living Dead

Part I

For a long moment, nobody spoke.

The underground chamber seemed to fall into complete silence as the photograph rested in Aryan's hands.

The woman in the picture stood in front of an unfamiliar building. Her hair was slightly shorter than he remembered. A few strands of grey had appeared near her temples. Time had left its mark, but there was no doubt.

It was her.

Dr. Aditi Sharma.

His mother.

Alive.

Aryan stared at the image without blinking.

Seven years.

Seven years of believing she was dead.

Seven years of accepting a reality he had never truly questioned.

Seven years of carrying grief that had shaped nearly every decision he had made.

And now a single photograph threatened to destroy all of it.

Rudra quietly took the file from his hands.

Normally he would have hesitated.

Not this time.

Because even he understood that Aryan wasn't actually seeing the photograph anymore.

He was seeing memories.

A woman helping him with school projects late at night.

A woman reading medical journals at the dining table.

A woman smiling every time he returned home covered in dirt after getting into another fight.

A woman whose funeral had never happened because there had never been a body to bury.

Only a report.

A government report.

One that stated she had died during Operation Falcon.

The same report Aryan had read countless times over the years.

The same report he had eventually accepted as truth.

Now it looked like a lie.

Rudra carefully examined the photograph.

The date printed in the lower corner immediately caught his attention.

Six months old.

His expression darkened.

"Damn."

The word escaped before he could stop it.

One of the operators looked up.

"What is it?"

Rudra handed over the photograph.

The reaction was immediate.

Confusion.

Disbelief.

Shock.

Every member of Alpha Team understood what they were looking at.

Because all of them knew the official story.

All of them knew the casualties of Operation Falcon.

Or at least they thought they did.

Aryan remained silent.

His eyes fixed on the personnel file now lying open on the table.

Logic demanded caution.

Photographs could be manipulated.

Documents could be forged.

Evidence could be planted.

He knew that better than anyone.

And yet...

Something about this felt real.

Too real.

Slowly, he picked up the file again.

His attention moved across the contents.

Most sections had been heavily redacted.

Entire paragraphs were blacked out.

Names removed.

Locations erased.

Operational details hidden.

Whoever created the document had gone to extraordinary lengths to conceal information.

Yet several details remained visible.

NAME: Dr. Aditi Sharma

STATUS: Active

CLEARANCE LEVEL: OMEGA

Aryan's eyes narrowed.

Omega.

He had spent years operating within some of the highest security classifications available to military intelligence.

He had never encountered Omega.

Not once.

Which meant one of two things.

Either the clearance level belonged to a program so secret that even he had never been allowed access.

Or it officially didn't exist.

Neither possibility was reassuring.

Rudra leaned against a nearby workstation.

"You've heard of Omega?"

"No."

That answer immediately drew attention.

One of the operators looked surprised.

"You've never heard of it?"

Aryan slowly shook his head.

The room became quiet again.

Because everyone understood what that meant.

If Aryan Sharma didn't know something related to military operations, chances were very few people did.

He continued reading.

Most of the remaining information had been removed.

Dates.

Locations.

Project references.

Operational designations.

Everything hidden.

Then he found the only surviving line beneath a block of redacted text.

His eyes stopped.

The sentence was short.

Only a few words.

Yet it raised more questions than every other discovery combined.

Asset Transferred After Phase One.

Silence.

Rudra immediately noticed the change in Aryan's expression.

"What is it?"

Aryan turned the file toward him.

Rudra read the line.

Then frowned.

"Phase One?"

Nobody in the room recognized the term.

There was no explanation.

No project reference.

No context.

Just two words.

Phase One.

The problem was obvious.

If there had been a Phase One...

Then there could also be a Phase Two.

And possibly much more.

Aryan slowly closed the file.

A thought had begun forming in the back of his mind.

A possibility he didn't like.

Operation Falcon had always been presented as a military mission.

A failed operation.

A tragic incident.

An unfortunate loss.

Simple.

Straightforward.

Understandable.

But nothing they had discovered inside the mountain felt simple.

Nothing felt straightforward.

The hidden facility.

The classified archive.

The unknown organization.

The mysterious observer.

The photograph.

The personnel file.

Every answer led deeper into the darkness.

Almost as if Falcon had merely been a small piece of something much larger.

The thought lingered.

Growing heavier with every passing second.

One of the operators suddenly called out from the far side of the room.

"Commander."

Aryan turned.

The operator stood beside another storage cabinet partially concealed behind damaged equipment.

Unlike the previous lockers, this one appeared secured.

Recently secured.

The lock showed almost no signs of age.

Which immediately attracted Aryan's attention.

He crossed the room.

The others followed.

The cabinet door had been forced open years earlier, but someone had attempted to repair it afterward.

An unusual detail.
Most abandoned facilities weren't maintained.
This one clearly was.
The operator reached inside and removed a small metal case.
No markings.
No labels.
No identification numbers.
Just a plain black container.
Rudra accepted it carefully.
"Another mystery."
"Open it."

The latch released with a sharp click.
Inside rested a single object.
A data drive.
Old.
Military issue.
The type used nearly a decade earlier.
Dust covered most of its surface.
Yet one detail immediately stood out.
A handwritten label.
Faded but still readable.
Aryan felt his pulse quicken.
Because he recognized the handwriting instantly.
He had seen it hundreds of times growing up.
On birthday cards.
School notes.
Medical journals.
Personal letters.
The handwriting belonged to only one person.
Vikram Sharma.
His father.
The label contained four words.

FOR ARYAN — IF FOUND

Nobody spoke.
The room seemed to grow smaller around him.
Slowly, Aryan picked up the drive.
Seven years ago, he had lost both his parents.
Now, within the span of a few hours, he had discovered evidence suggesting one might be alive.
And the other had apparently left him a message.
Somewhere deep inside the mountain, the mystery they had been chasing was beginning to take shape.
And for the first time since Operation Falcon entered his life, Aryan had the unsettling feeling that he wasn't uncovering a secret.
He was uncovering a plan.
A plan that had been waiting seven years for him to find it.

Chapter 6

The Living Dead

Part II

For several moments, nobody moved.

The data drive rested in Aryan's palm like a relic from another lifetime.

The faded handwriting on its label felt more unsettling than anything else they had discovered inside the facility.

Because unlike photographs or documents, handwriting was personal.

It carried familiarity.

Memory.

Identity.

Aryan knew those four words had been written by his father.

There wasn't a single doubt in his mind.

Rudra watched him carefully.

Most people would have been overwhelmed by now.

A hidden facility.

A dead mother who might be alive.

A classified conspiracy.

A message from a father believed dead for seven years.

Yet Aryan's face remained unreadable.

Calm.

Controlled.

Disciplined.

Only those who knew him well could see the truth.

His silence had become dangerous.

"Let's see what's on it," Rudra finally said.

Aryan nodded.

One of the operators immediately connected a portable decryption module to the nearest workstation.

The facility's systems remained inactive, forcing Alpha Team to rely entirely on their own equipment.

The drive clicked into place.

A loading screen appeared.

For several seconds nothing happened.

Then the display changed.

The drive contained only a single file.

No folders.

No reports.

No archives.

Just one encrypted video.

The timestamp appeared beneath it.

7 Years, 3 Months Earlier.

The room fell silent again.

Aryan stared at the screen.

This recording had been created shortly before Operation Falcon.

Before the deaths.

Before the investigations.

Before everything changed.

The operator initiated playback.

Static filled the monitor.

White noise crackled through the speakers.
The image flickered repeatedly.
Then stabilized.
A man appeared on the screen.
The effect was immediate.
Aryan froze.
Rudra lowered his head slightly.
Nobody spoke.
Because everyone recognized him.
Vikram Sharma.
Older than Aryan remembered.
More exhausted.
Dark circles rested beneath his eyes.
His uniform appeared wrinkled.
His beard slightly unkempt.
He looked like a man who hadn't slept properly in weeks.
Yet his gaze remained sharp.
Focused.
Determined.
The recording seemed to have been made inside a secure office.
Maps covered the walls behind him.
Documents were scattered across a table.
A red warning light blinked somewhere outside the camera frame.
The atmosphere felt tense.
Urgent.
As if time was running out.
For several seconds Vikram simply stared into the camera.
Then he spoke.
"If you're watching this..."
His voice echoed through the room.
Aryan hadn't heard it in seven years.
The sound alone hit harder than he expected.
"...then Falcon has already failed."
Nobody moved.
The words settled heavily over the chamber.
Falcon has already failed.
Not might fail.
Not could fail.
Had failed.
As if he already knew what was coming.
The recording continued.
"And if this message reached you..."
Vikram glanced briefly toward something beyond the camera.
"...then they found the facility."
Aryan's eyes narrowed immediately.
They.
The same word appeared again.
The mysterious enemy.
The hidden organization.
The unknown observers.
Everyone seemed to reference them.
Yet nobody explained who they were.
Rudra folded his arms.

"Who are 'they'?"

The screen offered no answer.

Vikram continued speaking.

His expression had become noticeably more serious.

"If things have reached this point, then there are truths you deserve to know."

The room became completely silent.

Even the operators stopped moving.

Everyone focused on the screen.

Waiting.

Years of unanswered questions suddenly felt within reach.

Vikram inhaled slowly.

Then delivered the sentence that shattered whatever remained of the official story.

"Everything you know about Operation Falcon..."

A brief burst of static interrupted the recording.

The image distorted.

Then recovered.

"...is a lie."

Nobody spoke.

Nobody even breathed.

The words echoed through the chamber long after he finished speaking.

Everything you know is a lie.

Aryan felt the weight of every report he had ever read.

Every investigation.

Every official explanation.

Every conclusion.

If Vikram Sharma was telling the truth, then seven years of history had just become meaningless.

The recording continued.

"Falcon was never the mission."

Rudra's head snapped upward.

The exact same sentence from the photograph.

Only now it was coming directly from the man who had supposedly died during the operation.

"There were larger objectives involved. Objectives that never appeared in official files."

Another burst of static crossed the screen.

The image flickered.

Vikram looked frustrated.

As if he knew time was running out.

"Aryan, listen carefully."

For the first time, he addressed him directly.

The room suddenly felt much smaller.

"If you're seeing this, then you've already discovered enough to become a target."

The words sent a chill through everyone present.

Because every event of the last forty-eight hours suggested he was right.

The hidden facility.

The unknown watcher.

The intercepted transmission.

The mysterious figure.

Someone clearly wanted control over what remained hidden.

Vikram leaned closer toward the camera.

"Aditi—"

The recording abruptly glitched.

The image shattered into static.

Then returned.

Only for a second.

But it was enough.
Aryan heard his mother's name.
Nothing more.
The screen stabilized again.
Vikram's expression had changed.
For the first time, genuine fear appeared in his eyes.
"Aryan..."
The warning in his voice was unmistakable.
"Whatever happens..."
A loud metallic sound suddenly echoed somewhere deep inside the facility.
The room froze.
Not from the recording.
From the mountain itself.
A second later every light in the chamber exploded to life.
Brilliant white illumination flooded the room.
Alpha Team instinctively raised their weapons.
"What the hell—"

Before anyone could finish speaking, alarms erupted throughout the underground complex.
Red emergency lights activated across the ceiling.
Ancient systems awakened after years of silence.
Doors slammed shut in distant corridors.
Heavy mechanisms rumbled through the mountain.
The entire facility seemed to come alive around them.
The recording continued playing amid the chaos.
Vikram's face distorted beneath flashing red lights.
His final words struggled against the interference.
"Aryan... don't trust—"

The screen went black.
Complete silence.
Then a cold mechanical voice echoed through hidden speakers across the facility.
"Unauthorized access detected."
The announcement reverberated through every corridor.
Every chamber.
Every wall.
Alpha Team immediately shifted into combat formation.
Weapons swept across every angle.
The voice continued.
"Containment Protocol Initiated."
Somewhere far below them, massive doors began closing.
The mountain shook.
Dust fell from the ceiling.
Emergency sirens screamed through the darkness.
Then came another sound.
A single gunshot.
Sharp.
Distant.
Yet unmistakably real.
The entire team froze.
Because the shot hadn't come from outside the facility.
It had come from somewhere deeper inside the mountain.
And for the first time since entering the bunker, Aryan realized a terrifying possibility. Whoever had been watching them all night—
Might no longer be alone.

Chapter 6

The Living Dead

Part III

The gunshot echoed through the facility like a thunderclap.

For a fraction of a second, nobody moved.

Then training took over.

Alpha Team immediately spread out across the chamber. Weapons came up. Sectors were assigned. Every entrance, every shadow, every possible threat vector was covered.

The emergency alarms continued screaming through the mountain.

Red warning lights flashed rhythmically across the walls.

The facility no longer looked abandoned.

It looked awake.

Dangerously awake.

Aryan's eyes remained fixed on the black monitor.

The recording was gone.

Seven years of answers had been seconds away.

And now they had vanished.

His father's final warning echoed inside his mind.

Don't trust—

Don't trust who?

The government?

The military?

Alpha Team?

Someone else entirely?

The unfinished sentence felt more dangerous than any complete answer.

A nearby terminal suddenly flickered to life.

Then another.

And another.

Across the operations room, dead computer systems began rebooting one by one.

Ancient monitors illuminated the darkness.

Lines of code scrolled across screens.

Data archives unlocked.

Security systems activated.

It was as though the entire facility had been waiting for someone to arrive.

Waiting for them.

"Commander."

Aryan turned.

One of the operators was monitoring a portable scanner.

His expression had changed.

"What is it?"

The operator swallowed.

"We've got movement."

The room instantly grew silent.

"Location?"

"Multiple locations."

The scanner displayed a rough layout of nearby corridors.

Several red markers appeared.

Then another.
Then another.
And another.
Nobody liked what they were seeing.
"How many?" Rudra asked.
The operator checked again.
"Unknown."
Not the answer anyone wanted.
The markers weren't behaving like a normal patrol pattern.
They appeared.
Disappeared.
Reappeared elsewhere.
Almost as if whoever was moving through the facility knew exactly how to avoid surveillance.
Aryan stared at the display.
Something about it felt familiar.
Then he realized why.
The movement pattern resembled the thermal anomalies from the valley.
Scattered.
Controlled.
Deliberate.
The same invisible hand seemed to be guiding everything.
A loud metallic boom echoed somewhere below.
The entire floor trembled.
Dust rained from the ceiling.
The mechanical voice returned.
"Containment Zone Three Sealed."
Another distant impact followed.
"Containment Zone Four Sealed."
Rudra frowned.
"I don't think those doors are closing to keep us out."
Aryan nodded.
"They're closing to keep something in."
Nobody spoke after that.
Because everyone had reached the same conclusion.
Containment protocols weren't designed for intruders.
They were designed for threats.
And somewhere inside this mountain, a threat apparently existed.
One of the operators approached a nearby terminal.
The screen displayed a facility map.
Most sections remained inaccessible.
Large portions were blacked out.
Yet one location remained highlighted.
A blinking red marker deep beneath the mountain.
Aryan immediately noticed it.
"So did I," Rudra muttered.
The highlighted sector carried a simple designation.
LEVEL OMEGA
The room fell silent.
Omega.
The same clearance level mentioned in Aditi Sharma's personnel file.
Aryan's gaze hardened.
That wasn't a coincidence.
Nothing inside this facility felt like coincidence anymore.

A warning suddenly appeared across the monitor.

LIFE SUPPORT ACTIVE

Then another.

BIOSECURITY STATUS: STABLE

Rudra slowly looked up.

"Life support?"

The implication was obvious.

Life support systems served a purpose.

Something alive required them.

Something alive was still operating somewhere inside the facility.

A cold feeling settled across the room.

The facility wasn't preserving old secrets.

It was preserving something current.

Something important.

A burst of static erupted through the speakers.

For a moment everyone expected another automated announcement.

Instead, a voice emerged.

Human.

Distorted.

Male.

The exact same voice that had contacted Aryan in the valley.

Silence immediately consumed the room.

The voice spoke calmly.

Almost conversationally.

"You're moving faster than expected, Commander."

Every weapon instinctively turned toward the nearest speaker.

The voice laughed softly.

Not mockingly.

Almost respectfully.

"I suppose I should have expected that."

Aryan stepped forward.

"Who are you?"

Several seconds passed.

Then came the reply.

"The wrong question."

The voice sounded closer now.

More personal.

"You should be asking why you're here."

Aryan's expression remained unchanged.

"We're already doing that."

Another brief laugh echoed through the room.

"Not yet."

The speaker crackled.

For a moment it sounded as if the transmission might end.

Then the voice returned.

This time carrying something different.

Something almost resembling sympathy.

"Your father figured it out too late."

Silence.

Nobody moved.

Nobody breathed.

The voice continued.

"So did your brother, Rudra."

The room froze.
Rudra's eyes widened.
His brother.
The man officially killed during Operation Falcon.
The voice knew about him.
Which meant the speaker wasn't guessing.
He knew exactly who they were.
Exactly why they had come.
Exactly what they had discovered.
And perhaps worst of all—
Exactly what they would discover next.
The transmission crackled again.
"A word of advice, Commander."
Aryan remained silent.
The voice lowered.
Almost becoming a whisper.
"Leave the mountain."
The warning hung in the air.
Then came the final sentence.
The sentence that changed everything.
"Because if you reach Omega..."
A pause followed.
Long enough for dread to settle across every person in the room.
"...you'll wish your mother had stayed dead."
The transmission ended.
Complete silence followed.
No alarms.
No movement.
No static.
Nothing.
Only the flashing red lights.
Only the mountain.
Only the impossible statement that continued echoing inside Aryan's mind.
For several seconds nobody spoke.
Then the facility map suddenly updated.
A previously hidden section unlocked itself.
New corridors appeared.
New chambers.
New routes.
And for the first time, a path revealed itself.
A path leading directly toward Level Omega.
Aryan stared at the blinking route.
His expression unreadable.
His decision already made.
Because after everything they had discovered, there was no turning back.
Not now.
Not when the truth was finally within reach.
Not when someone had just used his mother as a warning.
Without saying a word, he picked up his rifle and started walking toward the newly revealed corridor.
Behind him, Alpha Team followed.
And somewhere far below the mountain, beyond layers of steel and concrete, a hidden door slowly began to open.

Chapter 7

Level Omega

Part I

The newly revealed corridor descended deeper into the mountain.

No one spoke as Alpha Team advanced.

The flashing red emergency lights painted the walls in shifting shadows, transforming the passageway into something that felt less like a military installation and more like the inside of a living organism.

Every few seconds, another warning echoed through the facility.

"Containment Protocol Active."

"Restricted Access In Effect."

"Omega Sector Locked."

The automated announcements repeated endlessly.

Yet despite the warnings, the route ahead remained open.

As if the facility itself wanted them to continue.

Aryan noticed it immediately.

The architecture was changing.

The upper levels had looked old.

Abandoned.

Forgotten.

Dust covered every surface.

Equipment had rusted.

Records had aged.

But the deeper they descended, the newer everything appeared.

The concrete walls gradually disappeared.

Reinforced steel replaced them.

Advanced security doors appeared at regular intervals.

Digital control panels lined the corridors.

Motion sensors blinked quietly overhead.

Nothing here looked seven years old.

It looked operational.

Maintained.

Alive.

Rudra noticed the same thing.

"This section shouldn't exist."

Aryan glanced at him.

"Why?"

"Because if this place was abandoned after Falcon..."

Rudra gestured around them.

"...someone forgot to tell the facility."

Nobody disagreed.

The evidence surrounded them.

A ventilation system was running somewhere overhead.

Air circulated through hidden ducts.

Emergency lights functioned perfectly.

Electronic systems responded instantly.

Someone had maintained Omega.

For years.

The realization made the situation far more dangerous.
Because facilities didn't maintain themselves.
People did.
The corridor eventually opened into a massive circular chamber.
Alpha Team halted immediately.
The room was enormous.
At least three stories high.
Rows of servers lined the walls.
Glass observation rooms overlooked the central floor.
Research stations filled the lower levels.
Most surprisingly—
Power still flowed through the facility.
Hundreds of tiny status lights blinked across the darkness.
Green.
Blue.
White.
The chamber resembled a hidden research center frozen in time.
Aryan slowly turned.
His eyes scanned every section.
No movement.
No visible threats.
Yet the feeling of being watched had returned stronger than ever.
One of the operators approached a nearby workstation.
The screen activated instantly.
No password request.
No authentication.
The system simply woke up.
Waiting.
Expecting.
The operator frowned.
"That's weird."
Aryan walked over.
"What is?"
"It already knows we're here."
The statement caused everyone to look up.
The monitor displayed a simple message.
OMEGA ACCESS GRANTED
Nothing else.
No request for identification.
No security verification.
Just acceptance.
As though the facility had already decided who belonged inside.
Rudra didn't like that.
Neither did Aryan.
A facility designed to hide secrets should have resisted them.
Instead it was opening doors.
Providing access.
Guiding them forward.
Almost like the unknown voice.
Almost like the messages.
Almost like everything had been arranged in advance.
Aryan pushed the thought aside.
He needed facts.

Not theories.
His attention shifted toward a large section of the chamber wall.
Dozens of framed photographs covered the surface.
Old photographs.
Official photographs.
Team photographs.
Research photographs.
The kind organizations displayed to preserve history.
He moved closer.
The others followed.
For several moments, nobody spoke.
The photographs revealed the same faces repeatedly.
Scientists.
Military officers.
Researchers.
Engineers.
Different locations.
Different years.
Different teams.
Yet one detail remained constant.
Two individuals appeared in nearly every image.
Vikram Sharma.
Aditi Sharma.
Aryan stared silently.
His father.
His mother.
Not as victims.
Not as casualties.
Not as people trapped in someone else's operation.
They stood at the center of everything.
Every major project photograph included them.
Every leadership meeting featured them.
Every research group seemed connected to them.
The realization struck harder than expected.
His entire life he had believed his parents were participants.
Now it appeared they had been architects.
Rudra stepped closer to one of the photographs.
His expression darkened.
"Look at this."
Aryan followed his gaze.
The image showed a large briefing room.
Several senior officers stood around a digital display.
Among them was Vikram Sharma.
Beside him stood Aditi Sharma.
Both appeared younger.
Confident.
Focused.
Leading.
Not following.
At the bottom of the photograph, a faded caption remained visible.
Most of the text had deteriorated.
Only a few words survived.

PHASE ONE AUTHORIZATION CEREMONY

Silence filled the room.
Phase One.
The same term mentioned in Aditi's file.
The same term nobody understood.
Which meant the project had existed long before Operation Falcon.
Long before the official timeline.
Long before the tragedy.
One of the operators continued searching nearby archives.
A few moments later, he found something else.
"Commander."
Aryan turned.
The operator stood beside a secure database terminal.
The screen displayed thousands of encrypted records.
Most remained inaccessible.
One folder, however, had unlocked automatically.
Its title appeared in bold white letters.
Nobody recognized the designation.
Nobody except Aryan.
Because the moment he saw it, a strange feeling settled inside him.
Not recognition.
Instinct.
The feeling that he had finally reached the center of the maze.
The folder contained only three words.
THE FALCON PROTOCOL
The room fell silent.
For several seconds, nobody moved.
The title seemed almost unreal.
Seven years.
Seven years of investigations.
Seven years of classified reports.
Seven years of lies.
And now the words stood directly before them.
Not Operation Falcon.
Not Mission Falcon.
Not Project Falcon.
The Falcon Protocol.
The actual name.
The real name.
The name someone had worked very hard to erase.
Slowly, Aryan stepped toward the terminal.
His pulse remained steady.
His expression calm.
But deep inside, he understood something important.
Everything that had happened so far—
The hidden facility.
The photographs.
The warnings.
The dead who weren't dead.
The unfinished messages.
All of it had been leading here.
To this folder.
To this name.
To the truth hidden beneath seven years of carefully manufactured lies.

And as Aryan reached toward the terminal, somewhere else inside Omega Sector, a surveillance camera silently rotated toward Alpha Team.

Someone was watching.

And for the first time since entering the mountain, that someone appeared concerned.

Chapter 7

Level Omega

Part II

The words remained on the screen.

THE FALCON PROTOCOL

For several seconds, nobody moved.

Years of mystery.

Years of classified reports.

Years of unanswered questions.

All of it seemed to converge into those three words.

Aryan slowly lowered himself into the chair before the terminal.

The screen illuminated his face.

Around him, the massive Omega Chamber remained silent except for the distant hum of active machinery.

Rudra stood beside him.

"What do you think it is?"

Aryan's eyes remained fixed on the display.

"The truth."

The folder opened.

Thousands of encrypted files immediately appeared across the screen.

Research logs.

Personnel records.

Security archives.

Operational documents.

Scientific reports.

Military assessments.

The sheer volume of information was staggering.

One hidden project had somehow generated enough data to fill an entire intelligence database.

Even more alarming—

Every file carried the same classification.

BEYOND OMEGA

One of the operators whistled softly.

"I've never seen a clearance level above Omega."

Neither had anyone else.

Aryan selected the primary archive.

A loading icon appeared.

The system hesitated.

Then access was granted.

A document opened automatically.

The title alone changed the atmosphere inside the room.

FALCON PROTOCOL — FOUNDING OVERVIEW

Aryan began reading.

The others gathered around.

The first paragraph appeared heavily damaged.

Large sections had been deleted.

Entire pages were missing.

Yet enough survived to reveal something shocking.

Falcon Protocol had never been designed as a military operation.

It had started as a research initiative.
A joint project.
Scientists.
Military strategists.
Intelligence analysts.
All working together.
The objective section had been erased completely.
Only fragments remained.
Words.
Broken sentences.
Disconnected references.
Yet several terms appeared repeatedly.

Threat Assessment.

Containment Measures.

Long-Term Survival.

Phase One.

The room grew silent.
Nothing about the document resembled a counter-terrorism mission.
Nothing resembled a standard military operation.
Rudra folded his arms.
"This isn't what we were told."
"No."
Aryan continued scrolling.
"It isn't."
For seven years, Falcon had been described as a failed operation in hostile territory.
A tragic mission.
A classified disaster.
Yet the original documentation suggested something entirely different.
Operation Falcon appeared to have been merely one chapter.
One event inside a much larger story.
The realization felt disturbing.
Someone had rewritten history.
Deliberately.
Systematically.
One file led to another.
Then another.
Then another.
Every answer created more questions.
Personnel records revealed hundreds of individuals connected to Falcon Protocol.
Scientists.
Military officers.
Researchers.
Intelligence specialists.
Many names had been erased.
Many identities removed.
But two names appeared repeatedly.
Vikram Sharma.
Aditi Sharma.
Again and again.
Leadership meetings.
Research approvals.
Strategic planning sessions.
Final authorizations.

They weren't participants.
They were founders.
The truth hit Aryan harder than he expected.
His parents hadn't died because they were caught in someone else's mission.
They had been responsible for creating it.
One of the operators suddenly spoke.
"Commander."
Aryan looked up.
The operator pointed toward another section of the database.
A hidden archive.
Recently accessed.
Unlike the older files, this section showed activity logs.
Current activity logs.
Aryan immediately noticed the timestamp.
His expression darkened.
The archive had been accessed less than twenty-four hours ago.
Silence.
Nobody needed to explain the implications.
Someone was still using Omega.
Someone had been here recently.
Very recently.
The facility wasn't preserving history.
It was continuing it.
A cold feeling settled across the room.
Rudra stepped closer.
"You seeing this?"
Aryan nodded.
The activity logs contained dozens of entries.
Most had been encrypted.
Several remained visible.
The latest entry carried only a simple designation.
SUBJECT TRANSFER AUTHORIZED
No further details.
No names.
No destination.
Nothing.
Just confirmation that something—or someone—had been moved.
One day ago.
Deep inside the facility.
The mountain suddenly felt smaller.
More dangerous.
More alive.
Aryan opened another archive.
Security footage.
Hundreds of camera feeds appeared.
Most inactive.
Most empty.
Then one screen caught his attention.
A corridor.
Modern.
Operational.
Far deeper than their current location.
The timestamp showed live recording.

The camera was active.
Still functioning.
Everyone stared at the screen.
For several moments, nothing happened.
The corridor remained empty.
Silent.
Motionless.
Then movement appeared.
A figure entered the frame.
Black tactical uniform.
Military posture.
Professional movement.
The person walked calmly through the corridor.
No hesitation.
No urgency.
As if they belonged there.
As if they had spent years inside the facility.
The operators immediately began zooming the image.
The resolution sharpened.
Another figure appeared.
Then another.
Then another.
The room became silent.
This wasn't one person.
It was a team.
Heavily trained.
Heavily equipped.
Moving with precision.
Weapons carried at ready positions.
Communication headsets.
Modern tactical gear.
No insignia.
No identifying marks.
Nothing.
They looked less like intruders and more like owners.
Aryan's eyes narrowed.
Whoever these people were, they clearly understood Omega.
Perhaps better than anyone.
One of the operators quickly checked system records.
"No breach detected."
Rudra frowned.
"What does that mean?"
"It means they didn't break in."
The operator swallowed.
"They were already inside."
The statement landed like a hammer.
Someone had been living inside Omega.
Operating inside Omega.
Maintaining Omega.
All while the rest of the world believed Falcon was dead.
The lead figure suddenly stopped walking.
As if sensing something.
Slowly, he turned his head toward the camera.

Directly toward them.
The room froze.
The camera feed was located hundreds of meters away.
There was no possible way he could know they were watching.
And yet—
The figure seemed to stare directly into the lens.
Directly at Alpha Team.
Then he smiled.
Not a threatening smile.
Not a cruel smile.
Something far worse.
Recognition.
As if he knew exactly who had arrived.
The feed abruptly cut to static.
Every screen in the chamber went dark.
At once.
Silence returned.
The hum of machinery vanished.
The terminal shut down.
Emergency lights flickered.
Then stabilized.
Nobody spoke.
Because everyone felt it.
The atmosphere had changed.
Until now, they had been investigating.
Now someone had acknowledged their presence.
And somewhere beyond the walls of Omega Sector, a group of unknown operators had just learned that Alpha Team had reached the truth.
The hunt was no longer one-sided.
For the first time since entering the mountain—
Something inside Omega was hunting them back.

Chapter 8

The Architects of Falcon

Part I

For several seconds after the monitors went dark, nobody moved.
The silence inside Omega Chamber felt different now.
Heavier.
More dangerous.
The unknown operators had seen them.
That much was certain.
Whether through the surveillance network or some other system, the message was clear.
Alpha Team was no longer investigating a forgotten secret.
They had become part of it.
The emergency lights continued flashing across the chamber.
Red shadows crawled over steel walls and silent workstations.
Aryan remained standing before the dead terminal.
His eyes fixed on the black screen.
The image of the smiling operator lingered in his mind.
Recognition.
Not surprise.
Not curiosity.
Recognition.
Whoever that man was, he had expected Aryan to arrive.
The realization disturbed him more than he cared to admit.
Rudra broke the silence.
"So what now?"
Aryan turned.
"We keep moving."
One of the operators looked toward the inactive servers.
"The database is gone."
"No."
Aryan glanced toward the chamber.
"It's still here."
The facility had been active for years.
No organization maintaining something this large would rely on a single terminal.
There would be backups.
Archives.
Redundant systems.
Professional installations always had them.
The question was where.
The team immediately spread out.
Workstations were searched.
Storage rooms inspected.
Access panels opened.
For nearly twenty minutes, nothing useful emerged.
Most systems had locked themselves down.
Several had wiped temporary access logs.
Others required authorization levels nobody possessed.

Omega was protecting itself.
Then one of the operators called out.
"Commander."
Aryan crossed the chamber.
The operator stood near a section of wall partially concealed behind rows of inactive servers.
At first glance, nothing seemed unusual.
Then Aryan noticed a thin gap running vertically through the steel surface.
A hidden door.
The discovery instantly captured everyone's attention.
Rudra stepped closer.
"Please tell me that's not another secret room."
"It is."
"Fantastic."
The sarcasm earned no response.
A concealed control panel sat beside the door.
Unlike everything else in the facility, it remained active.
A faint blue light glowed beneath the display.
The screen contained only a single message.
ARCHIVE ACCESS AVAILABLE
Aryan exchanged a glance with Rudra.
Again.
The facility was helping them.
Guiding them.
Opening doors.
Providing answers.
Almost as if someone wanted them to reach the truth.
The door slid open with a soft mechanical hiss.
Cold air escaped from the darkness beyond.
Weapon lights immediately activated.
Alpha Team entered cautiously.
The room beyond was smaller than expected.
No laboratories.
No command center.
No advanced technology.
Just shelves.
Hundreds of shelves.
Each filled with storage drives.
Documents.
Encrypted data modules.
Research archives.
Years of accumulated information.
The hidden archive.
The heart of Omega.
For the first time since entering the mountain, genuine excitement appeared among the team.
Not because they had found evidence.
Because they had found history.
Aryan moved toward the nearest terminal.
Unlike the systems outside, this one activated immediately.
No warnings.
No lockdowns.
No resistance.
The screen illuminated.
A list of archived records appeared.

Thousands of entries.
Decades of classified information.
His eyes moved across the database.
Then stopped.
One folder sat at the top.
Highlighted.
Waiting.
As if it had been selected in advance.
The title read:

FOUNDING BRIEFING — FALCON PROTOCOL

Silence filled the archive room.
Nobody needed to discuss it.
This was where they started.
Aryan opened the file.
A loading icon appeared.
Then an old recording materialized on the screen.
The image quality was poor.
The footage clearly predated modern systems.
Static flickered across the display.
A conference room slowly emerged.
Several individuals sat around a large table.
Military officers.
Scientists.
Intelligence personnel.
The atmosphere felt serious.
Tense.
Important.
Then the camera focused on a familiar face.
Vikram Sharma.
Younger.
Confident.
Very much alive.
Beside him sat Aditi Sharma.
Aryan's mother.
The room became silent.
Neither looked like victims.
Neither looked like people trapped in events beyond their control.
They looked like leaders.
Architects.
Founders.
The recording began.
A date appeared briefly in the corner.
Eight years ago.
One year before Operation Falcon.
Rudra immediately noticed it.
"This was before everything."
Aryan nodded.
The implication was obvious.
Whatever Falcon Protocol truly was, it existed long before the mission that supposedly destroyed it.
The recording continued.
Vikram stood and approached a digital display behind him.
Several maps appeared on the screen.
International maps.

Not local.
Not regional.
Global.
That alone surprised everyone.
Then Vikram spoke.
His voice echoed through the archive room.
"The threat facing us cannot be addressed through conventional military operations."
Silence.
Every member of Alpha Team focused on the screen.
Vikram continued.
"For years, intelligence agencies around the world have identified patterns that should not exist."
A new slide appeared behind him.
Financial networks.
Political connections.
Military procurement chains.
Communication routes.
At first glance the information looked unrelated.
Then lines began connecting everything together.
The room slowly darkened as the display expanded.
Countries.
Corporations.
Intelligence assets.
Military contractors.
Political organizations.
The web stretched across continents.
Across governments.
Across entire systems.
Rudra frowned.
"What am I looking at?"
Nobody answered.
Because nobody knew.
Not yet.
On the screen, Vikram continued.
"Most people believe nations control events."
The next slide appeared.
His expression hardened.
"They don't."
The archive room fell silent.
Even the air seemed frozen.
The web of connections expanded again.
Larger.
More complex.
More disturbing.
Thousands of invisible links connected people and organizations that should never have been connected.
Aryan felt an uncomfortable sensation growing in his chest.
Because the structure looked familiar.
Not the names.
The pattern.
The design.
It wasn't chaos.
It was organization.
Someone had built it.
Someone had maintained it.

Someone had hidden it.

Then Vikram spoke the words that changed everything.

"We have identified the existence of a covert international network operating beyond national oversight."

The screen zoomed toward the center of the web.

One symbol appeared.

Simple.

Unknown.

Unmarked.

The same symbol Alpha Team had discovered throughout the facility.

The circle intersected by geometric lines.

A symbol that officially did not exist.

Vikram looked directly into the camera.

His next sentence felt less like a briefing and more like a warning.

"We don't know who created this organization."

A pause followed.

"We don't know how large it is."

Another pause.

"We don't even know its real name."

The room remained silent.

Then the final slide appeared.

Across the screen, a temporary designation materialized in bold white letters.

CODENAME: THE CONSORTIUM

Nobody spoke.

Because for the first time since entering the mountain, Alpha Team finally knew what Falcon Protocol had been created to hunt.

And they were beginning to understand why so many people had died trying to keep it hidden.

Chapter 8

The Architects of Falcon

Part II

Nobody spoke for several seconds after the recording ended.

The archive room seemed smaller now.

More confined.

More dangerous.

For years, Alpha Team had fought enemies they could identify.

Terrorist organizations.

Insurgent groups.

Foreign assets.

Threats with names, faces, and locations.

The Consortium was different.

It wasn't an army.

It wasn't a country.

It wasn't even a single organization.

It was a network.

A hidden structure operating behind governments, corporations, intelligence agencies, and military systems.

And according to Falcon Protocol, it had existed long enough to infiltrate places nobody should have been able to reach.

The implications were terrifying.

Rudra leaned against a nearby console.

"So basically..."

He looked at the frozen image of Vikram Sharma.

"...our parents spent years chasing ghosts."

"No."

Aryan's eyes remained fixed on the screen.

"Ghosts don't leave evidence."

The room fell silent again.

Because the evidence was everywhere.

The facility.

The archives.

The symbols.

The surveillance teams operating inside Omega.

Someone had gone to extraordinary lengths to keep Falcon buried.

That alone proved the threat was real.

One of the operators began accessing additional files.

Hundreds of documents appeared.

Research papers.

Intelligence reports.

Field assessments.

Intercepted communications.

Most were heavily encrypted.

Several had been damaged.

But enough remained intact to reveal fragments of the truth.

A document opened automatically.

The title immediately drew everyone's attention.

INTERNAL THREAT ASSESSMENT

The date was eight years old.
Several names had been removed.
Most locations were blacked out.
Yet one section remained readable.
Aryan scanned the page.
His expression darkened.
"What is it?" Rudra asked.
Instead of answering, Aryan rotated the screen.
The paragraph contained only a few surviving lines.
The Consortium has demonstrated access to classified military networks.
Operational security can no longer be guaranteed.
Internal compromise remains highly probable.
The room became silent.
Everyone understood exactly what those words meant.
Rudra was the first to say it.
"There was a leak."
Nobody disagreed.
The evidence pointed toward only one conclusion.
Falcon hadn't failed because the enemy was stronger.
It hadn't failed because of bad planning.
It hadn't failed because of bad luck.
Someone had compromised it.
Someone on the inside.
A traitor.
The realization sent a chill through the room.
Because an external enemy could be fought.
An internal one was far more dangerous.
Aryan continued reading.
Another paragraph survived.
This one was written by Vikram himself.
The timestamp placed it less than three weeks before Operation Falcon.
His words appeared on the screen exactly as he had written them.
We can no longer trust official channels.
Silence.
The sentence felt heavier than any classified report.
Because Vikram Sharma wasn't a paranoid man.
Every file they had discovered portrayed him as methodical.
Careful.
Rational.
For someone like him to write those words—
The situation must have been catastrophic.
Rudra stared at the document.
"He knew."
Aryan nodded slowly.
"He knew someone was feeding information out."
One of the operators looked concerned.
"Do we know who?"
"No."
Aryan closed the file.
"And that's the problem."
The traitor had never been identified.
Or if they had, the information was hidden.
Either possibility was dangerous.

A new archive appeared on the terminal.
Security review documents.
Investigation reports.
Counterintelligence assessments.
Someone inside Falcon Protocol had clearly spent months trying to identify the leak.
The deeper they searched, the worse the situation appeared.
Several operations had been compromised.
Safehouses exposed.
Assets eliminated.
Information leaked.
Again and again.
Every trail eventually disappeared.
Whoever the mole was, they had been extraordinarily effective.
Almost invisible.
Almost.
One damaged file suddenly caught Aryan's attention.
The title read:

POST-FALCON ANALYSIS

He opened it immediately.
The document loaded slowly.
Years of corruption had destroyed large portions of the file.
Entire sections were unreadable.
Pages were missing.
Names erased.
Yet one conclusion remained intact.
Aryan read it once.
Then again.
To make sure he hadn't misunderstood.
Finally, he spoke.
"Falcon wasn't a failure."
Every head turned toward him.
Rudra frowned.
"What?"

Aryan pointed toward the screen.
"The report doesn't classify Falcon as failed."
The others moved closer.
There it was.
Clear.
Undamaged.
Official.
The final assessment contained only one sentence.

MISSION STATUS: COMPROMISED

The room fell silent.
Compromised.
Not failed.
Compromised.
The difference was enormous.
A failed mission meant objectives weren't achieved.
A compromised mission meant someone had deliberately exposed it.
Rudra slowly exhaled.
"Someone sold them out."
No one argued.
Because there was no other explanation left.

Everything pointed toward betrayal.
The facility.
The deaths.
The cover-up.
The lies.
The hidden archives.
All roads led back to a single event.
Someone inside Falcon Protocol had handed information to the enemy.
And people had died because of it.
A cold feeling settled in Aryan's chest.
For seven years he had blamed circumstances.
Bad intelligence.
Bad luck.
Operational failure.
Now another possibility emerged.
Maybe his parents hadn't died because the mission went wrong.
Maybe someone had arranged for it to go wrong.
The thought lingered.
Dark.
Dangerous.
Unwelcome.
A sudden beep interrupted the silence.
Every operator immediately looked up.
The sound had come from a nearby surveillance terminal.
A screen activated automatically.
Then another.
Then another.
Live camera feeds appeared throughout the archive room.
Dozens of corridors.
Research labs.
Storage sectors.
Security checkpoints.
Omega was revealing itself.
Rudra stepped closer.
"What changed?"
One of the operators checked the system logs.
His expression hardened.
"We've got access."
"To what?"
"Everything."
The room became silent.
Because they all understood what that meant.
For the first time since entering the facility, they could see Omega.
And perhaps more importantly—
Omega could see them.
Across the monitors, corridors stretched endlessly into darkness.
Elevators moved between sectors.
Security systems activated.
Doors opened and closed.
The facility wasn't dead.
It was functioning.
Operating.
Breathing.

Then one of the screens flickered.
A new feed appeared.
Not a corridor.
Not a laboratory.
A secure archive room.
The camera zoomed automatically.
A document lay open across a table.
Someone had been reading it recently.
The title appeared clearly.

FALCON INTERNAL SECURITY REVIEW

Aryan's eyes narrowed.
Without hesitation, he transferred the file to the central terminal.
The download completed instantly.
The document opened.
Hundreds of pages.
Investigations.
Interviews.
Security assessments.
Counterintelligence reports.
The team began scanning through the contents.
Then they reached the final section.
The conclusion.
The part everyone wanted.
The suspected source of the leak.
The suspected traitor.
The room became silent as Aryan scrolled downward.
Most names had been removed.
Most findings redacted.
Then the final page appeared.
Only a single entry remained visible.
The rest had been erased.
A line of text sat alone at the bottom of the report.
Simple.
Cold.
Terrifying.

PRIMARY SUSPECT — REDACTED

Below it sat another line.
A status update.
The timestamp was recent.
Very recent.
Three days old.
Aryan felt his pulse slow.
Because the words beneath it changed everything.

STATUS: STILL ACTIVE

Nobody spoke.
Nobody moved.
The traitor who had destroyed Falcon Protocol—
The person responsible for everything—
Wasn't dead.
Wasn't missing.
Wasn't forgotten.
They were still out there.
And somewhere inside Omega, a hidden camera silently focused on Alpha Team as they read the report.

As if someone was waiting to see how they would react.

Chapter 9

First Contact

Part I

The archive room remained silent.

Too silent.

Aryan stared at the final line displayed on the monitor.

PRIMARY SUSPECT — REDACTED

STATUS: STILL ACTIVE

Three days ago.

Someone had updated the file three days ago.

Not seven years ago.

Not months ago.

Three days.

Which meant someone with access to Falcon Protocol was still operating.

Still watching.

Still protecting the truth.

Or hiding it.

Rudra slowly stepped back from the terminal.

"I don't like this."

Aryan didn't reply.

Because he agreed.

Every instinct developed through years of combat operations was warning him.

Something was wrong.

Not the file.

Not the archive.

The atmosphere.

The facility felt different.

The deeper they had gone into Omega, the more it had felt alive.

Now it felt aware.

As though the mountain itself had noticed their presence.

One of the operators suddenly looked up from a surveillance console.

His expression changed instantly.

"Commander."

Aryan turned.

The operator was staring at one of the live camera feeds.

"What is it?"

The operator enlarged the image.

A corridor appeared.

Empty.

At first.

Then movement entered the frame.

A figure.

Black tactical uniform.

Rifle held low.

Professional posture.

Not running.

Walking.

Calmly.
Purposefully.
The room became silent.
Another figure entered the camera view.
Then another.
Then another.
Within seconds, six armed operators appeared across multiple camera feeds.
Every one of them wore identical gear.
No insignia.
No identification.
No flags.
Nothing.
Just black combat uniforms and advanced tactical equipment.
Rudra's jaw tightened.
"Those aren't militants."
"No."
Aryan's voice remained calm.
"They're professionals."
The difference was obvious.
Militants moved aggressively.
These men moved efficiently.
No wasted motion.
No unnecessary communication.
Every step was controlled.
Every movement disciplined.
Years of training were visible in the way they carried themselves.
One of the operators switched between camera feeds.
The situation immediately became worse.
The unknown team wasn't moving randomly.
They were advancing through Omega using multiple routes.
Covering intersections.
Securing corridors.
Establishing overlapping fields of fire.
Exactly the way Alpha Team would.
The realization settled heavily across the room.
They weren't facing soldiers.
They were facing hunters.
"How many?" Aryan asked.
The surveillance operator checked again.
"Six confirmed."
The answer should have been reassuring.
Instead it wasn't.
Because six highly trained operators inside a confined underground facility could be more dangerous than sixty ordinary soldiers.
Another camera feed activated.
The lead figure appeared briefly.
Tall.
Broad-shouldered.
Helmet.
Face covered.
No identifying features visible.
Yet something about him immediately caught Aryan's attention.
The man moved with unusual confidence.

Not confidence born from skill.
Confidence born from familiarity.
As if he knew every corridor.
Every door.
Every hidden route inside Omega.
Because perhaps he did.
Rudra pointed toward the screen.
"They're coming here."
The room fell silent again.
The tactical routes displayed on the monitor left little room for doubt.
The unknown team was converging.
And their destination appeared to be the archive room.
The same archive room currently occupied by Alpha Team.
A sharp electronic tone suddenly echoed through the facility.
Every monitor flickered.
The mechanical voice returned.
"Security breach detected."
A pause followed.
Then another announcement.
"Archive Sector Compromised."
The room instantly tensed.
Aryan's eyes narrowed.
That message wasn't referring to the unknown operators.
It was referring to Alpha Team.
To Omega, they were the intruders.
Which meant the facility's automated systems might not help them anymore.
The tactical situation had changed completely.
One of the operators checked nearby camera feeds.
His face darkened.
"Commander."
Aryan looked over.
The operator zoomed in on a junction approximately two hundred meters away.
The unknown team had stopped.
All six operators gathered briefly at the intersection.
The lead figure knelt beside a wall-mounted terminal.
Seconds later, something unexpected happened.
The terminal activated.
The man entered a code.
A moment later—
The security door ahead of them opened.
No alarms.
No resistance.
Nothing.
The facility had accepted his authorization.
Silence filled the room.
Nobody needed to explain what that meant.
The unknown operators weren't breaking into Omega.
They belonged here.
Rudra slowly exhaled.
"That's bad."
"No."
Aryan grabbed his rifle.
The metallic click echoed through the archive room.

"That's confirmation."

The others immediately prepared their weapons.

Magazines checked.

Communications verified.

Positions assigned.

The atmosphere shifted instantly.

No more investigation.

No more research.

No more searching through files.

Now it was survival.

One of the operators began downloading archive data onto encrypted drives.

"We need at least ten minutes."

"You have five."

The operator looked up.

"Five isn't enough."

Aryan's expression remained unchanged.

"Then work faster."

Nobody argued.

Because everyone understood the reality.

If the archive fell into enemy hands, years of evidence could disappear forever.

The downloads began immediately.

Progress bars crawled across multiple screens.

8%.

12%.

15%.

Far too slow.

Far too vulnerable.

Meanwhile, the camera feeds continued updating.

The unknown team kept moving.

Closer.

Closer.

Closer.

Every few minutes they appeared on another camera.

Always calm.

Always methodical.

Never rushing.

Never hesitating.

As if they knew exactly how much time remained.

Then something happened that made Aryan's stomach tighten.

The lead operator suddenly stopped.

He turned toward a nearby surveillance camera.

Directly toward it.

Directly toward Alpha Team.

For several seconds, he remained motionless.

Staring into the lens.

Then he slowly raised one hand.

And pointed.

Not at the camera.

Beyond it.

Toward the archive room.

Toward them.

The message couldn't have been clearer.

I know where you are.

The feed abruptly went black.
Then another camera disappeared.
Then another.
One by one, Omega's surveillance network began shutting down.
The unknown team was blinding the facility.
Removing every advantage Alpha Team possessed.
The archive room suddenly felt very exposed.
Very isolated.
Very vulnerable.
Then the lights flickered.
Once.
Twice.
Three times.
The emergency systems struggled.
Power levels dropped.
Several monitors shut off completely.
A low warning tone echoed through the chamber.
And somewhere in the darkness beyond the archive room, a heavy steel door slowly opened.
For the first time since entering Omega, Alpha Team could hear them.
Footsteps.
Measured.
Disciplined.
Getting closer.
The hunt was over.
The first contact was about to begin.

Chapter 9

First Contact

Part II

The footsteps echoed through Omega.

Slow.

Measured.

Deliberate.

Nobody inside the archive room spoke.

They didn't need to.

Every member of Alpha Team understood exactly what those sounds meant.

The enemy was close.

Very close.

One of the operators checked the download progress.

Twenty-two percent.

Far from enough.

Aryan's expression remained calm.

Years of combat had taught him something important.

The moments before a fight were often more dangerous than the fight itself.

Fear lived in uncertainty.

Once bullets started flying, training took over.

He activated his headset.

"Positions."

Immediately the team moved.

Two operators established a defensive position behind server racks.

Another covered the entrance corridor.

Rudra took the left flank.

Aryan positioned himself near the center of the room where he could observe every approach.

The archive suddenly transformed from a research facility into a battlefield.

The footsteps stopped.

Silence returned.

Nobody moved.

Nobody breathed.

Then—

A metallic object rolled through the doorway.

The entire room reacted instantly.

"Flash!"

Everyone turned away.

The grenade detonated.

A blinding white explosion filled the archive.

Even with training, several operators were momentarily affected.

The enemy moved immediately.

Not after.

Not before.

Immediately.

Professional.

A dark figure appeared in the doorway.

Suppressed rifle.

Controlled burst.
Three rounds struck the server rack where an Alpha Team operator had been positioned seconds earlier.
The operator returned fire.
The archive exploded into violence.
Gunfire thundered through the chamber.
Rounds tore into steel shelves.
Glass shattered.
Sparks erupted from damaged electronics.
The first contact had begun.
Aryan leaned around cover.
Three quick shots.
The lead intruder disappeared behind the doorway.
No hit confirmation.
No mistake either.
The man had reacted instantly.
Fast.
Too fast for ordinary soldiers.
Rudra fired toward another position.
The enemy answered immediately.
Short bursts.
Disciplined bursts.
Not a single round wasted.
The exchange lasted only seconds.
Yet Aryan already understood something.
These operators fought exactly like special forces.
Movement.
Communication.
Fire discipline.
Everything was precise.
Everything was calculated.
One of Alpha Team's operators shifted position.
The enemy anticipated it.
A round struck his shoulder.
The operator dropped behind cover with a curse.
Blood immediately appeared across his sleeve.
The room fell silent for half a second.
Then the firefight intensified.
Rudra dragged the wounded operator behind a workstation.
"You good?"
The operator gritted his teeth.
"Still breathing."
"Then keep breathing."
More rounds slammed into the workstation.
Metal bent inward.
Fragments scattered across the floor.
Aryan studied the pattern.
The enemy wasn't trying to overwhelm them.
They were probing.
Testing.
Learning.
Exactly what Alpha Team would have done.
Which made them dangerous.
A nearby server exploded in a shower of sparks.

The archive lights flickered again.
Darkness swallowed half the room.
Emergency lighting activated moments later.
Everything became red.
The entire archive now looked like a scene from a nightmare.
Flashing crimson lights.
Smoke.
Gunfire.
Falling debris.
The download terminal continued running in the background.
Thirty-one percent.
Not enough.
Not even close.
The enemy advanced again.
A second flashbang entered the room.
This time Alpha Team was ready.
The device detonated harmlessly.
Immediately afterward, two hostile operators pushed through the entrance.
Fast.
Aggressive.
Covering each other.
Aryan engaged instantly.
One burst.
The first operator dove sideways.
The second fired back.
Rounds struck the wall inches from Aryan's head.
Concrete exploded.
Dust filled the air.
For a brief moment, visibility disappeared completely.
Then a shadow emerged from the smoke.
Closer than expected.
Much closer.
The hostile operator had crossed nearly half the room.
Aryan reacted immediately.
The enemy fired.
Aryan moved.
The round missed by centimeters.
Then both men collided.
The rifle became useless.
The fight turned physical.
The operator was powerful.
Well-trained.
Every movement precise.
No wasted energy.
No hesitation.
Aryan blocked a strike.
Countered.
Drove an elbow toward the man's ribs.
The enemy absorbed the impact and retaliated instantly.
Neither man gained an advantage.
For several seconds they fought in complete silence.
Pure training.
Pure instinct.

Then Aryan finally created space.
His pistol appeared.
The hostile operator reacted immediately.
A combat knife flashed into his hand.
Both men froze.
Less than two meters apart.
Weapons ready.
Neither blinking.
Neither lowering their guard.
The emergency lights flashed again.
Red.
Dark.
Red.
Dark.
For a brief second, Aryan saw the man's eyes behind the visor.
Calm.
Focused.
Familiar.
Not hatred.
Not anger.
Recognition.
The same expression from the surveillance feed.
The operator slowly tilted his head.
Almost studying him.
Then he spoke.
The voice was low.
Controlled.
And unmistakably confident.
"You're making the same mistake your father made."
The words hit harder than any bullet.
Aryan's eyes narrowed.
"What mistake?"
A faint smile appeared beneath the visor.
The operator took a single step backward.
Not retreating.
Creating distance.
Preparing.
For what?
Aryan didn't know.
Then the lights died completely.
The archive vanished into darkness.
Total darkness.
For two seconds, nobody could see anything.
When emergency power finally returned—
The hostile operator was gone.
Completely gone.
As if he had never been there.
The firefight had stopped.
The enemy team was withdrawing.
Rudra immediately checked the corridor.
"Contact lost!"
Another operator rushed toward the entrance.
"They're falling back!"

Aryan didn't move.
His attention remained fixed on the empty space where the operator had stood.
The same mistake your father made.
The sentence echoed inside his mind.
Not because of what it meant.
Because of how it was said.
The man hadn't sounded like an enemy.
He had sounded like someone issuing a warning.
A sudden alarm interrupted his thoughts.
The download terminal.
One of the operators looked up in horror.
"Commander."
Aryan turned.
Smoke poured from the central archive server.
The enemy hadn't come to kill them.
They had come for the data.
Across the room, flames began spreading through the archive network.
One server.
Then another.
Then another.
Thousands of Falcon Protocol files started disappearing in real time.
The archive was burning.
And unless Alpha Team acted immediately—
Seven years of secrets were about to die forever.

Chapter 9

First Contact

Part III

The archive was dying.

Flames spread across server racks like a living creature.

One after another, decades of classified records vanished into smoke and molten circuitry.

The heat inside the chamber rose rapidly.

Emergency sprinklers attempted to activate.

Nothing happened.

The systems had been disabled.

Deliberately.

Rudra stared at the burning servers.

"Dammit!"

Another explosion erupted somewhere deeper inside the archive.

The floor trembled.

Chunks of concrete crashed from the ceiling.

The entire Omega sector was beginning to collapse.

Aryan immediately understood what was happening.

The enemy hadn't simply sabotaged the archive.

They had initiated a purge.

A complete purge.

Everything connected to Falcon Protocol was being erased.

Seven years of secrets.

Seven years of lies.

Seven years of answers.

Gone.

A warning siren echoed through the facility.

"CRITICAL FAILURE DETECTED."

"STRUCTURAL INTEGRITY COMPROMISED."

"EVACUATE IMMEDIATELY."

The mechanical voice repeated itself again and again.

The message was clear.

Omega was dying.

"Download status?" Aryan shouted.

One of the operators checked.

His face turned pale.

"Forty-eight percent!"

Not enough.

Not even close.

Aryan looked at the burning servers.

Then at the download terminal.

Then at his team.

Decision made.

"Take the drives."

Rudra immediately understood.

"No."

Aryan's gaze never left the flames.

"That's an order."
The room fell silent.
Rudra stepped forward.
"We leave together."
"We don't have time."
Another explosion rocked the chamber.
The lights flickered violently.
A steel support beam crashed across the archive entrance.
The escape route narrowed instantly.
Smoke filled the room.
Visibility dropped.
The situation had changed from dangerous to critical.
Aryan grabbed the primary data drive and shoved it into Rudra's vest.
"Get everyone out."
Rudra didn't move.
For the first time all night, genuine anger appeared in his eyes.
"You really think I'm leaving you here?"
Aryan remained calm.
"Someone has to make sure the transfer completes."
The progress bar continued climbing.
Fifty-two percent.
Fifty-three.
Fifty-four.
Still not enough.
Every second mattered.
The wounded operator coughed violently.
The smoke was getting worse.
Another section of ceiling collapsed.
The mountain groaned around them.
It sounded like a dying beast.
Aryan looked toward the team.
"Move."
Nobody obeyed.
Not immediately.
Because every one of them knew exactly what this felt like.
The classic sacrifice.
The officer staying behind.
The team escaping.
The hero trapped.
Aryan hated those stories.
Because reality was usually uglier.
But right now reality offered no alternatives.
The archive suddenly erupted.
A massive fireball tore through the central server bank.
The shockwave threw everyone backward.
Alarms screamed.
Steel twisted.
Glass exploded.
The entire chamber shook.
Rudra knew the fight was over.
Not the battle.
The argument.
There was no more time.

His jaw clenched.
Then finally—
He nodded.
One sharp nod.
The kind soldiers gave when words stopped being useful.
"Don't die."
Aryan almost smiled.
"Not planning to."
The team began moving.
Fast.
Disciplined.
Dragging the wounded operator.
Carrying the recovered drives.
Retreating through the collapsing corridor.
Rudra remained the last to leave.
For a brief moment, the two friends looked at each other.
No speeches.
No emotional goodbye.
No dramatic promises.
Neither needed them.
Then Rudra disappeared into the smoke.
Aryan was alone.
The download reached sixty percent.
Sixty-one.
Sixty-two.
The archive burned around him.
Flames reflected across the monitor.
The air had become almost impossible to breathe.
Still he stayed.
Still he waited.
Then—
Something beeped.
A different sound.
Not the terminal.
Not the alarms.
Something else.
Aryan's eyes shifted downward.
A small device sat beneath the nearest server rack.
Red light blinking.
Once.
Twice.
Three times.
His expression hardened instantly.
Explosive.
The enemy hadn't simply destroyed the archive.
They had left insurance.
A final charge.
A final erasure.
Aryan lunged toward the terminal.
The progress bar climbed.
Sixty-seven percent.
Sixty-eight.
The blinking accelerated.

There wasn't enough time.
Not for both.
The drive.
Or escape.
One choice.
One second.
Then white light consumed everything.
The explosion ripped through the archive like the wrath of God.
The floor disappeared beneath him.
The ceiling collapsed.
Steel shattered.
Fire erupted in every direction.
For a single instant, Aryan felt himself being thrown backward through smoke and debris.
Then—
Nothing.
No sound.
No pain.
No fire.
No alarms.
Only silence.
Absolute silence.
And far above the collapsing Omega Sector, Alpha Team emerged from the mountain just as a massive section of the facility imploded behind them.
Rudra turned.
The explosion illuminated the night sky.
His heart stopped.
Because Aryan had not emerged with them.
And for the first time since joining Alpha Team...
Nobody knew whether Commander Aryan Sharma was alive or dead.

Chapter 10

The Ghost Chamber

Part I

The mountain burned through the night.

Columns of smoke rose into the dark sky as military helicopters circled overhead. Searchlights cut through the surrounding valleys. Emergency teams moved between command vehicles and temporary medical stations. Radios crackled continuously. Orders were shouted. Reports exchanged hands. Perimeters expanded.

The entire operation zone had transformed into controlled chaos.

And in the center of that chaos stood Rudra Rathode.

His uniform was stained with dust and dried blood.

A bandage covered a cut above his forehead.

His shoulder ached from carrying one of the wounded operators out of Omega.

Yet none of that mattered.

Because his eyes remained fixed on the mountain.

On the place where Aryan had disappeared.

The first rays of dawn slowly appeared over the horizon.

A cold wind swept across the valley.

Still, the rescue operation continued.

For nearly six hours.

Without success.

A senior military officer approached the temporary command post carrying a tablet.

His expression alone told Rudra everything he needed to know.

"No signal?"

The officer shook his head.

"No signal."

Rudra looked away.

The answer wasn't surprising anymore.

Aryan's radio had vanished from military tracking systems the moment Omega collapsed.

No emergency beacon.

No communication.

Nothing.

It was as if the mountain had swallowed him whole.

Nearby, the remaining Alpha Team members sat in silence.

No one talked much.

No one laughed.

No one slept.

The empty space among them felt impossible to ignore.

For years they had followed Aryan into situations most soldiers would never willingly enter.

Cross-border operations.

Hostage rescues.

Counter-terror missions.

Deep-cover assignments.

Every time, he had found a way back.

Every single time.

Until now.

One of the operators stared toward the mountain.

"How much of the facility collapsed?"

The officer checked his tablet.
"Most of the Omega sector."
Silence followed.
Nobody needed further explanation.
Most.
Not all.
Unfortunately, that wasn't reassuring.
Because the sections that remained standing were now buried beneath thousands of tons of rock and steel.
The possibility of survival grew smaller with every passing hour.
A technician suddenly approached the command post.
"Sir."
The officer turned.
"What is it?"
"We finished the satellite assessment."
Everyone immediately paid attention.
The technician placed several images on the table.
Thermal scans.
Structural maps.
Underground analysis.
The mountain's interior looked like a shattered skeleton.
Entire sections had collapsed.
Corridors no longer existed.
Access routes were gone.
Escape tunnels destroyed.
The images painted a grim picture.
Rudra studied them carefully.
Then something caught his attention.
A faint anomaly.
Deep beneath the collapse zone.
Almost invisible.
The technician noticed his expression.
"We saw that too."
Rudra pointed toward the image.
"What is it?"
"We don't know."
The answer wasn't satisfying.
The anomaly appeared far below Omega.
Deeper than any section they had explored.
Almost beyond the original facility map.
One of the analysts shook his head.
"The readings are inconsistent."
"What does that mean?"
"It means whatever is down there shouldn't exist."
The statement immediately captured everyone's attention.
The analyst enlarged the scan.
A rough shape appeared.
Geometric.
Artificial.
Hidden beneath layers of rock.
The structure looked ancient compared to Omega.
Older.
Much older.
Rudra felt a strange sensation settle in his chest.

Because this wasn't the first hidden section they had discovered.
Every time they thought they had reached the center of Falcon Protocol—
Another layer appeared.
Another secret.
Another door.
The analyst folded his arms.
"It could be nothing."
Nobody believed that.
Not anymore.
Not after everything they had found.
A helicopter landed nearby.
The roar of its engines briefly drowned out every other sound in the valley.
Several high-ranking intelligence officers stepped out.
Their arrival immediately changed the atmosphere.
Conversations stopped.
Personnel straightened.
Security tightened.
Rudra watched them approach.
One of the officers carried a sealed black case.
Another held a classified operations file.
Neither looked pleased.
The lead officer stopped in front of the command post.
"Report."
The senior military officer summarized everything quickly.
Omega.
The archives.
The unknown operators.
The recovered drives.
The explosion.
Aryan's disappearance.
The intelligence officer listened without interruption.
His expression never changed.
When the briefing ended, he asked only one question.
"Commander Aryan Sharma?"
Silence.
The answer hung heavily in the air.
Finally, the officer at the command post spoke.
"Missing."
The intelligence officer looked toward the mountain.
For several moments he said nothing.
Then he closed the file in his hands.
"Officially?"
Nobody liked where this was going.
The officer continued.
"Officially, Commander Aryan Sharma is presumed dead."
The words struck the valley like a gunshot.
Several Alpha Team members immediately looked up.
One of them swore under his breath.
Another clenched his fists.
Rudra remained motionless.
But only outwardly.
Inside, anger exploded.
Slowly, he stepped forward.

The intelligence officer met his gaze.
"You have a problem with that assessment, Captain Rathode?"
Rudra's voice remained calm.
Dangerously calm.
"Yes."
The officer raised an eyebrow.
Rudra pointed toward the mountain.
"You didn't see him in there."
Nobody spoke.
The valley suddenly felt very quiet.
"He survived things that should've killed him years ago."
The officer remained unimpressed.
"That doesn't change physics."
"No."
Rudra took another step forward.
"But it changes probability."
For several seconds the two men stared at each other.
Neither willing to back down.
Finally, the intelligence officer sighed.
"Hope isn't evidence, Captain."
Rudra's jaw tightened.
"Neither is a body."
The silence that followed was absolute.
Because no one could argue with that.
No body had been recovered.
No remains identified.
No proof existed.
Only assumptions.
The officer looked away first.
A small victory.
But not enough.
Because assumptions had already begun spreading through the command structure.
Reports were being written.
Files updated.
Decisions made.
And somewhere inside those reports, Aryan Sharma was slowly becoming a casualty.
Rudra looked back toward the mountain.
The rising sun illuminated the smoke-covered peaks.
Most people saw a collapsed facility.
A failed operation.
A dead commander.
Rudra saw something else.
A promise.
Because despite the evidence.
Despite the silence.
Despite the odds.
One thought refused to leave his mind.
Aryan Sharma was still alive.
He just hadn't found his way back yet.

Chapter 10

The Ghost Chamber

Part II

Darkness.

Absolute darkness.

No light.

No sound.

No sense of time.

For a long while, Aryan wasn't even aware he was conscious.

Fragments drifted through his mind.

Fire.

The archive.

The explosion.

The unknown operator.

Then nothing.

A deep silence swallowed everything.

Gradually, another sound emerged.

A slow, rhythmic beat.

Thump.

Thump.

Thump.

His heartbeat.

Pain followed seconds later.

A sharp ache spread through his shoulders.

His ribs burned.

His head felt as though someone had driven a metal spike through his skull.

Aryan opened his eyes.

Nothing changed.

The darkness remained complete.

For several moments he simply lay still.

Training took over.

Assess.

Don't panic.

Assess.

His breathing was steady.

No signs of major internal bleeding.

Arms moving.

Legs responding.

Painful.

But functional.

Good.

Slowly, he pushed himself upright.

The movement immediately sent a wave of pain through his body.

He ignored it.

Years of military operations had taught him one useful lesson.

Pain could be managed.

Panic could not.

His hand moved toward his headset.
Broken.
The earpiece had shattered during the explosion.
He checked his tactical vest.
Most equipment was gone.
His primary rifle missing.
Radio destroyed.
Several magazines lost.
Only his sidearm remained secured inside its holster.
Not ideal.
But enough.
Aryan reached into a side pouch and found an emergency light.
The casing was cracked.
The battery nearly dead.
Still usable.
He activated it.
A weak beam cut through the darkness.
The sight that emerged immediately stopped him.
He wasn't inside Omega.
At least not the Omega they had explored.
Massive slabs of broken concrete surrounded him.
Collapsed support beams.
Twisted steel.
Burned debris.
The explosion had clearly thrown him through multiple structural levels.
But something else caught his attention.
The walls.
They looked different.
Older.
Far older.
Omega's architecture had been modern.
Military.
Engineered.
These walls resembled something else entirely.
Thick reinforced stone.
Aged steel.
Ancient construction hidden beneath newer layers.
Aryan slowly stood.
The emergency light swept across the chamber.
Dust particles drifted through the air.
Silence filled the space.
No alarms.
No machinery.
No voices.
Nothing.
The mountain felt dead.
Yet the chamber itself remained intact.
Almost untouched.
As if it had been protected from the collapse.
The realization unsettled him.
The explosion should have destroyed everything.
Instead, it had delivered him somewhere else.
Somewhere hidden.

His light moved across the room again.
Old computer terminals lined one wall.
Most appeared inactive.
Several were covered by decades of dust.
A row of storage cabinets stood nearby.
Rust covered their surfaces.
The entire chamber looked abandoned.
Forgotten.
Buried.
Aryan began moving carefully.
Every instinct warned him to remain cautious.
Because hidden places inside hidden facilities rarely contained good news.
The beam eventually reached the center of the room.
Aryan stopped.
A large glass structure stood there.
Cylindrical.
Vertical.
Connected to multiple support systems.
For a brief moment he thought it was some kind of containment unit.
Then he moved closer.
And realized he was right.
A containment pod.
Its transparent surface reflected the emergency light.
Dust covered most of the glass.
Power cables disappeared into the floor beneath it.
Monitoring equipment surrounded the structure.
The setup looked sophisticated despite its age.
Someone had invested enormous resources into whatever had once occupied it.
Aryan approached slowly.
The pod was empty.
Completely empty.
No equipment inside.
No remains.
Nothing.
Yet something about it felt wrong.
A containment system this elaborate wasn't built without a reason.
His light moved downward.
A metal identification plate remained attached near the base.
Most of the writing had faded.
Aryan wiped away years of accumulated dust.
Letters slowly appeared.
His eyes narrowed.
The label read:
SUBJECT A-17
Silence.
A designation.
Not a name.
A subject.
The terminology immediately bothered him.
Military facilities used names.
Research facilities used designations.
This chamber suddenly felt far less military.
Aryan continued reading.

A second line appeared beneath the first.

STATUS: TRANSFERRED

His expression hardened.

Transferred.

Not terminated.

Not deceased.

Transferred.

Meaning whatever—or whoever—had occupied the pod had left alive.

Then he saw the date.

And for the first time since regaining consciousness, genuine concern appeared in his eyes.

Three days ago.

The exact same date.

The same date from the Omega records.

The same date from the transfer authorization.

The same date appearing again and again throughout Falcon Protocol.

Nothing about that was coincidence anymore.

Someone had moved Subject A-17 three days ago.

Someone operating inside the mountain.

Someone connected to Omega.

Someone connected to Falcon Protocol.

The emergency light flickered.

Its battery weakening.

Aryan stepped back.

His beam traveled across the far wall.

Then stopped.

A familiar symbol emerged from the darkness.

The geometric emblem.

The same symbol found throughout Omega.

The same symbol linked to the Consortium.

Only this version was different.

Larger.

Older.

More prominent.

As though this chamber predated everything above it.

Aryan moved closer.

Dust covered part of the wall beneath the symbol.

Instinctively, he brushed it aside.

Words appeared.

Simple words.

Yet they sent a cold feeling down his spine.

Because they revealed the existence of something entirely new.

Something beyond Falcon.

Something beyond Omega.

Something even his father had never mentioned in the recordings.

The inscription read:

PHASE TWO

The silence inside the chamber suddenly felt heavier.

More oppressive.

More alive.

Then—

A sound echoed somewhere in the darkness beyond the room.

A metallic click.

Aryan froze.

His hand moved toward his pistol.

The noise came again.

Closer this time.

Not machinery.

Not collapsing debris.

Footsteps.

Slow.

Measured.

Approaching the chamber.

Aryan extinguished the emergency light instantly.

Darkness swallowed the room once more.

And somewhere beyond the doorway, something—or someone—had just entered the hidden level beneath Omega.

Chapter 11

The Cost of Survival

Part I

Twenty-one hours.

That was how long Commander Aryan Sharma had been missing.

Twenty-one hours since Omega collapsed.

Twenty-one hours since the mountain had swallowed one of the country's most decorated special operations officers.

Twenty-one hours without communication.

Without confirmation.

Without hope.

The valley looked completely different now.

The battlefield atmosphere had vanished.

In its place stood a massive search and recovery operation.

Military helicopters continuously rotated through the airspace.

Engineers analyzed structural damage.

Medical units remained on standby.

Recon teams searched every possible exit route around the mountain.

Temporary command centers had been established across the operation zone.

Yet despite all available resources, the result remained the same.

Nothing.

No signal.

No body.

No trace.

The uncertainty was becoming unbearable.

Inside the main command tent, dozens of officers studied reports spread across digital screens.

Satellite scans.

Thermal imaging.

Underground structural assessments.

Every new report looked worse than the previous one.

The collapse had destroyed nearly seventy percent of the known Omega complex.

Entire sections no longer existed.

Several tunnels had completely caved in.

Escape routes were buried beneath thousands of tons of rock.

The official assessment was simple.

No human being should have survived.

But Alpha Team refused to accept that conclusion.

Especially Rudra Rathode.

For nearly an entire day, he had not left the command zone.

Every report passed through him.

Every search grid was reviewed personally.

Every possible lead was investigated.

Because despite the evidence, something inside him refused to believe Aryan was gone.

Across the tent, several senior officers exchanged concerned glances.

They knew Rudra.

Everyone did.

Calm under pressure.

Disciplined.

Rational.

Yet since the collapse, he had become a completely different person.

Not reckless.

Not emotional.

Just relentless.

As though accepting reality was no longer an option.

A young intelligence analyst approached the operations table.

"Sir."

Rudra looked up.

The analyst hesitated.

Then spoke carefully.

"The northern search sector came back negative."

Another dead end.

Another disappointment.

Rudra simply nodded.

"Continue."

The analyst looked uncomfortable.

"Sir..."

"What?"

The younger officer swallowed.

"The rescue probability assessment has been updated."

Silence filled the table.

Nobody liked probability assessments.

Especially not this one.

Rudra already knew what the analyst was about to say.

Still, hearing it out loud somehow felt worse.

"The current survival estimate is below three percent."

The tent became completely silent.

Several officers lowered their eyes.

Others focused on their screens.

Nobody wanted to look at Rudra.

Because everyone knew exactly what that number meant.

Three percent wasn't hope.

It was statistical mercy.

A number generated by computers unwilling to say zero.

The analyst immediately regretted speaking.

Because the temperature inside the tent seemed to drop.

Slowly, Rudra closed the file he had been reading.

Then he looked directly at the young officer.

"Tell me something."

The analyst stiffened.

"Sir?"

"Have you ever worked with Aryan Sharma?"

The question caught him off guard.

"No, sir."

Rudra nodded once.

"Then don't quote survival statistics to me."

Nobody said another word.

The analyst quietly stepped back.

Because there was no response to that.

Not here.

Not after everything Aryan had accomplished.

The stories surrounding him had become almost legendary inside special operations circles.

At nineteen, he had completed missions most veterans would refuse.
At twenty-one, he had become one of the youngest operational leaders in his field.
By twenty-five, he was regarded as one of the country's most effective special operations commanders.
Statistics didn't explain people like that.
The command tent entrance suddenly opened.
Several senior officers entered.
The atmosphere immediately changed.
These weren't ordinary officials.
These were the people who had trained Aryan throughout his military career.
Men who had watched him grow from a promising recruit into a battlefield commander.
Men who knew him personally.
One of them, Lieutenant General Arvind Khanna, walked directly toward the operations table.
His expression was unreadable.
But his eyes revealed exhaustion.
The last twenty-one hours had affected him as well.
"Any updates?"
Rudra shook his head.
"Nothing confirmed."
The General looked toward the mountain through the tent opening.
For several moments, he remained silent.
Then he spoke quietly.
Almost to himself.
"I still remember his first training exercise."
The officers nearby looked surprised.
The General rarely spoke about personal matters.
"He was nineteen."
A faint smile appeared.
"Arrogant."
Several officers actually laughed.
The first laughter heard in nearly a day.
"Thought he knew everything."
The smile faded quickly.
"But he learned faster than anyone I ever trained."
Silence returned.
Because everyone understood why the General was speaking this way.
Not as an officer.
As a mentor.
As someone remembering a student.
Another senior officer folded his arms.
"We're not giving up."
Nobody disagreed.
No matter what the reports said.
No matter what the assessments claimed.
Nobody present was ready to write Aryan Sharma's obituary.
Then suddenly—
A radio crackled.
The sound instantly grabbed everyone's attention.
A perimeter guard's voice emerged through the speaker.
Confused.
Breathless.
Almost disbelieving.
"Control, this is East Perimeter."
The entire command tent froze.

The guard continued.
"Possible movement detected."
Rudra's head snapped upward.
Every officer immediately turned toward the communications desk.
The operator grabbed the radio.
"Repeat."
Several seconds passed.
Then the guard spoke again.
This time his voice sounded shaken.
"Single individual approaching from the eastern ridge."
Silence.
Absolute silence.
The operator checked nearby surveillance feeds.
One of the drone cameras automatically zoomed toward the reported location.
The image appeared on the central screen.
At first nobody saw anything.
Just rocks.
Dust.
Mountain terrain.
Then—
A figure emerged.
Tiny.
Distant.
Barely visible.
Walking.
Slowly.
Unsteadily.
The entire command center stopped breathing.
Because even from hundreds of meters away...
Everyone recognized that walk.
Everyone recognized that posture.
Everyone recognized the man refusing to fall.
And for the first time in twenty-one hours—
Hope returned.

Chapter 11

The Cost of Survival

Part II

For a moment, nobody moved.
Nobody spoke.
Nobody even blinked.
Every eye inside the command center remained locked on the large screen.
The drone feed continued zooming in.
Slowly.
Carefully.
As though even the camera operator was afraid of what he might discover.
The figure stumbled again.
Nearly falling.
Yet somehow managed to remain standing.
Another step followed.
Then another.
The entire valley seemed to hold its breath.
Rudra didn't.
The moment he recognized that silhouette, he was already moving.
His chair crashed backwards.
Maps scattered across the operations table.
Several officers shouted after him.
He didn't hear a single word.
Or perhaps he simply didn't care.
The command tent erupted into chaos.
"Captain!"
"Wait!"
"We haven't secured the area yet!"
"Follow protocol!"
Protocol.
The word almost made him laugh.
For twenty-one hours, protocol had achieved nothing.
For twenty-one hours, protocols, assessments, and survival statistics had declared Aryan Sharma dead.
And now that same man was walking out of a mountain that should have buried him forever.
Rudra burst out of the command tent and sprinted across the valley.
The cold mountain air struck his face.
His boots pounded against the rocky ground.
Behind him, security teams immediately mobilized.
Perimeter units moved into position.
Weapons were raised.
Recon operators scanned the surrounding ridgelines.
Because from a tactical perspective, this situation made no sense.
A lone survivor emerging from a destroyed underground facility could easily be bait.
A trap.
An ambush.
The enemy had already demonstrated extraordinary capabilities.
No risks could be taken.

Yet Rudra ignored every warning.
Because somewhere ahead of him, a man was still walking when he should have been dead.
The drone feed had shown only part of the truth.
Up close, the reality was far worse.
Much worse.
Aryan looked like he had fought a war alone.
His uniform was barely recognizable.
Large sections had been torn apart.
Burn marks covered the fabric.
Blood stained nearly every visible surface.
Dried blood.
Fresh blood.
Too much blood.
The left side of his tactical vest had been shredded by shrapnel.
One sleeve hung loosely from his arm.
His face was covered in dirt and cuts.
Every step appeared painful.
As if his body had already reached its limit hours ago.
And yet he continued moving.
Not because he had strength left.
Because he refused to stop.
The distance between him and the camp slowly disappeared.
Two hundred meters.
One hundred and eighty.
One hundred and fifty.
Rudra ran faster.
The security teams struggled to keep up.
More personnel flooded into the valley.
Medics.
Officers.
Alpha Team members.
Nobody wanted to believe what they were seeing.
Yet the evidence stood directly before them.
Alive.
Against all logic.
Against all probability.
Alive.
Then Aryan suddenly stumbled.
This time harder.
His knee struck the ground.
The impact sent a visible tremor through his body.
A collective gasp escaped several personnel watching from the perimeter.
For a second, it looked like he might not get up again.
But he did.
Slowly.
Painfully.
Using nothing except sheer determination.
Rudra felt his chest tighten.
Because he knew Aryan.
And he knew exactly what this meant.
The only reason Aryan was still moving was because he had something important to deliver.
Some reason.
Some purpose.

Something that had carried him through pain that would have broken most men.

Then Aryan took another step.

And another.

Before finally—

His body quit.

No warning.

No dramatic moment.

No heroic speech.

Just exhaustion.

Pure human exhaustion.

His legs gave out beneath him.

The world tilted.

And Aryan Sharma collapsed face-first onto the rocky ground.

This time he didn't move.

The valley froze.

"ARYAN!"

Rudra's voice echoed across the operation zone.

He reached him seconds later.

Ignoring every shouted order behind him.

Ignoring every security warning.

Ignoring every risk assessment.

Because none of it mattered.

Not now.

Not when his brother was lying unconscious in the dirt.

Rudra dropped to one knee beside him.

The sight nearly shattered whatever composure remained.

Up close, the injuries looked catastrophic.

Multiple lacerations.

Shrapnel wounds.

Severe burns.

Signs of internal trauma.

His breathing was shallow.

Unsteady.

Dangerously weak.

The skin beneath the blood had turned pale.

Far too pale.

"Aryan."

No response.

Rudra gripped his shoulder.

"Aryan!"

Nothing.

Only a faint breath escaped his lips.

Then another.

Alive.

Barely.

But alive.

The rest of Alpha Team arrived moments later.

For a brief second, nobody spoke.

These were soldiers who had seen battle.

Seen death.

Seen things most people never would.

Yet seeing Aryan in this condition struck them differently.

Because Aryan had always been the one standing.

The one leading.
The one pulling others out.
Seeing him broken felt wrong.
Almost unnatural.
The medical team finally pushed through the crowd.
The lead trauma specialist dropped beside Aryan and immediately began his assessment.
His expression changed within seconds.
Then changed again.
The medic checked Aryan's pulse.
Looked at the wounds.
Checked pupil response.
Then swore quietly under his breath.
That alone terrified everyone nearby.
Because military trauma surgeons were not easily shaken.
"How bad?" Rudra asked.
The medic didn't answer immediately.
Instead, he turned toward his team.
"Move!"
The urgency in his voice electrified the entire area.
"Stretcher!"
"Emergency blood preparation!"
"Alert the evacuation helicopter!"
Personnel exploded into motion.
The medic looked back at Rudra.
His expression grim.
"He's critical."
The words hit harder than any bullet.
Several officers nearby immediately exchanged looks.
Critical.
Not serious.
Not severe.
Critical.
There was a difference.
A massive difference.
One meant recovery.
The other meant uncertainty.
Aryan was placed onto a stretcher.
Even unconscious, he instinctively resisted movement.
The result of years of training.
Years of combat.
Years of surviving situations exactly like this.
Then something unexpected happened.
As the medics secured him, a damaged data pouch slipped from his vest and fell onto the ground.
Rudra immediately picked it up.
Inside were multiple encrypted storage drives.
The same drives recovered from Omega.
The reason Aryan had kept moving.
The reason he had survived.
The reason he had dragged himself through a mountain after nearly dying.
Not for himself.
For the mission.
For the team.
For the truth.

Rudra closed his eyes briefly.
Then looked toward the evacuation helicopter descending into the valley.
Its rotors thundered overhead.
Dust filled the air.
Around him, senior officers watched in silence.
Many of them had trained Aryan personally.
Many had known him since he was nineteen.
Some had celebrated his promotions.
Others had recommended him for command.
To the country, Aryan Sharma was one of its finest special operations officers.
To the men standing here—
He was family.
And as the helicopter doors opened and the medical team rushed him aboard, a realization spread through every rank present.
If Aryan Sharma died today—
They would not just lose a commander.
They would lose the heart of Alpha Team itself.
And deep down, every officer present understood the same frightening truth.
Replacing a soldier was possible.
Replacing Aryan Sharma was not.

Chapter 12

Between Life and Death

Part I

The helicopter landed before the medical team was ready.

Not because they were unprepared.

Because they had not expected the patient to arrive alive.

The aircraft touched down on the military hospital's emergency pad just as sunset painted the sky in shades of orange and grey.

The moment the doors opened, doctors rushed forward.

Then they saw the patient.

And everything changed.

"Move!"

The senior trauma surgeon's voice cut through the noise.

Medical personnel immediately surrounded the stretcher.

Monitors were attached.

Blood pressure checked.

Airway secured.

The urgency increased with every passing second.

Because Commander Aryan Sharma was dying.

Not dramatically.

Not visibly.

Quietly.

The way soldiers often did.

The flight medic handed over the casualty report.

The surgeon scanned it.

Then looked at Aryan.

Then looked back at the report.

For several moments he simply stared.

As if comparing two completely different realities.

Finally he spoke.

"How long?"

The flight medic understood immediately.

"Sir?"

"How long was he moving with these injuries?"

The medic hesitated.

"Approximately twenty-one hours."

The surgeon actually stopped walking.

"What?"

"Twenty-one."

Silence followed.

The doctor looked at the wounds again.

Blood loss.

Internal trauma.

Multiple fractures.

Burn injuries.

Shrapnel penetration.

Exhaustion.

Shock.

No human being should have remained conscious for that long.

Yet somehow Aryan had walked out of a mountain.

The surgeon handed the report back.

"Get him to Operating Room Three."

The medical team accelerated immediately.

Behind them, Alpha Team entered the hospital.

Nobody spoke.

Nobody needed to.

The atmosphere alone was enough.

The sight of Aryan on that stretcher had affected everyone.

Because seeing him injured was one thing.

Seeing him vulnerable was another.

Rudra followed close behind until the surgical wing entrance.

A nurse blocked his path.

"I'm sorry, sir."

He stopped.

The doors leading toward the operating rooms slowly closed.

For the first time since the mountain collapse, there was nothing he could do.

No enemy to fight.

No mission to execute.

No decision to make.

Only waiting.

And waiting was always the hardest part.

The surgery began minutes later.

Outside, the hospital corridor gradually filled.

Senior military officers arrived one after another.

Intelligence officials.

Command personnel.

Even individuals who technically had no reason to be there.

Yet they came anyway.

Because Aryan Sharma was not merely another officer.

His reputation extended far beyond Alpha Team.

Many of the men now gathering in the corridor had watched his career from the beginning.

Some had trained him.

Others had recommended him for command positions.

A few had personally mentored him.

The concern visible on their faces wasn't professional.

It was personal.

Lieutenant General Arvind Khanna arrived nearly an hour later.

The moment he entered the corridor, conversations stopped.

The General's eyes immediately found the operating room doors.

Still closed.

Still active.

Not a good sign.

He approached Rudra.

"Status?"

Rudra looked exhausted.

"He lost consciousness before reaching the perimeter."

The General nodded slowly.

"And the doctors?"

"They haven't said anything yet."

That answer worried him more than he admitted.

Experienced military surgeons usually communicated early.
Silence often meant complications.
Neither man spoke for several moments.
The red surgery light remained illuminated above the operating room.
A simple light.
Yet every person in the corridor kept looking at it.
As though it controlled their breathing.
Their hope.
Their fear.
Hours passed.
Night arrived.
Still the light remained on.
Inside the operating room, doctors fought a different kind of battle.
One measured in blood pressure.
Heart rate.
Oxygen levels.
Seconds.
Outside, nobody moved far from the corridor.
Coffee cups accumulated.
Reports remained unread.
Phones stayed unanswered.
Because every update eventually led back to the same question.
Would Aryan survive?
Meanwhile, several floors below, inside one of the military hospital's secure intelligence rooms, another battle had quietly begun.
The recovered Omega drives.
The drives Aryan had carried out of the mountain.
The drives he had nearly died protecting.
Rows of analysts worked across encrypted systems.
Cyber specialists.
Intelligence officers.
Data recovery experts.
The atmosphere inside the room was tense.
Not because they lacked information.
Because they had too much.
Thousands of files.
Corrupted archives.
Encrypted databases.
Security layers built by people who clearly did not want their secrets discovered.
One analyst rubbed his eyes.
"We've recovered approximately fourteen percent."
A nearby officer looked up.
"Anything useful?"
The analyst hesitated.
Then nodded.
"A lot."
The room became silent.
The officer stood.
"What kind of useful?"
The analyst turned his monitor.
Several folders appeared on the screen.
Falcon Protocol.
Omega Research.

Internal Security Reviews.
Consortium Activity Logs.
The officer felt his pulse quicken.
Months of intelligence work could emerge from those files.
Perhaps years.
Then something else appeared.
A folder hidden beneath multiple layers of encryption.
Unlike the others, this one carried a different designation.
Simple.
Short.
Unusual.
The analyst frowned.
"That's strange."
"What?"
"This folder wasn't listed in the original directory."
The officer stepped closer.
"What does it say?"
The analyst enlarged the screen.
Everyone in the room stared at the name.
A designation they had already encountered once before.
Deep beneath Omega.
Inside the hidden chamber where Aryan had disappeared.
The folder name read:
A-17
The room fell silent.
Because suddenly, the mountain wasn't finished with them.
Not even close.

Chapter 12

Between Life and Death

Part II

At 2:17 AM, the operating room doors were still closed.
The red light above them continued glowing.
Hour after hour.
Unchanging.
Unforgiving.
The hospital corridor had grown quieter as the night deepened.
Some officers sat silently.
Others stood near windows overlooking the military compound.
Nobody had gone home.
Nobody intended to.
Because as long as that red light remained on, every person present felt trapped in the same uncertainty.
Rudra sat alone at the far end of the corridor.
For the first time in nearly two days, exhaustion was beginning to show.
His eyes were bloodshot.
His uniform remained unchanged.
Dust from the mountain still clung to the fabric.
He hadn't bothered cleaning it.
Part of him didn't want to.
It was the last thing connecting him to the operation.
To Omega.
To Aryan.
A pair of footsteps approached.
Rudra looked up.
General Khanna lowered himself into the chair beside him.
Neither spoke immediately.
The silence wasn't uncomfortable.
It was familiar.
The kind shared between soldiers who understood loss.
Eventually the General sighed.
"You know what his biggest problem was during training?"
A faint smile appeared despite the circumstances.
Rudra shook his head.
"No."
"He never quit."
Rudra raised an eyebrow.
"That sounds like a good thing."
"It wasn't."
The General looked toward the operating room.
"He broke three ribs during a field exercise."
Rudra blinked.
"What?"
"He finished the exercise anyway."
A small laugh escaped him.
The first genuine laugh in nearly twenty-four hours.

The General continued.
"The instructors were furious."
"Sounds like Aryan."
"It was."
The smile disappeared.
And suddenly the corridor felt heavy again.
Because stories were easier than reality.
And reality sat behind those doors.
Fighting for survival.
The General stared at the red light.
Then quietly said something that surprised Rudra.
"He's the closest thing I've had to a son."
Silence.
Rudra looked at him.
The older man kept his eyes fixed forward.
As if admitting it aloud had cost him something.
For the first time, Rudra realized how many people Aryan's life touched.
Not because of rank.
Not because of achievements.
Because of who he was.
The realization settled heavily between them.
Then the operating room doors finally opened.
Both men stood instantly.
Doctors emerged first.
Masks removed.
Faces exhausted.
The lead surgeon looked as though he had aged years in a single night.
Every person in the corridor gathered around.
Nobody asked questions immediately.
The answer was written on the surgeon's face.
He removed his gloves slowly.
Then looked directly at General Khanna.
"The surgery was successful."
The entire corridor released a collective breath.
Some officers visibly relaxed.
Others closed their eyes.
One of the nurses smiled for the first time all night.
The relief was immediate.
Powerful.
Almost overwhelming.
But the surgeon wasn't finished.
"He survived the operation."
The wording caught everyone's attention.
Survived.
Not recovered.
Not stable.
Survived.
A subtle but important difference.
The surgeon continued.
"His injuries were severe."
No one was surprised.
"We stopped the internal bleeding. Removed most of the shrapnel. Stabilized the fractures."
The General folded his arms.

"When will he wake up?"

The surgeon hesitated.

And suddenly the relief vanished.

"That's the problem."

Silence.

The doctor looked genuinely concerned.

"The physical injuries are under control."

"Then what's wrong?"

"We don't know."

The answer confused everyone.

The surgeon looked toward the ICU wing.

"His body should be responding better."

No one understood.

So he explained.

"Based on the surgery results, he should already be showing signs of neurological improvement."

The corridor grew silent.

"But he isn't."

The surgeon paused.

"We've stabilized him."

Another pause.

"But right now..."

His voice softened.

"...he's not waking up."

The words hit harder than expected.

Because they introduced a new fear.

A different fear.

The battle wasn't over.

Not yet.

Far below the hospital, inside the intelligence wing, nobody knew about the conversation upstairs.

They had their own problem.

And it sat on a computer screen.

The A-17 folder.

Every specialist in the room focused on the monitor.

The folder had resisted multiple decryption attempts.

Layer after layer of security protected it.

Unlike Falcon files.

Unlike Consortium archives.

Unlike Omega records.

This folder was different.

Someone had gone to extraordinary lengths to hide it.

Which meant it mattered.

An analyst finally leaned back.

"We're in."

The room immediately became silent.

The folder opened.

Several files appeared.

Medical reports.

Transfer documents.

Research logs.

Authorization records.

Everything carried the same designation.

A-17.

The officer overseeing the room stepped closer.

"Open the first file."

The analyst clicked.

The document loaded slowly.

Years of encryption peeled away line by line.

At first everything appeared normal.

Project references.

Facility numbers.

Dates.

Then a detailed personnel section emerged.

The room froze.

One line appeared.

Then another.

Then another.

Every person present stared at the screen.

Trying to understand what they were reading.

The file listed supervisory personnel assigned to Subject A-17.

Several names had been removed.

Others remained.

Most were unfamiliar.

Until one entry appeared.

A name every person in the room recognized instantly.

Primary Guardian: Vikram Sharma

Nobody spoke.

The analyst read it twice.

Then a third time.

The supervising officer stepped forward.

His expression slowly changing.

Because this wasn't a coincidence anymore.

Not after Omega.

Not after Falcon.

Not after everything they had discovered.

Vikram Sharma wasn't connected to A-17.

He was responsible for A-17.

The officer looked toward the remaining files.

There were hundreds of them.

And suddenly every person in the room understood the same thing.

They hadn't uncovered the truth behind Falcon Protocol.

Not yet.

They had only discovered the door leading to it.

And somewhere inside the ICU above them, unconscious and unaware, Aryan Sharma remained trapped between life and death...

while the greatest secret his parents had ever hidden was finally beginning to surface.

Chapter 12

Between Life and Death

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The answer confused everyone.

The surgeon looked toward the ICU wing.

"His body should be responding better."

No one understood.

So he explained.

"Based on the surgery results, he should already be showing signs of neurological improvement."

The corridor grew silent.

"But he isn't."

The surgeon paused.

"We've stabilized him."

Another pause.

"But right now..."

His voice softened.

"...he's not waking up."

The words hit harder than expected.

Because they introduced a new fear.

A different fear.

The battle wasn't over.

Not yet.

Far below the hospital, inside the intelligence wing, nobody knew about the conversation upstairs.

They had their own problem.

And it sat on a computer screen.

The A-17 folder.

Every specialist in the room focused on the monitor.

The folder had resisted multiple decryption attempts.

Layer after layer of security protected it.

Unlike Falcon files.

Unlike Consortium archives.

Unlike Omega records.

This folder was different.

Someone had gone to extraordinary lengths to hide it.

Which meant it mattered.

An analyst finally leaned back.

"We're in."

The room immediately became silent.

The folder opened.

Several files appeared.

Medical reports.

Transfer documents.

Research logs.

Authorization records.

Everything carried the same designation.

A-17.

The officer overseeing the room stepped closer.

"Open the first file."

The analyst clicked.

The document loaded slowly.

Years of encryption peeled away line by line.

At first everything appeared normal.

Project references.

Facility numbers.

Dates.

Then a detailed personnel section emerged.

The room froze.

One line appeared.

Then another.

Then another.

Every person present stared at the screen.

Trying to understand what they were reading.

The file listed supervisory personnel assigned to Subject A-17.

Several names had been removed.

Others remained.

Most were unfamiliar.

Until one entry appeared.

A name every person in the room recognized instantly.

Primary Guardian: Vikram Sharma

Nobody spoke.

The analyst read it twice.

Then a third time.

The supervising officer stepped forward.

His expression slowly changing.

Because this wasn't a coincidence anymore.

Not after Omega.

Not after Falcon.

Not after everything they had discovered.

Vikram Sharma wasn't connected to A-17.

He was responsible for A-17.

The officer looked toward the remaining files.

There were hundreds of them.

And suddenly every person in the room understood the same thing.

They hadn't uncovered the truth behind Falcon Protocol.

Not yet.

They had only discovered the door leading to it.

And somewhere inside the ICU above them, unconscious and unaware, Aryan Sharma remained trapped between life and death...

while the greatest secret his parents had ever hidden was finally beginning to surface.

Chapter 13

The World Beyond War

Part I

For the first time in two years, Alpha Team had nowhere to go.

No mission briefing.

No target package.

No encrypted orders waiting on a secure terminal.

No helicopter warming its engines on a runway.

Nothing.

The realization felt wrong.

Almost unnatural.

Because for men who had spent years running toward danger, stillness was often more unsettling than war itself.

Outside, dawn was slowly rising over the military medical complex.

Inside, the sixth-floor conference room remained silent.

Six chairs.

Five occupied.

One empty.

Nobody looked directly at it.

Yet everyone was aware of its presence.

Commander Aryan Sharma's chair.

The center of every briefing.

Every operation.

Every impossible decision.

Empty.

The sight alone was enough to sour the atmosphere.

Rudra Rathore sat with folded arms, staring at the polished wooden table.

The bruise across his jaw had started fading.

The stitches near his shoulder had not.

Across from him, the rest of Alpha Team waited in silence.

Nobody joked.

Nobody argued.

Nobody complained.

Which was unusual.

Because Alpha Team never stayed quiet for this long.

Not unless something was seriously wrong.

At precisely 08:00 hours, the conference room door opened.

Every man immediately stood.

Major General Arvind Khanna entered alongside three senior officers.

The room straightened instinctively.

"At ease."

Nobody sat.

Not immediately.

The General looked around the room.

His gaze paused briefly on the empty chair.

Something unreadable crossed his face.

Then disappeared.

Only after he took his seat did the others follow.

A thick folder landed on the table.
The sound echoed through the room.
"This won't take long."
That sentence alone made everyone nervous.
Because military meetings that started with those words rarely ended well.
The General opened the file.
"The medical board has reached a conclusion regarding Commander Sharma."
Every eye focused on him instantly.
Even breathing seemed to stop.
"The surgery was successful."
A few shoulders relaxed.
"The bleeding has stopped."
More relief.
"The fractures are healing."
Good.
Then came the pause.
The dangerous pause.
The kind soldiers learned to fear.
"But..."
The room froze.
The General's expression hardened.
"Commander Sharma remains unconscious."
Silence.
Heavy.
Oppressive.
Nobody spoke.
Because everybody already knew.
But hearing it spoken aloud somehow made it worse.
The General continued.
"The doctors cannot predict when he will wake up."
Rudra's jaw clenched.
Not because he was surprised.
Because he hated uncertainty.
Especially when it involved Aryan.
The General closed the file.
"What I am about to say stays inside this room."
Instantly the atmosphere changed.
Now this sounded like a classified briefing.
Not a medical update.
The General leaned forward.
"If Commander Sharma had died during Operation Omega..."
Nobody moved.
"...Alpha Team would have lost nearly fifty percent of its operational effectiveness."
The words landed like a grenade.
Not because they were insulting.
Because they were true.
The General wasn't finished.
"Every strategic review reached the same conclusion."
Another pause.
"Nobody in the armed forces currently processes battlefield intelligence faster than Aryan Sharma."
Silence.
"He sees patterns before analysts."
"Predicts movements before satellites."

"Identifies threats before they fully emerge."

The General looked directly at Rudra.

"And that's why half the people in this building haven't slept in three days."

Nobody argued.

Nobody could.

Because everyone understood something the public never would.

Heroes weren't rare.

Great soldiers weren't rare.

Even elite operators weren't rare.

But people like Aryan?

Those were once-in-a-generation assets.

The room remained silent for several seconds.

Then the General flipped another page.

"Now for the second matter."

Something about his tone immediately worried everyone.

"The High Command has approved six months mandatory leave for Alpha Team."

For a moment nobody reacted.

The statement simply didn't register.

Then reality caught up.

"What?"

The word escaped before anyone could stop it.

Several soldiers exchanged looks.

One actually thought he had misheard.

Six months?

Six.

Entire.

Months.

The General raised an eyebrow.

"Is there a problem?"

Nobody answered.

Because they genuinely didn't know how to.

For two years they had lived from operation to operation.

Mission to mission.

War to war.

Now suddenly someone was telling them to stop.

To rest.

To live.

The idea felt absurd.

Rudra finally broke the silence.

"Sir..."

The General already knew what was coming.

"No."

Rudra blinked.

"I haven't asked anything yet."

"I know."

A faint smile appeared on the older man's face.

"And the answer is still no."

A few quiet laughs finally escaped the room.

The first in days.

For a brief moment, the tension cracked.

But only briefly.

Because everyone knew the truth.

This leave wasn't a reward.

It wasn't a vacation.

It was an admission.

The Falcon Protocol investigation could not continue.

Not without Aryan Sharma.

And for the first time since the beginning of the operation, Alpha Team found itself facing an enemy none of them knew how to fight.

Time.

Chapter 13

The World Beyond War

Part II

The transfer happened forty-eight hours later.

At exactly 10:00 AM, a convoy of black military vehicles rolled out of the medical complex.

The lead vehicle carried military police.

The rear vehicle carried armed security personnel.

At the center of the convoy, surrounded from every direction, was a heavily modified ambulance.

Inside it lay Commander Aryan Sharma.

Unconscious.

Unaware.

And somehow still influencing the decisions of people across the country.

The transfer order had been classified.

Officially, the patient did not exist.

No media coverage.

No public statements.

No military press release.

Yet despite every precaution, news had somehow leaked.

Not the identity.

Just the fact that an extremely high-profile military patient was being moved under extraordinary security.

Which was why dozens of reporters had gathered outside the country's most prestigious civilian medical center.
St. Thomas Advanced Medical Institute.

The hospital was known throughout the country.

Politicians came there.

Business tycoons came there.

International patients came there.

Its success rates were among the highest in Asia.

But the reason cameras were currently gathered outside had nothing to do with military convoys.

They were there because of two doctors.

"Doctor Arya, one last question!"

The young reporter pushed forward through the crowd.

Nearby cameramen immediately adjusted their positions.

The woman standing at the center of the media gathering looked mildly annoyed.

Not nervous.

Not excited.

Annoyed.

Dr. Arya Mehra had never particularly enjoyed interviews.

Unfortunately, interviews seemed to enjoy her.

At twenty-four years old, she had become one of the youngest specialists ever appointed by the institute.

The achievement had attracted attention.

A lot of attention.

"One final question became ten final questions fifteen minutes ago."

Several reporters laughed.

The reporter grinned sheepishly.

"Fair point."

Arya folded her arms.

"Then make it count."

The crowd immediately became silent.
The reporter glanced at his notes.
"What motivates you to continue working after losing your father only six months ago?"
The smile disappeared from several faces.
Even the cameramen became uncomfortable.
It was an insensitive question.
Everyone knew it.
For a moment the atmosphere changed.
Arya's expression remained calm.
Professional.
Controlled.
The kind of control built from pain rather than confidence.
"When someone spends their entire life teaching you how to stand," she said quietly, "the least you can do after they're gone is keep standing."
The crowd became silent.
No dramatic speech.
No emotional display.
Just a simple answer.
And somehow that made it hit harder.
Several reporters lowered their microphones.
Nearby, another woman shook her head.
"You people really don't know when to stop, do you?"
The reporters immediately groaned.
"Not you too, Doctor Ridhi."
Dr. Ridhi Kapoor stepped beside Arya with an amused smile.
Unlike Arya, Ridhi actually enjoyed dealing with people.
She enjoyed conversations.
Arguments.
Chaos.
The media loved her.
Mostly because she never sounded rehearsed.
"If you make her emotional before lunch," Ridhi said, "she'll make the entire hospital miserable."
Arya gave her a look.
Ridhi smiled wider.
The reporters laughed.
The tension disappeared instantly.
The contrast between the two doctors was obvious.
Arya was discipline.
Ridhi was energy.
Arya was restraint.
Ridhi was expression.
Yet somehow they worked perfectly together.
A phone suddenly vibrated inside Arya's pocket.
She checked the screen.
The caller ID immediately changed her expression.
Hospital Administration.
That was unusual.
Very unusual.
She answered.
"Dr. Mehra."
The voice on the other end sounded rushed.
"Where are you?"
"Outside."

"Return immediately."

Arya frowned.

"What happened?"

A brief pause followed.

Then—

"Emergency military transfer."

Her expression sharpened instantly.

"What kind of transfer?"

"Level Black."

That got her attention.

Level Black authorizations were exceptionally rare.

In her entire career, she had encountered only one.

And even that had involved a cabinet minister.

"What happened?"

"We'll explain when you arrive."

The call ended.

Ridhi had already noticed the change.

"What is it?"

Arya put away her phone.

"We're needed inside."

The two doctors immediately headed toward the hospital entrance.

Behind them, reporters began shouting questions.

Neither stopped.

Because something serious had happened.

Very serious.

Five minutes later, they entered the administrative conference room.

Several senior doctors were already present.

Hospital directors.

Department heads.

Security officials.

Far more people than necessary.

Which meant the incoming patient was important.

Very important.

Arya exchanged a glance with Ridhi.

Both noticed the same thing.

Tension.

Nobody looked relaxed.

The hospital director cleared his throat.

"Thank you for coming."

"What happened?" Arya asked.

The director slid a classified patient file across the table.

"The military requested our best specialists."

Ridhi frowned.

"For who?"

The director didn't answer.

Instead, he pointed toward the file.

Arya opened it.

The first page appeared.

Patient status.

Critical recovery.

Multiple injuries.

Neurological observation.

Long-term rehabilitation.

She turned the page.

And froze.

For the first time all morning, genuine surprise appeared on her face.

Beside her, Ridhi leaned closer.

Then she froze too.

Because printed across the top of the document were three words.

Commander Aryan Sharma.

Outside the hospital windows, the military convoy finally entered the main gate.

And for the first time, two completely different worlds began moving toward each other.

Chapter 14

The Doctor Who Hated Heroes

Part I

The television hanging in the corner of the waiting area was muted.

Nobody paid attention to it.

At least, nobody except Arya.

She stood outside Room 312, reviewing a patient's neurological chart while fragments of a news broadcast flashed across the screen behind her.

A memorial ceremony.

Candles.

Photographs.

Families.

A banner stretched across the stage.

Remembering The Victims.

For a fraction of a second, Arya's eyes lingered on the screen.

Then she looked away.

Immediately.

Deliberately.

As if looking any longer would hurt.

"Doctor?"

The voice pulled her back.

She blinked once and entered the room.

Inside sat seventy-year-old Mr. Verma, one of her long-term patients.

The elderly man smiled the moment he saw her.

"There she is."

Arya placed the chart down.

"Good morning."

"You're late."

She checked her watch.

"I'm exactly on time."

"Which means you're late."

Arya sighed.

"That makes absolutely no sense."

"It makes perfect sense."

The old man pointed at her.

"You're young."

Then pointed at himself.

"I'm old."

"And?"

"Old people decide what time means."

Despite herself, a small smile appeared.

The old man immediately noticed.

"See? That's better."

The smile vanished.

"Don't get used to it."

"Too late."

For the next fifteen minutes, she completed his examination.

Simple questions.
Simple responses.
Another ordinary morning.
Another patient slowly recovering.
Another battle fought without bullets.
Those were the battles Arya preferred.
Nobody called doctors heroes when they saved one life.
Nobody held parades.
Nobody gave medals.
And honestly, she liked it that way.
As she prepared to leave, Mr. Verma suddenly spoke.
"Still thinking about him?"
Arya froze.
Only for a second.
But it was enough.
The old man's expression softened.
"I saw you looking at the television."
Silence.
The room suddenly felt smaller.
"He would've been proud of you."
Arya looked away.
The familiar ache returned instantly.
Six months.
Half a year.
Yet some wounds remained untouched by time.
"He should've been there to say that himself."
The words escaped before she could stop them.
The old man didn't respond immediately.
Sometimes silence carried more understanding than advice.
Eventually he nodded.
"Yes."
That single word hurt more than sympathy ever could.
Arya picked up the chart.
"Get some rest."
Then she walked out before the conversation could continue.
The corridor outside was busy.
Doctors moving between departments.
Nurses discussing treatment plans.
Families waiting anxiously.
Life continued.
It always did.
Whether people were ready or not.
Her phone vibrated.
A hospital notification appeared.

Administrative Meeting. 09:30 AM. Mandatory Attendance.

Arya frowned.
Administrative meetings were proof that suffering existed outside medicine.
She slipped the phone back into her pocket and headed toward the staff lounge.
The moment she entered, she regretted it.
Ridhi Kapoor was already there.
Which meant peace had officially ended.
"Good morning, sunshine."
Arya grabbed a coffee.

"Good morning."

Ridhi narrowed her eyes suspiciously.

"Why do you sound like you're attending a funeral?"

"I work in a hospital."

"Fair point."

Arya sat opposite her.

For nearly thirty seconds, Ridhi remained silent.

Which was concerning.

Very concerning.

Finally Arya looked up.

"What?"

Ridhi grinned.

"You noticed."

"Noticed what?"

"You counted."

Arya stared.

"You've spoken only once in thirty seconds."

"I'm growing as a person."

"No."

Ridhi sighed dramatically.

"Nobody appreciates character development."

Before Arya could respond, another doctor entered the lounge.

The younger physician looked excited.

Which usually meant gossip.

"Have you heard?"

Several people immediately looked up.

Ridhi smiled.

"There it is."

"Heard what?"

"The military patient."

The room instantly became interested.

Hospital rumors spread faster than viruses.

"The VIP transfer?" someone asked.

The doctor nodded.

"Apparently the government requested an entire rehabilitation floor."

A few eyebrows rose.

"Seriously?"

"It gets better."

The doctor lowered his voice.

"There are intelligence officers in the building."

Now everyone was paying attention.

Except Arya.

She continued drinking her coffee.

The younger doctor noticed.

"You don't care?"

"Should I?"

"It's a military case."

Arya's expression remained unchanged.

"So?"

The doctor looked surprised.

"So... it's important."

For a moment nobody spoke.

Then Arya calmly placed her coffee down.

"My father died in a terror attack."
The room fell silent.
Instantly.
The younger doctor looked horrified.
He hadn't known.
Nobody blamed him.
Few people did.
Arya's voice remained steady.
Controlled.
Almost emotionless.
Which somehow made the words heavier.
"Every year newspapers publish stories."
She looked toward the window.
"Every year politicians make speeches."
Another pause.
"Every year somebody gets a medal."
Silence.
Then she stood.
"And every year families visit graves."
Nobody knew what to say.
Because there was nothing to say.
The room remained quiet long after she left.
Ridhi watched her disappear into the corridor.
The playful expression on her face gone.
Because she knew the truth.
Arya didn't hate soldiers.
She didn't hate officers.
She didn't even hate heroes.
She hated what remained after they left.
At exactly 9:30 AM, Arya entered the administration conference room.
Nearly every department head was already present.
Hospital directors.
Senior consultants.
Security officials.
Far more people than necessary.
Which meant something serious was happening.
The hospital director stood.
"Thank you for coming."
Nobody interrupted.
The director adjusted his glasses.
"As many of you know, we have received a special government transfer."
A file appeared on the screen behind him.
Restricted.
Classified.
Military.
Arya immediately lost interest.
Then the director continued.
"After reviewing all available specialists, a lead physician has been selected."
Something about his tone made her suspicious.
Very suspicious.
The director looked directly at her.
And suddenly Arya knew.
She absolutely knew.

"This assignment will be handled by Dr. Arya Mehra."

The room turned toward her.

Arya closed her eyes.

Of course.

"Sir, no."

The answer came instantly.

Several doctors exchanged amused looks.

The director sighed.

"We've had this conversation before."

"We're about to have it again."

"Arya—"

"Assign someone else."

"There is no one else."

The director pushed a classified file across the table.

"At least review the patient."

Reluctantly, she opened it.

Patient Name:

Commander Aryan Sharma

She turned the page.

Age: 25.

Multiple Gallantry Citations.

Special Operations Command.

Classified Mission Record.

National Security Clearance.

Decorated Officer.

Hero.

Arya closed the file.

The room waited.

The director folded his arms.

"Problem?"

For a moment she said nothing.

Then she looked at the name one final time.

Before answering quietly.

"I don't like heroes."

And for reasons she couldn't explain...

The uneasy feeling in her chest only grew stronger.

Chapter 14

The Doctor Who Hated Heroes

Part II

By the time the meeting ended, Arya's mood had worsened considerably.

Which was saying something.

The classified file rested beneath her arm as she walked through the administrative corridor. Every few steps she considered handing it back.

Unfortunately, professionalism was a curse she suffered from.

If a patient needed treatment, personal opinions didn't matter.

That didn't mean she had to like it.

Behind her, Ridhi struggled to keep pace.

"You know," Ridhi began, "most people would be excited."

Arya didn't slow down.

"Most people aren't me."

"Also true."

They entered an elevator.

The doors closed.

For several seconds neither spoke.

Then Ridhi glanced at the file.

"Commander Aryan Sharma."

No response.

"Big name."

Nothing.

"Decorated officer."

Silence.

"Youngest operational commander in—"

"I read the file."

Ridhi grinned.

"I noticed."

The elevator opened.

Both stepped out.

Ahead of them, the atmosphere inside the hospital had changed.

Completely.

Security personnel occupied every major corridor.

Additional cameras had appeared overnight.

Restricted access signs covered entire sections of the rehabilitation wing.

Even nurses seemed more alert than usual.

Several military officers stood outside designated checkpoints.

The scene felt less like a hospital and more like a secure government facility.

Arya immediately hated it.

Hospitals were supposed to heal people.

Not resemble military compounds.

As they passed one checkpoint, a young nurse approached nervously.

"Doctor Mehra?"

"Yes?"

"The transfer convoy just entered the campus."

Arya nodded.

"Thank you."

The nurse hesitated.

Then lowered her voice.

"They say he's famous."

Arya continued walking.

"They also say coffee causes immortality."

The nurse blinked.

"What?"

"Exactly."

Ridhi nearly laughed.

The younger nurse looked completely confused as the two doctors disappeared down the corridor.

Meanwhile, outside the hospital, the convoy entered through the main gate.

The reaction was immediate.

Reporters surged forward.

Cameras flashed.

Security teams pushed the crowd back.

The sight looked more like the arrival of a head of state than a patient.

Inside the lead vehicle, intelligence officers monitored every movement.

Inside the ambulance, machines tracked every heartbeat.

And at the center of it all lay a man who remained completely unaware of the chaos surrounding him.

Aryan Sharma hadn't opened his eyes in six days.

Not once.

The convoy reached the private medical entrance.

The rear doors opened.

Doctors and military personnel immediately moved into position.

A specialized transfer team carefully rolled the stretcher out.

Several hospital staff members froze.

Not because of the security.

Because of the patient.

The injuries were impossible to ignore.

Even after emergency treatment.

Even after surgery.

Bandages covered significant portions of his body.

His left arm remained immobilized.

Visible scars stretched across exposed skin.

The monitors attached to him painted a clear picture.

This wasn't somebody recovering from an accident.

This was somebody who had survived a war.

Arya watched from the far end of the corridor.

For the first time, she saw him.

Not photographs.

Not reports.

Not military records.

The actual person.

The famous Commander Aryan Sharma.

The national hero.

The decorated officer.

The man half the country apparently admired.

And her first thought was surprisingly simple.

He looked tired.

Not strong.

Not intimidating.

Not legendary.

Just tired.
A twenty-five-year-old carrying far more damage than anyone his age should.
The thought annoyed her immediately.
Sympathy wasn't helpful.
Especially when dealing with military officers.
She pushed the feeling aside.
Professional distance.
That was easier.
The transfer team moved him toward the restricted rehabilitation wing.
Doctors exchanged information.
Nurses reviewed medications.
Military officers signed paperwork.
Everything proceeded smoothly.
Until one elderly patient noticed the convoy.
"What happened to him?"
The question came from a wheelchair near the reception area.
Nobody answered.
The old man looked toward Arya.
"He a soldier?"
She nodded.
The patient studied Aryan for several seconds.
Then quietly said,
"Poor kid."
Arya stopped walking.
So did Ridhi.
The old man wasn't praising him.
Wasn't admiring him.
Wasn't calling him a hero.
He simply looked at a broken young man and felt sorry for him.
For some reason, that bothered Arya more than all the medals in the file.
The transfer finally reached the rehabilitation floor.
One by one, personnel began leaving.
Security teams established positions.
Doctors returned to work.
Nurses resumed their routines.
Within minutes, the excitement faded.
Only the patient remained.
Arya stood outside Room 701.
Commander Aryan Sharma's room.
The file rested in her hands.
The corridor behind her was silent.
Slowly, she entered.
The room smelled faintly of antiseptic.
Monitors emitted steady rhythms.
Sunlight filtered through the large windows overlooking the city.
Aryan remained motionless.
Unconscious.
Completely unaware of his surroundings.
For several moments, Arya simply observed.
Professional assessment.
Nothing more.
The neurological reports.
The surgical records.

The rehabilitation projections.
Everything pointed toward a difficult recovery.
Months.
Possibly longer.
She opened the file again.
Read the first page.
Then another.
Then another.
The achievements were ridiculous.
Operational commendations.
Gallantry citations.
Special recognition awards.
Classified missions.
National security distinctions.
A career most officers spent entire lifetimes chasing.
Arya closed the file.
Her gaze returned to the unconscious man.
"You know what's strange?"
The question escaped before she realized she had spoken aloud.
The room remained silent.
"Everybody keeps talking about what you've done."
No response.
"Nobody talks about what it cost."
The machines continued their steady beeping.
For the first time all day, she didn't see a military officer.
Or a decorated commander.
Or a national hero.
She saw a patient.
And patients were easier to understand than heroes.
Because patients were honest.
Their injuries couldn't lie.
Their scars couldn't pretend.
Their pain couldn't be hidden behind medals.
Arya placed the file on the bedside table.
Then turned toward the door.
Before leaving, she stopped.
Just briefly.
Long enough to glance back once.
"You're not getting special treatment from me, Commander."
Her voice remained calm.
Professional.
Certain.
"You're just another patient."
Then she walked out.
The door closed behind her.
Inside the room, silence returned.
Neither Arya nor anyone else noticed the faint movement of Aryan's fingers beneath the blanket.
A movement so small it lasted less than a second.
But after six days of complete unconsciousness...
It was the first sign that Commander Aryan Sharma might finally be finding his way back.

Chapter 14

The Doctor Who Hated Heroes

Part III

The first sign appeared at 2:43 AM.
Nobody noticed it.
Not the nurse reviewing medication charts.
Not the security personnel stationed outside Room 701.
Not the monitoring systems continuously tracking every heartbeat.
Because the movement lasted less than a second.
A slight twitch.
Barely visible.
Then nothing.
The room returned to silence.
Outside, the hospital slept.
Or at least tried to.
Hospitals never truly slept.
Someone somewhere was always fighting for survival.
A nurse hurried through a corridor.
A surgeon completed an operation.
A family waited outside an ICU.
Life and death continued their endless dance.
And inside Room 701, Commander Aryan Sharma remained trapped somewhere in between.
Darkness surrounded him.
Not pain.
Not fear.
Just darkness.
Fragments drifted through the void.
Broken memories.
Disconnected sounds.
Pieces of conversations.
A woman's voice.
A man's laughter.
Gunfire.
Rain.
Fire.
Then silence again.
Nothing remained long enough to make sense.
Everything appeared and disappeared like smoke.
Far away, a monitor beeped.
The sound felt strangely familiar.
Steady.
Rhythmic.
Persistent.
Almost like someone knocking on a locked door.
Waiting.
Patiently.
Outside the room, another long shift had ended.

Arya finally emerged from surgery shortly after midnight.
Exhausted.
Hungry.
Mentally drained.
The emergency procedure had lasted nearly six hours.
Normally she would have gone home immediately.
Tonight she didn't.
For reasons she couldn't explain, her feet carried her toward the rehabilitation wing.
The hospital corridors were nearly empty now.
Only night-shift staff remained.
The atmosphere felt calmer.
Quieter.
More honest.
Without visitors and reporters, hospitals revealed their true nature after midnight.
Not buildings.
Not institutions.
Battlefields.
Thousands of invisible battles being fought simultaneously.
Some won.
Some lost.
Arya stopped outside Room 701.
She stared at the door.
Then immediately became annoyed with herself.
"What am I doing?"
There was no answer.
The patient was unconscious.
Nothing had changed.
Nothing would change until morning.
Yet after a moment, she opened the door anyway.
The room remained exactly as she had left it.
Machines.
Monitors.
Silence.
Aryan Sharma.
Unmoving.
The city lights glittered beyond the window behind him.
For several moments she simply stood there.
Then crossed the room and checked the charts.
Everything looked stable.
Neurological activity improving.
Vitals consistent.
Recovery progressing exactly as expected.
Good.
She should leave.
Instead she found herself studying the patient.
Again.
It irritated her.
Because the file and the reality refused to match.
Heroes weren't supposed to look like this.
The file described someone almost mythical.
One of the youngest operational commanders in the country.
Decorated officer.
Classified missions.

National-level asset.
The reality was a twenty-five-year-old man connected to machines.
Covered in scars.
Barely alive.
The contrast bothered her more than it should have.
A soft knock interrupted her thoughts.
She turned.
Ridhi stood in the doorway holding two coffees.
"You know this is becoming concerning."
Arya accepted the cup.
"What is?"
"You voluntarily spending time around military personnel."
"He's unconscious."
"Still counts."
Arya rolled her eyes.
Ridhi entered the room.
Her gaze immediately landed on Aryan.
Then the file.
Then Arya.
A smile slowly appeared.
"No."
Arya immediately understood.
"No."
Ridhi looked disappointed.
"I haven't even said anything."
"You don't need to."
Ridhi sighed dramatically.
"You're no fun."
They stood quietly for a few moments.
Then Ridhi spoke again.
This time more seriously.
"You know..."
Arya narrowed her eyes.
"That's usually how conversations begin."
Ridhi ignored the comment.
"I met someone today."
"What a shocking development."
"Rudra Rathore."
Arya paused.
The name sounded familiar.
Very familiar.
Then she remembered.
Second-in-command.
Alpha Team.
Mentioned repeatedly in the briefing documents.
"The friend?"
Ridhi nodded.
A strange smile appeared on her face.
Not her usual teasing smile.
Something softer.
Older.
More personal.
"We grew up together."

Arya immediately became suspicious.
"That's never a good sign."
"It was before he disappeared for years."
Now that was interesting.
Ridhi rarely spoke about her past.
"Then?"
"He joined the military."
Arya nodded slowly.
That explained enough.
For a moment neither spoke.
Then Ridhi looked toward Aryan.
"Apparently those two are impossible."
"What do you mean?"
"The team practically worships him."
Arya snorted.
"That's healthy."
"No."
Ridhi shook her head.
"You don't understand."
Her voice became thoughtful.
"They weren't talking about a commander."
Arya raised an eyebrow.
"They were talking about family."
The room grew quiet.
Ridhi stared at the unconscious man.
"One of the nurses said half the officers in the military hospital refused to leave during surgery."
Arya looked away.
She didn't like where this conversation was heading.
Because it humanized him.
And humanized people were harder to dislike.
Thankfully her pager saved her.
A new emergency consultation request appeared.
Arya immediately stood.
Duty first.
Always.
As she moved toward the door, Ridhi remained beside the window.
Watching the city.
Watching the patient.
Watching something Arya couldn't see.
The door closed behind her.
Silence returned.
Several minutes passed.
Then an hour.
Then another.
Around four in the morning, the night nurse entered Room 701 for a routine assessment.
Vitals.
Medication.
Documentation.
Everything appeared normal.
She noted the readings on her chart.
Prepared to leave.
Then froze.
Her eyes slowly lifted toward the monitor.

The neurological activity graph had changed.
Only slightly.
But enough.
The nurse stepped closer.
Checked again.
Then again.
A pulse of excitement shot through her.
Immediately she pressed the intercom.
"Neurology station, this is Room 701."
The response came instantly.
"Go ahead."
The nurse couldn't stop smiling.
"I think Commander Sharma just responded."
Silence.
Then—
"What?"
The nurse looked back toward the patient.
For the first time since arriving at the hospital, the neurological activity wasn't merely stable.
It was increasing.
Slowly.
Steadily.
As though someone was climbing toward the surface.
Far away from the machines.
Far away from the hospital.
Far away from the waiting doctors and worried soldiers...
Aryan Sharma heard a voice.
Faint.
Distant.
Almost impossible to understand.
Yet somehow familiar.
A woman's voice.
Calm.
Annoyed.
Stubborn.
"You're just another patient."
Darkness shifted.
Then—
A slight movement appeared beneath the blanket.
The nurse froze.
Her eyes immediately focused on his hand.
For a moment, nothing happened.
She wondered if she had imagined it.
Then it happened again.
A faint twitch.
Barely noticeable.
Gone almost instantly.
The nurse's heartbeat quickened.
She stepped closer.
Watching carefully.
Waiting.
Several seconds passed.
Then one finger moved again.
Only slightly.

An involuntary response.

Nothing more.

Yet after six days of complete stillness, it felt monumental.

The nurse immediately reached for the room phone.

"Neurology Station."

The response came seconds later.

"Go ahead."

She kept her eyes fixed on the patient.

"The neurological activity is increasing."

A pause.

"How much?"

"Not enough for consciousness."

She glanced toward the monitor.

"But definitely more than yesterday."

The nurse looked back at Aryan.

The patient remained unconscious.

Silent.

Unaware.

Still trapped somewhere beyond reach.

Yet something had changed.

Not in his mind.

Not yet.

But in his body.

For the first time since arriving at St. Thomas Hospital, it was no longer merely surviving.

It was responding.

Recovering.

Fighting.

The nurse slowly lowered the phone.

Outside the room, the hospital remained quiet.

Most doctors were asleep.

Most officers had gone home.

Most of the city knew nothing about the battle being fought behind a single hospital door.

But somewhere deep beneath the darkness of unconsciousness, Commander Aryan Sharma's body had finally begun pushing back.

And after six long days...

That was enough.

For now.

Chapter 15

Ghosts of Yesterday

Part I

Some reunions happened exactly the way people imagined them.

Warm smiles.

Happy tears.

Old memories returning like forgotten songs.

This wasn't one of those reunions.

Rudra Rathore stood outside Room 701, staring through the small glass panel on the door.

Inside, Aryan Sharma remained unconscious.

The machines continued their steady rhythm.

The room remained silent.

For a week now, this had become part of Rudra's routine.

Visit the hospital.

Check on Aryan.

Leave.

Come back again.

As if repeated visits alone could somehow force reality to make sense.

Because reality still felt wrong.

Aryan wasn't supposed to be lying in a hospital bed.

He was supposed to be giving orders.

Arguing with intelligence officers.

Destroying mission plans and rebuilding them from scratch.

Not this.

Never this.

Rudra folded his arms.

The corridor around him was unusually quiet.

Morning sunlight spilled through the large windows at the far end of the floor.

Doctors moved between rooms.

Nurses exchanged reports.

Everything looked normal.

Yet every time his eyes drifted toward Room 701, the illusion shattered.

Nothing about this was normal.

Nothing.

"Still staring at the door?"

The voice hit him like a bullet from the past.

For a second, he genuinely froze.

Not because of fear.

Because recognition arrived instantly.

Some voices never left you.

No matter how many years passed.

Slowly, Rudra turned around.

And suddenly five years disappeared.

Dr. Ridhi Kapoor stood a few feet away.

White coat.

Hospital ID card hanging around her neck.

A patient file tucked beneath one arm.

The same sharp eyes.
The same stubborn expression.
The same annoying ability to look directly through every lie he ever tried telling.
For a moment neither spoke.
Neither moved.
The world around them continued normally.
But for both of them, time seemed to pause.
The last time Ridhi had seen him, he was eighteen.
Reckless.
Loud.
Always smiling.
Always getting into trouble.
The man standing before her now looked nothing like that boy.
This version carried scars.
A faded mark across his jaw.
Another near his temple.
His posture had changed.
His eyes had changed.
Even the way he stood had changed.
Military life had taken the boy she once knew and returned someone harder.
Someone quieter.
Someone older than twenty-three had any right to be.
Meanwhile Rudra found himself studying her too.
Because the girl he remembered wasn't standing in front of him anymore either.
Life had changed her.
Not physically.
Something deeper.
A strength that hadn't existed before.
A sadness she tried hiding.
A maturity born from loss.
And suddenly, for reasons he couldn't explain, facing enemy gunfire felt easier than this conversation.
Five years.
Five years of operations.
Five years of war.
Five years of near-death experiences.
Yet seeing Ridhi Kapoor again somehow made him more nervous than entering hostile territory.
Ridhi finally broke the silence.
"Hello, Rudra."
Simple words.
But they carried the weight of half a decade.
Rudra cleared his throat.
"Hello, Ridhi."
Awkward.
Painfully awkward.
Neither knew what came next.
Because there were too many things left unsaid.
Too many questions.
Too many memories.
Fortunately, Ridhi was still Ridhi.
Which meant awkwardness never survived around her for long.
She tilted her head.
"You look terrible."
Rudra blinked.

"What?"

"You heard me."

She pointed toward the scar on his jaw.

"What happened there?"

Rudra touched it instinctively.

"Training accident."

"Liar."

"How do you know?"

"You were always terrible at lying."

He sighed.

"Explosion."

Ridhi stared.

"That's somehow worse."

"I know."

For the first time, a small laugh escaped both of them.

The sound felt strange.

Familiar.

Comfortable.

Dangerous.

Because laughter made it easier to forget the years between them.

For a few seconds, they almost looked like two old friends meeting after a long trip.

Then reality returned.

Ridhi's gaze shifted toward Room 701.

"How is he?"

Rudra followed her eyes.

Aryan.

Safe topic.

Good.

He preferred safe topics.

"The doctors say he's improving."

"Good."

"Yeah."

Silence returned.

Less awkward now.

More thoughtful.

Ridhi glanced toward the room again.

"The entire hospital talks about him."

Rudra smirked.

"I'm not surprised."

"They act like he's some kind of legend."

"He'd hate hearing that."

That earned another small laugh.

"Really?"

"Absolutely."

Rudra shook his head.

"If he woke up and heard half the things people say about him, he'd probably file complaints."

"Against who?"

"Everyone."

Ridhi laughed properly this time.

And for a brief moment, Rudra forgot how much he had missed hearing it.

Then came the dangerous part.

The moment both of them knew was coming.

Because some conversations couldn't be avoided forever.

Ridhi's smile slowly faded.
Not completely.
Just enough.
The atmosphere shifted.
Subtly.
Almost imperceptibly.
Yet Rudra felt it immediately.
She looked at him.
Not the soldier.
Not Aryan's teammate.
Just him.
And suddenly he knew.
The real conversation was finally beginning.
"Five years."
Her voice remained calm.
Too calm.
Rudra's stomach tightened.
"Ridhi—"
"No."
She shook her head.
Not angry.
Not yet.
"Five years."
The words hung between them.
Heavy.
Uncomfortable.
Real.
A nurse walked past.
Neither noticed.
A doctor entered another room.
Neither cared.
Because for the first time since their reunion, neither was pretending anymore.
Ridhi looked directly into his eyes.
And asked the one question that had waited half a decade.
"Where did you go, Rudra?"
The corridor seemed to fall silent.
Rudra opened his mouth.
Then closed it again.
Because despite everything he had survived...
Despite every mission.
Every battle.
Every impossible situation.
He still didn't know how to answer that question.
And somewhere deep inside, he realized something terrifying.
The conversation he had feared for five years...
Had only just begun.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 15

Ghosts of Yesterday

Part II

Rudra didn't answer immediately.
Because the truth wasn't simple.
And because some memories remained painful no matter how much time passed.
The corridor around them remained quiet.
Ridhi waited.
Patiently.
Silently.
For the first time in five years, she wasn't letting him escape.
"Where did you go, Rudra?"
The question came again.
Softer this time.
Yet somehow harder to ignore.
Rudra looked away.
Toward the hospital window.
Toward the city beyond it.
Anywhere except her.
Then he sighed.
Slowly.
Heavily.
"As far away as possible."
Ridhi frowned.
"What does that even mean?"
A bitter smile appeared on his face.
"It means I was a coward."
The answer surprised her.
Because it wasn't what she expected.
Not even close.
For years she had imagined dozens of possibilities.
Maybe he stopped caring.
Maybe he found someone else.
Maybe military life changed him.
Maybe she simply wasn't important enough.
But cowardice?
That possibility had never crossed her mind.
Before she could respond, Rudra spoke again.
"You remember the day before I left?"
Ridhi nodded slowly.
How could she forget?
The two of them had argued.
Nothing serious.
Just one of those stupid arguments couples have.
She had expected him to call the next day.
He never did.
"That evening," Rudra continued quietly, "your father came to meet me."

Ridhi froze.

"What?"

Rudra finally looked at her.

"The evening before I left."

For several seconds she simply stared at him.

Certain she had heard wrong.

"My father met you?"

He nodded.

"Alone."

The corridor suddenly felt much smaller.

The world seemed to narrow around those words.

Because her father had never mentioned that meeting.

Not once.

Not in all these years.

Rudra's gaze drifted away again.

And suddenly the hospital corridor disappeared.

Replaced by a memory.

Five years ago.

A small tea shop near the edge of town.

The sky had been dark.

Rain clouds gathering overhead.

Rudra had arrived expecting nothing unusual.

Then he saw him.

Ridhi's father.

Already waiting.

Already seated.

Already looking far more serious than usual.

The younger Rudra had immediately become nervous.

Because until then, their relationship had always been polite.

Respectful.

Comfortable.

That evening felt different.

Very different.

"Sit down."

The older man had spoken calmly.

Rudra obeyed.

For several moments neither said anything.

The silence stretched.

Then Ridhi's father finally looked at him.

"I know my daughter loves you."

Rudra remembered freezing instantly.

The words had arrived without warning.

No preparation.

No introduction.

Nothing.

The older man smiled faintly.

"Don't look so terrified."

But Rudra had been terrified.

Because suddenly the conversation felt far more important than anything he had expected.

The smile disappeared from the older man's face.

"And I know you love her too."

Silence.

Rudra never denied it.

Because there was nothing to deny.
The truth sat openly between them.
Then came the part he remembered most.
The part that never left him.
The older man looked out toward the road.
Toward the gathering storm.
And quietly said—
"Do you know what scares me?"
Rudra had shaken his head.
The answer came almost immediately.
"The military."
Present-day Ridhi stared at him.
Speechless.
Meanwhile Rudra continued.
"He wasn't angry."
His voice remained calm.
"He wasn't threatening me."
"He wasn't insulting me."
The memories felt vivid.
Painfully vivid.
"He was scared."
For the first time since the conversation began, Ridhi didn't interrupt.
Because she could already hear her father's voice in her mind.
Rudra swallowed.
Then continued.
"He told me he respected soldiers."
"He respected service."
"He respected sacrifice."
Another pause.
"But he said respect and fear aren't opposites."
The words landed heavily between them.
Because they sounded exactly like something her father would say.
Rudra laughed quietly.
Without humor.
"He asked me one question."
"What question?" Ridhi whispered.
Rudra looked directly at her.
Then repeated the words exactly as he remembered them.
"What happens to my daughter if one day men in uniform come to her door?"
Silence.
Absolute silence.
Ridhi couldn't move.
Couldn't speak.
Couldn't even look away.
Because suddenly she wasn't standing in a hospital corridor anymore.
She was hearing her father.
Actually hearing him.
The concern.
The fear.
The helplessness.
Everything.
Rudra continued quietly.
"He told me he'd already seen too many families destroyed."

"He told me he'd seen too many people waiting for calls that never came."

Another pause.

"He said he wasn't worried about me."

Ridhi's throat tightened.

"He was worried about you."

The corridor remained silent.

Neither moved.

Neither spoke.

Because suddenly five years of misunderstanding had begun unraveling.

Slowly.

Painfully.

And neither was prepared for where the truth was leading.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 15

Ghosts of Yesterday

Part III

For a long time, neither of them spoke.
The hospital corridor remained quiet.
Doctors passed by.
Nurses moved between rooms.
The world continued as if nothing had changed.
Yet for Ridhi, everything had.
Because for the first time in five years, she was hearing a version of the story she never knew existed.
"My father never told me."
The words escaped almost as a whisper.
Rudra nodded.
"I know."
"You never told me either."
This time he didn't answer immediately.
Because there was no defense.
No excuse.
No justification.
Only regret.
A lot of regret.
Ridhi folded her arms.
Trying to control the storm building inside her.
Part of her was angry.
Part of her was hurt.
Part of her didn't know what to feel anymore.
"So what happened next?"
Rudra looked toward the floor.
Toward memories he had spent years avoiding.
The tea shop.
The rain.
The conversation.
Everything remained painfully clear.
"He asked me to think."
Ridhi frowned.
"Think?"
"He said feelings weren't enough."
The words sounded strange now.
Yet back then they had carried enormous weight.
Rudra continued.
"He asked me whether I truly understood what military life meant."
His gaze drifted toward Room 701.
Toward Aryan.
Toward the reality of that life.
"He told me love is easy when everything is going well."
A bitter smile appeared.
"He asked whether I could guarantee your future."

Ridhi remained silent.
Because she already knew the answer.
Nobody could guarantee a future.
Especially not a soldier.
"He wasn't trying to separate us."
Rudra's voice remained calm.
"He wasn't threatening me."
Another pause.
"He was scared."
Those words hurt more than anything else.
Because Ridhi knew her father.
And she knew they were true.
The problem was...
That didn't make what happened next any easier to accept.
"So you left."
The words landed sharply.
Rudra closed his eyes briefly.
"Yes."
Ridhi stared at him.
Disbelief slowly turning into anger.
"That's it?"
"No."
"It sounds like that's it."
Her voice rose slightly.
For the first time since the conversation began, emotion finally broke through.
"You talked to my father once..."
She pointed toward him.
"...and then disappeared?"
Several people glanced toward them.
Neither noticed.
Because five years of pain was finally finding a voice.
"You didn't call."
Silence.
"You didn't text."
Silence.
"You didn't even say goodbye."
The anger in her voice grew stronger.
"And I'm supposed to accept that because my father was worried?"
Rudra absorbed every word.
Without interruption.
Without argument.
Because he knew she deserved them.
Every single one.
"You let someone else make the decision for me."
That sentence hit hardest.
Because it was true.
Painfully true.
Rudra looked away.
Unable to deny it.
"I thought I was doing the right thing."
Ridhi laughed.
A short broken laugh.
"The right thing?"

The hurt behind those words was impossible to miss.

"For who?"

Rudra had no answer.

Because at nineteen years old, he genuinely believed he was protecting her.

Now?

Now he wasn't so sure.

The silence stretched.

Heavy.

Uncomfortable.

Honest.

Finally Ridhi spoke again.

This time much quieter.

Which somehow felt worse.

"Do you know what hurt the most?"

Rudra's chest tightened.

Because something told him he wasn't ready for the answer.

Still, he nodded.

Ridhi smiled.

Not a happy smile.

The kind people wear after they've run out of tears.

"For two years..."

Her voice remained steady.

Barely.

"Every unknown number that called me..."

She looked away.

"...I answered."

Rudra froze.

"I thought maybe it was you."

The corridor disappeared.

The hospital disappeared.

Everything disappeared.

Leaving only those words.

"I kept thinking maybe you'd finally explain."

Another pause.

"Maybe you'd finally tell me what happened."

Ridhi laughed softly.

Without humor.

"Do you know how pathetic that feels?"

Rudra couldn't speak.

Couldn't move.

Because suddenly every battlefield he had survived felt insignificant compared to this moment.

"Every time my phone rang..."

She swallowed.

"...I hoped."

The word shattered something inside him.

Because hope was cruel.

And he had unknowingly left her carrying it for years.

Then came the final blow.

The one sentence he would remember for the rest of his life.

"I thought you were dead, Rudra."

Silence.

Absolute silence.

For the first time since the conversation began, Rudra felt completely defenseless.

No training could help here.
No strategy.
No mission plan.
Nothing.
Because there was no way to undo five years.
No way to erase that pain.
No way to give back the time she lost waiting.
Finally Ridhi took a step backward.
The anger was gone.
Only exhaustion remained.
Years of exhaustion.
Years of unanswered questions.
Years of closure she never received.
"I don't know what's worse."
Her eyes met his.
"The fact that you left..."
A pause.
"...or the fact that you thought I wasn't strong enough to choose for myself."
The words landed harder than any accusation.
Because deep down...
Rudra knew she was right.
Completely right.
Neither spoke.
Neither looked away.
Then a hospital announcement echoed through the corridor.
Breaking the moment.
Bringing reality back.
Ridhi looked toward the ceiling briefly.
Then back at him.
For the first time since seeing him again, her voice softened.
Just slightly.
"My father wasn't the problem."
Rudra frowned.
"What?"
"He was scared."
A sad smile appeared.
"And honestly..."
She looked toward Room 701.
Toward the unconscious commander lying beyond the door.
"...after seeing what military life does to people..."
Her eyes returned to him.
"...I understand why."
For several seconds neither moved.
Then Ridhi adjusted the file in her hands.
Professional mask returning once again.
Not because the conversation was over.
Because it wasn't.
Not even close.
But because some wounds couldn't heal in a single day.
Some truths needed time.
The same way scars needed time.
The same way forgiveness needed time.
She stepped backward.

Slowly.
Then turned.
And began walking down the corridor.
This time Rudra didn't stop her.
Because for the first time in five years...
She finally knew the truth.
And somehow that truth hurt both of them far more than the lie ever had.
At the end of the corridor, Ridhi paused.
Just for a moment.
Without turning around, she spoke.
Quietly.
"So..."
Rudra looked up.
A faint smile touched her face.
Barely visible.
"You're still terrible at making decisions."
And for the first time that day...
A genuine smile appeared on Rudra's face.
Small.
Tired.
But real.
As Ridhi disappeared around the corner, he leaned against the wall and exhaled slowly.
The conversation wasn't over.
The damage wasn't repaired.
The years weren't forgotten.
But for the first time in a very long time...
There was hope.
And sometimes...
Hope was enough.

Chapter 16

The Man Between Darkness And Dawn

Part I

The first person to notice the change wasn't a doctor.

It wasn't a neurologist.

It wasn't even a military officer monitoring Aryan's condition.

It was a nurse.

A young nurse named Kavya who had been assigned to the rehabilitation wing for the past four days.

At exactly 6:17 AM, she stopped outside Room 701 carrying the morning medication reports.

Nothing seemed unusual.

The corridor was quiet.

The hospital was only beginning to wake up.

Night-shift nurses exchanged reports with the incoming staff.

Doctors reviewed schedules.

Patients slowly emerged from sleep.

Everything appeared normal.

Until she looked through the glass panel.

And froze.

The monitor beside Aryan's bed displayed a number she had never seen before.

Not alarming.

Not dangerous.

Just... different.

Kavya frowned.

Then entered the room.

The machines continued their steady rhythm.

Morning sunlight filtered through the curtains.

Commander Aryan Sharma remained unconscious.

Yet something felt different.

The room no longer carried the same lifeless atmosphere it had during previous days.

It felt...

Active.

As if recovery itself had finally begun moving forward.

She approached the monitor.

Reviewed the readings.

Then checked them again.

The neurological activity had increased.

Not significantly.

Not enough to indicate consciousness.

But enough to attract attention.

Enough to make experienced doctors take notice.

A smile appeared on her face.

Small.

But genuine.

Because progress was progress.

No matter how small.

Especially in cases like this.

She quickly noted the changes in her report.

By 7:00 AM, the information had already reached the neurology department.

By 7:30, it reached the hospital administration.

And by 8:00, half the rehabilitation wing knew about it.

Hospitals operated that way.

Good news traveled almost as fast as bad news.

Almost.

At 8:15 AM, Arya entered the hospital.

Coffee in one hand.

Patient files in the other.

The beginning of another exhausting day.

Nothing unusual.

At least until she noticed the atmosphere.

People looked... optimistic.

Which immediately made her suspicious.

Optimistic hospital staff usually meant paperwork.

Or trouble.

Sometimes both.

She stepped into the doctors' station.

Three nurses were already discussing something.

The moment Arya appeared, they stopped.

That alone was suspicious.

"What happened?"

Nobody answered immediately.

The nurses exchanged glances.

Then one finally spoke.

"Room 701."

Arya sighed.

Of course.

The military patient.

What else could it be?

"What about him?"

"The neurological activity increased overnight."

Arya paused.

Only briefly.

But she paused.

"By how much?"

The nurse handed over a report.

Arya scanned the numbers.

Then scanned them again.

Interesting.

Very interesting.

Because the improvement wasn't random.

There was a pattern.

A progression.

The kind doctors hoped to see.

Not the kind they expected.

A second nurse smiled.

"Looks like he's finally turning a corner."

Arya handed the report back.

"Maybe."

The response sounded indifferent.

Professional.

Detached.

Exactly how she wanted it to sound.
Unfortunately, the nurses knew her too well.
"You look relieved."
Arya immediately frowned.
"I do not."
"You do."
"I don't."
"You absolutely do."
Arya grabbed her coffee.
"Find better hobbies."
The nurses laughed.
Arya walked away before the conversation could continue.
Ignoring them was easier.
Mostly because they weren't entirely wrong.
Around the same time, another update reached a completely different location.
A military guest house on the opposite side of the city.
Temporary residence of Alpha Team.
The team had been ordered to take leave.
Officially.
None of them were happy about it.
Years of military operations had destroyed their ability to relax.
The result was predictable.
Half the team spent their leave training anyway.
The other half spent it annoying each other.
This morning was no different.
Until Rudra's phone rang.
The room immediately became silent.
Because everyone recognized the hospital number.
Rudra answered instantly.
"Rudra speaking."
A brief pause followed.
The voice on the other side explained the update.
Neurological improvement.
Increased response.
Positive recovery indicators.
Nothing dramatic.
Nothing definitive.
But good news nonetheless.
The moment the call ended, six pairs of eyes stared at him.
Waiting.
Hopeful.
Nervous.
Rudra looked at them.
Then smiled.
The tension vanished immediately.
"He's improving."
Relief exploded across the room.
Not loud.
Not dramatic.
Just visible.
Shoulders relaxed.
Expressions softened.
Breaths released.

For days they had carried the same fear.
The same uncertainty.
The same helplessness.
Now, for the first time, things finally seemed to be moving in the right direction.
One of the younger operators leaned back against the couch.
"Told you he'd be fine."
Another laughed.
"You were literally crying three days ago."
"I was not."
"You absolutely were."
"I had dust in my eyes."
"We were indoors."
"Shut up."
Laughter filled the room.
Real laughter.
The first genuine laughter in days.
Rudra listened quietly.
Saying nothing.
Because unlike the others, he understood something important.
This wasn't victory.
Not yet.
Aryan was still unconscious.
Still recovering.
Still fighting a battle none of them could fight for him.
But for the first time...
The battle no longer felt one-sided.
Back at St. Thomas Hospital, Arya finally entered Room 701.
The room was silent.
Just as before.
The machines continued their steady rhythm.
The morning light illuminated the bed.
And there he was.
Still unconscious.
Still motionless.
Still somehow the center of everyone's attention.
Arya reviewed the latest reports.
Then approached the bedside.
Carefully.
Professionally.
Objectively.
The same way she approached every patient.
Nothing more.
Nothing less.
She checked the monitors.
Reviewed oxygen levels.
Heart activity.
Neurological readings.
Everything looked stable.
Encouragingly stable.
Then she performed a standard response assessment.
Routine procedure.
Nothing unusual.
She lightly adjusted his wrist position.

Preparing for the examination.
And suddenly—
His fingers moved.
Arya froze.
The movement lasted less than a second.
Small.
Controlled.
Gone almost immediately.
But she had seen it.
Clearly.
Her eyes narrowed.
She repeated the assessment.
Carefully.
Patiently.
Waiting.
Several moments passed.
Nothing happened.
Then once again—
A faint muscular response.
Not enough to indicate consciousness.
Not enough to wake him.
Yet stronger than a reflex.
Stronger than previous recordings.
Arya slowly straightened.
For the first time since taking over his treatment...
Her professional curiosity finally outweighed her personal prejudice.
She looked down at the unconscious commander.
Studying him.
Evaluating him.
Questioning assumptions she didn't even realize she had made.
The file had called him exceptional.
The military called him irreplaceable.
The country called him a hero.
Arya had dismissed all of it.
But the evidence sitting before her refused to cooperate.
Most patients with comparable injuries recovered far more slowly.
Yet somehow...
This one kept fighting.
Even while unconscious.
Even while broken.
Even while trapped somewhere beyond awareness.
For a brief moment, Arya found herself wondering the same question everyone else seemed to ask.
What kind of person was Aryan Sharma?
And why did it feel like she was only seeing the smallest fraction of the answer?
To Be Continued...

Chapter 16

The Man Between Darkness And Dawn

Part II

By evening, the entire hospital had settled into its usual rhythm.

Doctors moved between departments.

Patients received visitors.

Machines continued their endless work.

And somewhere on the seventh floor, Room 701 remained under constant observation.

Arya had spent most of the day pretending she wasn't curious.

Unfortunately, curiosity was becoming increasingly difficult to ignore.

The reports sat open on her desk.

Neurological charts.

Recovery projections.

Medical assessments.

She had reviewed them three times already.

Then reviewed them again.

Every number pointed toward the same conclusion.

Aryan Sharma's recovery was progressing faster than expected.

Not impossibly fast.

Not miraculously fast.

Just enough to make experienced doctors raise their eyebrows.

And Arya was a very experienced doctor.

A soft knock interrupted her thoughts.

Ridhi entered without waiting for permission.

Which was typical.

"You've been staring at those reports for twenty minutes."

Arya didn't look up.

"No, I haven't."

"You absolutely have."

"I've been working."

Ridhi sat down opposite her.

"On the same page?"

Arya finally looked up.

The expression on her face immediately made Ridhi grin.

"Oh no."

"What?"

"You're interested."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"I'm really not."

Ridhi pointed toward the reports.

"You've officially entered the research phase."

Arya sighed.

"I hate talking to you."

"No, you don't."

Unfortunately, Ridhi was right.

As usual.

Arya leaned back in her chair.
For several moments neither spoke.
Then Ridhi's expression softened.
"The team visited today."
Arya frowned.
"Alpha Team?"
Ridhi nodded.
"They weren't allowed inside."
Hospital policy.
Only limited personnel access.
Still, the information caught Arya's attention.
"How were they?"
The answer came immediately.
"Worried."
That single word lingered.
Because it matched what she had observed herself.
Every military officer visiting the hospital displayed the same reaction.
Respect.
Concern.
Loyalty.
The kind usually reserved for family.
Not commanders.
Family.
Arya found herself remembering something from Aryan's file.
A note written by one of the military psychologists.
Short.
Simple.
Yet strangely revealing.
Leadership through trust rather than authority.
At the time she had ignored it.
Now she wasn't so sure.
The conversation ended when her pager vibrated.
Room 701.
Routine assessment.
Arya grabbed the file and stood.
Ridhi smiled knowingly.
"I'm saying nothing."
"Good."
"But we're both thinking it."
Arya pointed toward the door.
"Leave."
Ridhi laughed all the way down the corridor.
Twenty minutes later, Arya entered Room 701.
The room remained quiet.
Peaceful.
The setting sun painted golden reflections across the walls.
For a moment, everything felt strangely calm.
Aryan remained unconscious.
Unmoving.
The machines beside him continued their steady rhythm.
Arya began her examination.
Blood pressure.
Oxygen levels.

Neurological response.
Everything appeared stable.
Again.
Encouragingly stable.
After recording the readings, she reached for the patient file resting beside the bed.
Originally she intended to review only the medical section.
Nothing else.
Unfortunately, curiosity had different plans.
Her eyes drifted toward another page.
Then another.
Then another.
Soon she found herself reading details unrelated to treatment.
Operational history.
Training evaluations.
Service records.
Classified sections.
Most remained heavily redacted.
Entire paragraphs blacked out.
Entire operations erased from public existence.
Yet enough remained visible to paint a picture.
And the picture didn't make sense.
Arya frowned.
Twenty-five years old.
Twenty-five.
She checked again.
Still twenty-five.
The operational record looked more appropriate for someone fifteen years older.
She turned another page.
Advanced warfare qualifications.
Mountain operations.
Hostage rescue certification.
Counter-terror training.
Special reconnaissance.
Language proficiency.
Joint command evaluations.
The list seemed endless.
"What exactly have you been doing?"
The question escaped before she realized it.
The unconscious patient, unsurprisingly, didn't answer.
Arya continued reading.
Then stopped.
One particular section caught her attention.
Injury history.
Her eyes narrowed.
The list was absurd.
Fractures.
Shrapnel wounds.
Concussions.
Burn injuries.
Surgical interventions.
Each entry represented a moment that could have ended differently.
A moment that could have ended everything.
Slowly, Arya looked up from the file.

Toward the man lying silently before her.
For the first time, she wasn't seeing a decorated officer.
Or a military symbol.
Or even a patient.
She was seeing something much simpler.
A human being.
A twenty-five-year-old who had spent years repeatedly putting himself in situations most people would spend their entire lives avoiding.
And suddenly she understood something.
Not admiration.
Not respect.
Understanding.
There was a difference.
For years she had blamed the uniform.
Blamed the system.
Blamed the military.
But sitting here now, looking at page after page of injuries and sacrifices...
She found herself asking a question she had avoided for a very long time.
What kind of person willingly chooses this life?
The answer never came.
Only silence.
The soft rhythm of the monitors.
The fading sunlight.
And a growing realization that perhaps her assumptions had never been as complete as she believed.
Slowly, Arya closed the file.
Her gaze remained fixed on Aryan.
The scars.
The bandages.
The evidence of battles nobody outside the military would ever know about.
Then, almost unconsciously, she spoke.
Quietly.
More to herself than anyone else.
"What kind of life have you lived, Commander?"
The room remained silent.
Yet somehow...
For the first time since taking over his treatment, Arya genuinely wanted to know.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 16

The Man Between Darkness And Dawn

Part III

The hospital looked different at night.

Quieter.

Softer.

Almost honest.

The endless noise of the day slowly faded away.

Visitors left.

Corridors emptied.

Doctors changed shifts.

The city outside transformed into a sea of distant lights.

And somewhere on the seventh floor, Room 701 remained illuminated by the soft glow of medical monitors.

Arya stood inside the room alone.

Her shift had technically ended forty minutes ago.

Unfortunately, medicine rarely cared about schedules.

Neither did curiosity.

She glanced toward the clock.

Then toward the patient.

Then immediately became annoyed with herself.

Because she had already checked his condition twice in the last hour.

There was absolutely no reason for a third visit.

Yet here she was.

Again.

The machines continued their steady rhythm.

Heart rate stable.

Oxygen levels normal.

Neurological activity gradually improving.

Everything looked encouraging.

By all medical standards, Aryan Sharma was progressing exactly the way doctors hoped.

The problem was that Arya had started wanting answers.

And unconscious patients were notoriously bad at answering questions.

She moved toward the window.

Outside, the city stretched endlessly beneath the night sky.

Millions of people.

Millions of lives.

Most completely unaware that an entire military task force had spent the last week worrying about a single man.

The thought lingered.

Because she still couldn't understand it.

Not fully.

The concern felt different.

Too personal.

Too emotional.

Military organizations respected capability.

That was expected.

But this?

This looked closer to affection.

Family.
Loyalty.
Something deeper.
A soft knock interrupted her thoughts.
The door opened.
Ridhi stepped inside carrying two coffees.
Arya didn't even look surprised.
"You know normal people go home after work."
Ridhi handed over a cup.
"You know normal people don't visit the same patient three times in one hour."
Arya accepted the coffee.
Then immediately regretted it.
Because Ridhi's grin became even wider.
"Oh, this is getting good."
"It isn't."
"It absolutely is."
"No."
"You're interested."
Arya took a sip.
"I'm a doctor."
"That's not what I meant."
Unfortunately, both of them knew it.
Before Arya could respond, a nurse hurried into the room.
Her expression immediately erased any chance of continuing the conversation.
"Doctor Mehra."
Arya turned.
"What happened?"
"The neurological monitor."
Instantly, her attention sharpened.
"What about it?"
The nurse pointed toward the screen.
Arya's eyes followed.
Then narrowed.
The readings had changed.
Not dramatically.
Not dangerously.
But noticeably.
A small increase.
Then another.
Then another.
The pattern continued.
Slow.
Consistent.
Purposeful.
Arya immediately moved closer.
Reviewing every detail.
Every fluctuation.
Every response.
For several moments nobody spoke.
Then Ridhi quietly asked,
"Good?"
Arya didn't answer immediately.
Because she wanted to be certain.

Only after reviewing the data again did she respond.
"Very good."
The nurse smiled.
Relief spreading across her face.
Arya remained focused on the monitor.
Because something about the readings felt different from previous improvements.
This wasn't random neurological activity.
This wasn't passive recovery.
This felt deliberate.
As if the body itself had begun actively fighting its way back.
The realization sent a strange feeling through the room.
Hope.
Carefully controlled hope.
But hope nonetheless.
Then suddenly—
The bedsheet moved.
Everyone froze.
Arya's head snapped toward the bed.
The nurse stopped breathing.
Even Ridhi went silent.
For one brief second, nothing happened.
Then it happened again.
This time stronger.
Clearer.
Aryan's right hand tightened around the bedsheet.
Not a twitch.
Not a reflex.
A grip.
Weak.
Brief.
But unmistakable.
The nurse stared.
"Did you—"
"Yes."
Arya's answer came instantly.
Because she had seen it too.
The room fell silent.
Nobody moved.
Nobody looked away.
Every eye remained fixed on the unconscious commander.
Several seconds passed.
Then the hand relaxed again.
The movement disappeared.
Returning to stillness.
Yet the atmosphere had completely changed.
Because everyone in the room understood exactly what they had witnessed.
Progress.
Real progress.
The strongest sign yet.
Arya immediately checked the monitors again.
The neurological activity had spiked.
Not dangerously.
Not abnormally.

But significantly.
Enough to make her heartbeat quicken.
Enough to make years of medical experience pay attention.
Ridhi looked toward her.
"What does it mean?"
Arya continued studying the readings.
Professional.
Focused.
Careful.
Only after several moments did she answer.
"It means..."
She paused.
Choosing her words carefully.
Because medicine never guaranteed outcomes.
Never promised miracles.
Never dealt in certainty.
Yet some moments spoke for themselves.
Finally, she looked toward the unconscious patient.
Then toward the monitor.
Then back again.
And quietly said,
"It means he's fighting his way back."
Silence followed.
Nobody spoke.
Nobody needed to.
Because the evidence was already there.
In the monitors.
In the movement.
In the steady progression that had continued for days.
For the first time since the explosion...
The battle was turning.
And somewhere beyond the darkness of unconsciousness...
Commander Aryan Sharma seemed to be winning.
The monitor continued its steady rhythm.
The city lights glittered beyond the window.
And for the first time in over a week...
The future no longer felt uncertain.
It felt close.
Very close.

End of Chapter 16

Chapter 17

The Awakening

Part I

At 4:12 AM, Room 701 was silent.
The hospital slept.
Or at least tried to.
Night shifts continued.
Emergency cases arrived.
Machines hummed endlessly through the darkness.
Life and death never followed schedules.
Neither did recovery.
A single monitor emitted its steady rhythm beside the hospital bed.
Heart rate stable.
Blood pressure normal.
Neurological activity higher than it had been all week.
The signs were encouraging.
But nobody expected what happened next.
Not tonight.
Not yet.
The night nurse sat outside the room reviewing patient reports when a notification appeared on her tablet.
Room 701.
Neurological fluctuation.
Not dangerous.
Not critical.
Just unusual.
The nurse frowned.
Then stood immediately.
A few moments later she entered the room.
The lights remained dim.
The city beyond the windows glittered beneath the darkness.
Everything appeared normal.
At first.
Then she noticed it.
A slight movement.
Barely visible.
Aryan's hand shifted against the bedsheet.
Not a reflex.
Not a twitch.
An actual movement.
The nurse's eyes widened.
Slowly she approached the bed.
Watching carefully.
Waiting.
For several seconds nothing happened.
Then his fingers curled slightly.
Again.
The nurse immediately reached for her radio.

"Neurology Station, this is Room 701."

The response arrived instantly.

"Go ahead."

"We have increased voluntary movement."

Silence.

Then:

"Repeat that."

The nurse kept watching the patient.

"I said voluntary movement."

Within minutes the information spread through the rehabilitation wing.

Doctors were notified.

Neurologists alerted.

Medical teams prepared.

Because everyone understood the significance.

After ten days of unconsciousness...

This was the strongest sign yet.

Half an hour later, Arya entered the room.

Still carrying coffee.

Still looking annoyed at being awake before sunrise.

Some things never changed.

The moment she stepped inside, however, her attention shifted completely.

The reports had not exaggerated.

The neurological readings were elevated.

Significantly elevated.

Arya reviewed the monitor.

Then reviewed it again.

Interesting.

Very interesting.

The brain activity patterns looked different.

Less passive.

More responsive.

Almost as though something beneath the surface had begun moving.

The unconscious mind fighting its way upward.

She moved toward the bedside.

Professional.

Focused.

Calm.

Exactly as always.

Yet somewhere deep down, she felt something unfamiliar.

Anticipation.

For the first time since meeting this patient...

She genuinely believed he might wake up.

Soon.

Very soon.

Arya checked his pupil responses.

Then neurological reflexes.

Everything looked promising.

Then suddenly—

His eyelids moved.

Arya froze.

Only for a fraction of a second.

But she froze.

The movement was small.

Extremely small.
Yet impossible to miss.
The eyelids trembled.
Then became still again.
Arya's heart rate increased slightly.
Professional curiosity.
Nothing more.
At least that's what she told herself.
She continued the examination.
Patiently.
Carefully.
Waiting.
Several moments passed.
Nothing happened.
Then—
The movement returned.
Stronger this time.
A faint reaction beneath closed eyes.
The neurological monitor immediately responded.
The readings jumped.
Not dramatically.
But enough.
Enough to make every doctor in the room pay attention.
One of the neurologists glanced toward Arya.
"You seeing this?"
"Yes."
The answer came instantly.
Nobody spoke afterward.
Because all attention remained focused on the patient.
The room felt different now.
Charged.
Expectant.
Like standing outside a door moments before it opened.
Somewhere beyond the darkness, Aryan heard a sound.
Faint.
Distant.
Unclear.
Like an echo traveling through water.
Then another.
Voices.
Several voices.
Impossible to understand.
Fragments only.
Nothing complete.
Nothing meaningful.
Pain followed.
Not sharp.
Not overwhelming.
Just present.
Everywhere.
His body felt heavy.
Unresponsive.
As though he had been asleep for years instead of days.

The darkness around him shifted.
For the first time, it didn't feel endless.
Somewhere ahead, something existed.
Light.
Small.
Distant.
Yet real.
The closer he moved toward it, the clearer the sounds became.
Machines.
Footsteps.
Voices.
A woman's voice.
Calm.
Professional.
Slightly irritated.
For reasons he couldn't understand, that voice stood out more than the others.
The darkness shifted again.
Then cracked.
Just slightly.
Inside Room 701, the monitors suddenly reacted.
Neurological activity increased.
Again.
Then again.
The pattern continued.
Steady.
Consistent.
Purposeful.
Arya stared at the screen.
Then toward the patient.
Then back again.
Years of medical experience told her exactly what she was witnessing.
The process had begun.
Not consciousness.
Not yet.
But the final stage before it.
The body was responding.
The brain was responding.
Everything was moving in the right direction.
Slowly.
Relentlessly.
Like a soldier refusing to quit.
The thought annoyed her.
Mostly because it felt accurate.
A faint smile appeared on one of the neurologists' faces.
"We're close."
Nobody disagreed.
Because they all knew it.
After ten days of uncertainty...
After ten days of waiting...
After ten days of fighting a battle nobody else could fight for him...
Commander Aryan Sharma was finally approaching the surface.
And for the first time since the explosion...
Waking up no longer felt like a possibility.

It felt inevitable.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 17

The Awakening

Part II

By sunrise, half the hospital already knew something had changed.

Not officially.

Hospitals rarely worked that way.

Information simply traveled.

A nurse told another nurse.

A doctor mentioned it during rounds.

Someone overheard a conversation.

Within hours, everyone on the seventh floor knew that the military officer in Room 701 was showing strong signs of waking up.

Inside the room, however, the atmosphere remained controlled.

Professional.

Careful.

Nobody wanted to celebrate too early.

Arya stood near the monitors, reviewing the latest neurological readings. Every update looked better than the last. Brain activity continued increasing steadily, and for the first time since the explosion, the recovery curve was matching the most optimistic projections.

A senior neurologist walked over and studied the screen.

"How long do you think?"

Arya didn't answer immediately.

"Could be hours."

The doctor nodded.

"Could be."

A brief silence followed.

Then he smiled slightly.

"Looks like your patient is too stubborn to stay unconscious."

Arya rolled her eyes.

"He's not my patient."

The neurologist laughed.

"Of course."

Before Arya could respond, movement on the bed caught everyone's attention.

Aryan's hand shifted again.

This time stronger than before.

The fingers curled.

Then relaxed.

The monitor reacted immediately.

Nobody said a word.

The signs were becoming impossible to ignore.

Whatever barrier existed between consciousness and unconsciousness was beginning to collapse.

Across the city, Alpha Team was having breakfast when Rudra's phone rang again.

The moment he saw the hospital number, the entire table went silent.

He answered immediately.

The update lasted less than a minute.

When the call ended, nobody spoke.

Every member of the team was staring at him.

Waiting.
Rudra slowly lowered the phone.
A smile appeared on his face.
A real one.
The first in weeks.
"Get ready."
The reaction was instant.
Chairs moved.
People stood.
Expressions changed.
One of the operators looked confused.
"Ready for what?"
Rudra grabbed his jacket.
"He's waking up."
For a second, absolute silence filled the room.
Then chaos erupted.
Nobody tried hiding their excitement.
Not even a little.
Years of discipline disappeared instantly.
Questions flew from every direction.
"When?"
"Did they confirm it?"
"Can we go now?"
"How long?"
Rudra shook his head.
"I don't know."
That was the truth.
Nobody knew.
But after everything that had happened, uncertainty finally felt different.
It no longer felt hopeless.
Back in Room 701, Aryan's world was changing.
The darkness that had surrounded him for days was fading.
Slowly.
Painfully.
But fading.
Sounds became clearer.
Voices became easier to understand.
The distant beeping that had followed him through the darkness now sounded familiar.
Close.
Real.
His body still felt impossibly heavy.
Every movement demanded effort.
Every thought felt slow.
Yet awareness was returning.
Piece by piece.
Somewhere nearby, people were speaking.
Doctors.
Nurses.
He couldn't understand every word.
Only fragments.
Recovery.
Response.
Stable.

Neurological activity.
The words drifted in and out of focus.
Then another voice appeared.
A familiar voice.
Calm.
Confident.
Slightly annoyed.
For reasons he couldn't explain, he focused on it immediately.
Arya.
Though he didn't know her name yet.
Only the voice.
The same voice he had heard repeatedly through the darkness.
The same voice that seemed to appear whenever someone discussed his condition.
The same voice that somehow sounded irritated even while helping people.
Strange.
Very strange.
Arya was updating a chart when she noticed something.
His breathing pattern had changed.
Subtly.
But enough.
Her attention immediately sharpened.
The neurological readings climbed again.
Another increase.
Then another.
The senior neurologist stepped closer.
"So?"
Arya looked at the monitor.
Then at the patient.
Then back again.
Her answer was quiet.
"Now."
The doctor frowned.
"What?"
Arya didn't take her eyes off Aryan.
"Now."
The room instantly became alert.
Every doctor moved closer.
Every nurse focused on the bed.
The atmosphere shifted completely.
Nobody spoke.
Nobody wanted to interrupt what was happening.
Because after ten days of waiting, the moment had finally arrived.
Aryan's eyelids moved.
Once.
Twice.
A third time.
The effort seemed enormous.
Like lifting a mountain.
His brow tightened slightly.
Muscles reacted.
The monitor responded.
One of the nurses unconsciously held her breath.
Then—

His eyes opened.
Only partially.
Blurred.
Unfocused.
Confused.
The bright hospital lights immediately forced them shut again.
But it was enough.
More than enough.
The room exploded into activity.
Doctors began speaking.
Nurses updated readings.
Monitors were checked.
Assessments started immediately.
Arya remained standing beside the bed.
Watching carefully.
The patient who had spent ten days trapped in darkness had finally returned.
Several seconds later, his eyes opened again.
This time longer.
Still blurry.
Still unfocused.
But open.
His gaze drifted across the room.
Machines.
Lights.
White ceiling.
Unknown faces.
Nothing made sense.
Then his eyes settled on Arya.
For a moment neither spoke.
Neither moved.
Arya immediately switched into professional mode.
"Can you hear me?"
A pause.
Aryan stared at her.
Trying to process the question.
Trying to process reality itself.
His throat felt dry.
His entire body ached.
Speaking felt impossible.
Yet somehow he managed it.
Barely.
His voice emerged rough and broken.
"...unfortunately."
The room fell silent.
Arya blinked.
One nurse nearly choked trying not to laugh.
The senior neurologist looked away immediately.
Arya stared at him for several seconds.
Then slowly folded her arms.
"Great."
The room waited.
Arya sighed.
"He's conscious."

A pause.

Then she added,

"And already annoying."

For the first time in ten days, a faint smirk appeared on Aryan Sharma's face.

And somewhere across the city, Alpha Team was already racing toward the hospital.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 17

The Awakening

Part III

News traveled fast.

Especially inside military circles.

By the time Aryan had been conscious for fifteen minutes, three different commands already knew about it.

By the time thirty minutes passed, Alpha Team had broken at least six traffic laws getting to the hospital.

Officially, nobody acknowledged that.

Unofficially, nobody cared.

The moment the elevator doors opened on the seventh floor, seven operators stepped out.

Combat veterans.

Special forces personnel.

Men who had walked through gunfire without hesitation.

Yet at this moment, every single one of them looked nervous.

Rudra led the group.

His expression remained calm.

At least on the surface.

Inside, however, was a completely different story.

For ten days he had watched his brother fight a battle he couldn't help him win.

For ten days he had sat outside hospital rooms.

Answered questions.

Given updates.

Pretended everything would be fine.

Now the waiting was finally over.

A nurse intercepted them before they reached Room 701.

"Only two visitors."

Seven disappointed expressions appeared instantly.

The nurse didn't care.

Hospital policy was hospital policy.

After a brief argument and several failed attempts at negotiation, Rudra and another team member were finally allowed inside.

The rest remained outside.

Complaining loudly.

As expected.

Inside Room 701, Aryan was discovering that being alive hurt.

A lot.

Every muscle in his body felt like it had been run over by a tank.

His head throbbed.

His vision remained slightly blurred.

Even breathing felt unnecessarily complicated.

The doctors had explained everything.

Recovery.

Observation.

Rehabilitation.

Rest.

Aryan hated every word.

Especially the last one.

Rest.
It sounded suspiciously like doing nothing.
And Aryan Sharma was very bad at doing nothing.
Arya stood nearby reviewing charts.
Occasionally checking his vitals.
Occasionally making sure he wasn't secretly trying to escape.
Which honestly felt like a reasonable concern.
The door opened.
Aryan glanced toward it.
And froze.
Rudra stood there.
For a second, neither spoke.
Neither moved.
The room suddenly felt much quieter.
Arya noticed the change immediately.
So did everyone else.
Because this wasn't simply a commander and his subordinate.
This was something deeper.
Something built over years.
Years of missions.
Years of trust.
Years of surviving things neither of them should have survived.
Rudra stared at the hospital bed.
At the bandages.
At the injuries.
At the proof that he had almost lost someone important.
Then he smirked.
"You look terrible."
Aryan's response came immediately.
Weak.
Exhausted.
But unmistakably Aryan.
"You're one to talk."
The tension shattered.
A laugh escaped Rudra before he could stop it.
Even Arya looked away to hide a smile.
Because somehow that exchange felt completely normal.
As if ten days hadn't happened.
As if near death hadn't happened.
As if this was just another day.
Rudra pulled a chair beside the bed.
For several moments neither spoke.
They didn't need to.
The silence itself carried meaning.
Finally Aryan looked at him.
"Team?"
Rudra already knew that would be the first question.
Not family.
Not injuries.
Not himself.
The team.
"Fine."
"Everyone?"

"Everyone."

Aryan relaxed slightly.

A small change.

Almost invisible.

Yet Rudra noticed it immediately.

Only then did Aryan ask the second question.

"Mission?"

The room became quiet.

Much quieter than before.

Rudra's expression changed.

Only slightly.

But enough.

Aryan noticed.

Years of operational experience made him notice.

"What happened?"

Rudra glanced toward the door.

Then toward Arya.

The doctors.

The nurses.

Too many people.

Too many ears.

Before he could answer, another voice interrupted.

"Commander Sharma."

Everyone turned.

A military intelligence officer stood in the doorway.

Dark suit.

Official credentials.

Serious expression.

The kind expression that usually meant paperwork.

Or problems.

Most often both.

Aryan immediately recognized him.

Major Vikram Sethi.

Military Intelligence Division.

If Vikram was here personally...

Something had happened.

The major entered the room and nodded respectfully.

"Good to see you awake, sir."

Aryan ignored the greeting.

"What happened?"

The major's expression hardened.

For several seconds he said nothing.

Then he held up a sealed black file.

Instantly, the atmosphere changed.

Rudra noticed it.

Aryan noticed it.

Even Arya sensed something shift.

Because suddenly this no longer felt like a hospital visit.

It felt like a briefing.

The major placed the file beside the bed.

"We finished the verification process."

Aryan's eyes narrowed.

The words hit instantly.

Verification.

There was only one thing being verified.

The hidden layer.

The possibility he had identified before the mission.

The possibility nobody had been able to confirm.

Slowly, Aryan reached for the file.

His injured hand trembled slightly.

Not from fear.

From weakness.

The major opened it for him.

Several photographs.

Satellite imagery.

Intercepted communications.

Field reports.

Aryan scanned the first page.

Then the second.

Then the third.

The color slowly drained from his face.

Rudra felt his stomach tighten.

Because he knew that look.

Everyone in Alpha Team knew that look.

It was the same expression Aryan wore whenever something went very, very wrong.

"What is it?"

Rudra asked quietly.

Aryan didn't answer.

His eyes remained fixed on the documents.

Reading.

Processing.

Calculating.

The room waited.

Finally, he looked up.

Directly at Major Vikram.

"This is impossible."

Nobody spoke.

The Major's answer came quietly.

"We thought so too."

Aryan lowered his gaze back to the file.

Every page made things worse.

Not better.

Worse.

The hidden network existed.

Exactly as he had suspected.

But that wasn't the problem.

The problem was its size.

Its reach.

Its connections.

Everything.

The room suddenly felt smaller.

The air felt heavier.

And for the first time since waking up...

Aryan forgot about the pain.

Forgot about the hospital.

Forgot about recovery.

Because the mission they thought had ended in Jammu...

Had never ended at all.

In fact—

It had only revealed the first layer.

Aryan slowly closed the file.

Then looked toward Rudra.

His voice was calm.

Far too calm.

The kind of calm that appeared before disasters.

"We have a problem."

Rudra stared.

"How bad?"

A long silence followed.

Then Aryan gave the answer.

And every person in the room immediately understood that the war they thought was over...

Was only beginning.

"Much bigger than we imagined."

End of Chapter 17

Chapter 18

The Hidden Network

Part I

Three days after Aryan regained consciousness, the seventh floor of St. Thomas Hospital looked normal. At least from the outside.

Doctors moved through corridors.

Patients met visitors.

Nurses exchanged reports.

Everything appeared ordinary.

Which was exactly why nobody noticed the heavily armed military personnel stationed at every entrance.

Nobody noticed the intelligence officers entering through restricted access points.

And nobody noticed that Conference Room B had been sealed off for the entire morning.

Inside that room, however, the atmosphere was anything but ordinary.

A large digital screen covered one wall.

Maps.

Satellite imagery.

Intercepted communications.

Operational reports.

Every available surface displayed information.

At the center of the room sat the people responsible for the country's most sensitive operations.

General Vikram Sharma.

General Arjun Rathore.

Senior Intelligence Officers.

Counter-Terror Division representatives.

And Alpha Team.

Aryan sat at the far end of the conference table.

Officially, he was still a patient.

Unofficially, nobody in the room was treating him like one.

The bandages remained.

The injuries remained.

The doctors' restrictions remained.

Yet despite all of that, every person present kept glancing toward him.

Waiting.

Because they knew something.

Aryan Sharma rarely attended briefings without changing the outcome.

A few seats away sat Arya.

She wasn't there as part of the military.

She was there because hospital administration insisted that a recovering patient should not participate in classified meetings without medical supervision.

Arya thought the entire arrangement was ridiculous.

Unfortunately, nobody had asked for her opinion.

So now she found herself surrounded by generals, intelligence officers, and special forces operators.

Exactly how she imagined spending her morning.

The meeting began the moment General Vikram stood.

The room immediately fell silent.

Years of command had that effect.

"We completed verification of all recovered intelligence from the Jammu operation."

The screen behind him changed.
A satellite image appeared.
The destroyed compound.
The same location where everything had gone wrong.
The same location where Aryan nearly died.
General Vikram continued.
"Initially, we believed this facility functioned as an independent operational base."
Another image appeared.
Then another.
Then another.
Different locations.
Different regions.
Different states.
Arya frowned.
Because she immediately noticed something.
The images weren't random.
They formed a pattern.
A network.
The General's next words confirmed it.
"We were wrong."
The room remained silent.
Nobody interrupted.
Nobody reacted.
Everyone understood the seriousness of those words.
High Command did not admit mistakes lightly.
"If the Jammu facility had been destroyed six months ago, our original assessment would've been correct."
The screen changed again.
This time displaying communication logs.
Encrypted transmissions.
Movement records.
Financial data.
The amount of information was overwhelming.
But the conclusion was simple.
The Jammu compound had never been the headquarters.
It had never been the primary target.
It had never even been important.
It was merely a transit point.
A relay station.
A single node inside something much larger.
General Arjun leaned forward.
"The facility we attacked was essentially a courier hub."
One of the intelligence officers nodded.
"Personnel."
Another slide appeared.
"Money."
Another.
"Weapons."
Another.
"Information."
The realization slowly spread through the room.
The compound Alpha Team had destroyed wasn't the organization.
It was merely one road leading toward it.
General Vikram's expression darkened.

"And unfortunately..."

The next slide appeared.

Several cities lit up across the digital map.

Delhi.

Mumbai.

Jaipur.

Lucknow.

Chandigarh.

Hyderabad.

The room became noticeably quieter.

Even Arya felt the atmosphere change.

Because suddenly this wasn't a border issue.

This wasn't a regional threat.

This was national.

One of the intelligence officers finally spoke.

"We currently believe sleeper assets may exist within these locations."

Nobody liked hearing those words.

Sleeper assets meant time.

Preparation.

Planning.

It meant the enemy wasn't reacting.

The enemy had already prepared.

Months ago.

Possibly years ago.

A dangerous silence settled over the room.

Then, for the first time since the briefing started, General Vikram looked directly at Arya.

"So."

The room's attention shifted immediately.

Every eye moved toward him.

Every eye except Arya's.

She was already watching him.

Because she wanted to understand something.

For the last three days she had heard stories.

Legends.

Achievements.

Impossible missions.

Yet stories were easy.

Reality was different.

Today she wanted to see reality.

General Vikram folded his arms.

"What do you think?"

The room fell silent.

No suggestions.

No interruptions.

No competing opinions.

Nothing.

Just silence.

Arya noticed it instantly.

A room filled with senior officers.

Decorated commanders.

Veteran intelligence personnel.

Yet all of them were waiting for the opinion of a twenty-five-year-old recovering from a hospital bed.

For the first time, she found that genuinely surprising.

Aryan studied the screen.
The maps.
The communication routes.
The financial trails.
The movement logs.
Several minutes passed.
Nobody rushed him.
Nobody pressured him.
Then slowly, Aryan leaned forward.
And the expression on his face changed.
The patient disappeared.
The commander appeared.
The difference was immediate.
Subtle.
Yet unmistakable.
His eyes sharpened.
His posture straightened.
Even the way he looked at the information felt different.
For the first time since entering the room, Arya understood why people followed him.
Not because of rank.
Not because of authority.
Something else.
Something harder to explain.
Aryan stared at the map for several more seconds.
Then quietly spoke.
And the first sentence out of his mouth made the entire room freeze.
"No."
General Vikram frowned.
"No?"
Aryan's eyes never left the screen.
"We're looking at this wrong."
The silence that followed felt dangerous.
Because everyone in the room suddenly understood one thing.
The briefing had only just begun.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 18

The Hidden Network

Part II

The room remained silent.
Aryan's words still hung in the air.
"We're looking at this wrong."
Nobody interrupted him.
Not because of rank.
Because experience had taught them something important.
Whenever Aryan said a plan was wrong...
It usually was.
General Vikram folded his arms.
"Explain."
Aryan slowly zoomed out the digital map.
The highlighted cities shrank.
The communication routes became visible.
The financial transfers appeared.
Then he pointed toward Jammu.
"Our mistake started here."
One of the intelligence officers frowned.
"That's the primary node."
"No."
Aryan's answer came immediately.
"It's the visible node."
A subtle difference.
But an important one.
The room grew quieter.
Arya watched from the corner of the table.
Observing.
Listening.
Trying to understand why everyone suddenly looked so focused.
Aryan continued.
"If I wanted to build a hidden network..."
His finger moved across the screen.
"...I wouldn't hide the headquarters."
Several officers exchanged glances.
Aryan zoomed in on the communication records.
"I'd hide the decision-makers."
The statement landed heavily.
Because it made sense.
Dangerous sense.
The kind everyone should have noticed earlier.
A senior analyst stood.
"You think we're chasing infrastructure."
Aryan nodded.
"Exactly."
The analyst looked toward the screen.

"And?"

Aryan's eyes hardened.

"The infrastructure doesn't matter."

General Arjun leaned forward.

"What matters?"

Aryan met his gaze.

"The people giving orders."

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Because suddenly the entire investigation looked different.

The weapons routes didn't matter.

The courier stations didn't matter.

The safe houses didn't matter.

All of them were replaceable.

Destroy one.

Build another.

Destroy five.

Build ten more.

Networks survived.

Leaders didn't.

Aryan pointed toward the financial records.

"These accounts."

The intelligence officer responsible for cyber operations immediately responded.

"What about them?"

"Who owns them?"

"We don't know."

Aryan nodded.

"Exactly."

The officer frowned.

"We traced them."

"No."

Aryan shook his head.

"You traced where the money moved."

His gaze sharpened.

"You still don't know who started the movement."

The room fell silent again.

Because once more...

He was right.

Arya watched the discussion carefully.

Something about it felt surreal.

For the past two weeks she had seen Aryan as a patient.

A difficult patient.

An irritating patient.

A patient who constantly ignored medical advice.

But now?

Now she was seeing something completely different.

Every person in the room was following his thought process.

Not because they had to.

Because they wanted to.

Even the generals.

And that fact alone surprised her more than she wanted to admit.

One of the younger intelligence officers spoke.

"If that's true, then we're chasing shadows."

Aryan looked toward him.
"No."
The officer waited.
Aryan pointed toward one specific section of the map.
"We're chasing the wrong shadow."
The room froze.
General Vikram narrowed his eyes.
"What do you mean?"
Aryan reached for the tablet lying beside him.
His injured arm protested immediately.
Pain shot through his shoulder.
His expression didn't change.
Not even slightly.
Arya noticed.
And immediately hated that she noticed.
Ignoring injuries shouldn't have been impressive.
Yet somehow it was.
Aryan brought up another set of records.
Communication timestamps.
Message delays.
Signal routing patterns.
Data nobody had paid much attention to.
Then he highlighted three locations.
Delhi.
Jaipur.
Chandigarh.
The screen displayed dozens of connections.
A tangled web.
At first glance it looked random.
Then Aryan removed half of them.
Suddenly the pattern appeared.
Several officers visibly straightened in their chairs.
Because now they could see it too.
The communications weren't spreading outward.
They were converging inward.
Toward a single point.
A hidden center.
A command layer.
The room erupted.
People started talking simultaneously.
Analysts reviewed data.
Officers compared notes.
The atmosphere changed instantly.
For the first time since the briefing began, there was direction.
A target.
A possibility.
General Vikram looked genuinely impressed.
Which was saying something.
The man rarely looked impressed by anything.
"You found that in ten minutes?"
Aryan shrugged.
"Eight."
A few members of Alpha Team smirked.

Because that sounded exactly like him.
General Arjun shook his head.
"Show-off."
A faint smile appeared on Aryan's face.
For about half a second.
Then it vanished.
Because his attention had already returned to the screen.
And suddenly...
His expression changed.
Completely.
The faint amusement disappeared.
The focus disappeared.
Something else replaced it.
Something darker.
Arya noticed it first.
Then Rudra.
Then the generals.
The room gradually became silent once again.
Because Aryan wasn't looking at the communication map anymore.
He was staring at a single file.
A file that had just appeared on the screen.
Recovered communication logs.
Recovered identities.
Recovered code references.
Most meant nothing.
One, however, clearly meant something.
Aryan's eyes remained fixed on a single word.
A codename.
Nothing more.
Yet the reaction it caused was immediate.
Rudra frowned.
"Aryan?"
No response.
The room waited.
Still nothing.
General Vikram slowly stood.
For the first time during the briefing...
He looked concerned.
"Aryan."
The commander finally looked up.
His face had gone pale.
Not from injury.
Not from exhaustion.
Something else.
Something far worse.
The General's voice became serious.
"What is it?"
A long silence followed.
Then Aryan looked back toward the screen.
Toward the codename.
Toward the one detail that should not have existed.
The one detail that made absolutely no sense.
And for the first time since waking up...

Fear appeared in his eyes.

"This can't be right."

Nobody moved.

Nobody spoke.

Because everyone understood the implication.

If Aryan Sharma looked afraid...

Then whatever was written on that screen was far more dangerous than anyone had imagined.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 18

The Hidden Network

Part III

Nobody spoke.

The conference room remained completely silent.

Dozens of eyes shifted between Aryan and the screen.

For the first time since the briefing had begun, nobody cared about the maps.

Nobody cared about the communication routes.

Nobody cared about the financial records.

Because Aryan Sharma was afraid.

And that had never happened before.

At least not in front of them.

General Vikram slowly approached the display.

"What are we looking at?"

Aryan didn't answer immediately.

His eyes remained fixed on the recovered file.

A single communication log.

One intercepted transmission.

Three words highlighted in red.

Project Sentinel Active.

The room frowned collectively.

Most officers looked confused.

The phrase meant nothing to them.

Nothing unusual.

Nothing alarming.

Just another codename among hundreds.

But Aryan looked like he had seen a ghost.

Rudra stood up.

"Aryan."

This time the commander responded.

Quietly.

Almost to himself.

"I thought it was terminated."

The room became even quieter.

General Arjun exchanged a glance with General Vikram.

Both men suddenly looked serious.

Very serious.

Because they recognized the name.

And that realization alone was enough to unsettle them.

Arya noticed it immediately.

For the first time since entering the briefing room, the two generals looked uncomfortable.

That was not normal.

Not even remotely normal.

General Vikram slowly sat down.

"When was the last confirmed reference?"

Aryan finally looked away from the screen.

"Seven years ago."

Several intelligence officers immediately started checking records.
Searching databases.
Reviewing archives.
Most found nothing.
Because most of the information was classified far beyond their clearance levels.
Arya looked around the room.
The atmosphere had changed completely.
This no longer felt like a routine briefing.
This felt like the reopening of something old.
Something dangerous.
Something everyone had hoped remained buried.
One analyst finally spoke.
"Sir... what exactly was Project Sentinel?"
Nobody answered.
The silence stretched.
Then General Arjun exhaled slowly.
"An operation."
The analyst waited.
"That's it?"
"No."
The General's gaze hardened.
"It was a disaster."
The room froze.
Because nobody had ever heard General Arjun describe an operation that way.
Not once.
Arya found herself listening more carefully.
Even Alpha Team looked surprised.
Which was saying something.
Because they usually knew everything.
General Vikram stood and walked toward the screen.
Seven years earlier.
A classified counter-intelligence operation.
One of the most secretive missions ever conducted.
Only a handful of officers had known about it.
Even fewer had survived it.
"It was designed to eliminate a growing covert network before it could establish itself."
The General paused.
"The operation failed."
Nobody interrupted.
Nobody even moved.
"Officially, every major figure involved was neutralized."
Another pause.
"Unofficially..."
His eyes shifted toward Aryan.
"We were never completely certain."
Arya slowly turned toward Aryan.
And suddenly she understood.
This wasn't just another mission.
This was personal.
Very personal.
The realization hit harder when Aryan finally spoke.
His voice remained calm.
Too calm.

The kind of calm that usually appeared before something bad happened.

"I was thirteen."

The room looked at him.

Aryan's gaze never left the screen.

"My father was part of the operation."

Silence.

Every person present immediately understood the weight behind those words.

General Vikram Sharma.

National hero.

Legendary officer.

The man who had trained half the current leadership.

And Aryan's father.

The room listened carefully.

Because nobody had ever heard Aryan speak about him voluntarily.

"After Sentinel ended..."

Aryan paused.

"...he never talked about it again."

The words carried more meaning than they appeared to.

Even General Vikram remained silent.

Aryan looked toward the highlighted codename once more.

Project Sentinel Active.

The phrase echoed in his mind.

Seven years.

Seven years without a single trace.

Seven years without a single confirmed lead.

Seven years of silence.

And now suddenly—

It had appeared again.

Inside intelligence recovered from Jammu.

The probability should have been impossible.

Yet there it was.

Staring back at him.

Real.

One of the analysts finally broke the silence.

"Could it be fake?"

Aryan answered instantly.

"No."

The confidence surprised everyone.

The analyst frowned.

"How can you be sure?"

Aryan slowly closed the file.

Then looked directly at him.

"Because nobody outside that operation knew the codename existed."

The room froze.

A chill seemed to spread through the conference room.

Because that meant only one thing.

Whoever sent that message wasn't guessing.

They knew.

They knew exactly what Sentinel was.

Which meant—

Somebody connected to that operation was still active.

Still watching.

Still moving.

General Arjun's jaw tightened.
"Then we have a serious problem."
Aryan nodded.
"No."
The room looked at him.
He leaned back in his chair.
Eyes locked on the map.
On the cities.
On the network.
On the hidden enemy that suddenly felt much closer than before.
Then he delivered the sentence nobody wanted to hear.
"We have a war."
Silence.
Absolute silence.
Because every person in that room understood exactly what he meant.
This wasn't about sleeper cells anymore.
This wasn't about funding routes.
This wasn't about one operation in Jammu.
Someone had been building something for years.
Quietly.
Patiently.
Right under their noses.
And now they had finally revealed their existence.
Not by mistake.
Not accidentally.
But intentionally.
Almost as if they wanted the military to know.
Almost as if—
It was a challenge.
General Vikram stared at the map.
The intelligence officers exchanged uneasy glances.
Alpha Team sat motionless.
And for the first time since the mission began...
Everyone realized they weren't hunting a network anymore.
The network had started hunting them.

End of Chapter 18

Chapter 19

A Day Off

Part I

A week later.

For the first time in days, there were no emergency briefings.

No intelligence meetings.

No classified reports waiting on conference tables.

The investigation into Project Sentinel had entered a temporary analysis phase. Intelligence agencies were chasing leads across multiple cities, and until concrete results appeared, even Alpha Team had little choice but to wait.

Aryan hated it.

Waiting was arguably the worst part of military life.

A mission could be dangerous.

A mission could be painful.

A mission could go wrong.

But at least a mission gave you something to do.

Recovery didn't.

Recovery meant hospital rooms.

Medical examinations.

Physiotherapy.

And doctors constantly reminding you that you were not allowed to do half the things you normally did.

Which was exactly why Aryan was currently attempting to leave the hospital without informing anyone.

Unfortunately for him, Arya caught him before he reached the elevator.

"Where do you think you're going?"

Aryan stopped.

Slowly turned around.

And immediately regretted it.

Because Dr. Arya Mehra was standing behind him with her arms crossed.

Which was never a good sign.

"Walking."

Arya stared.

"Walking."

"Yes."

"Outside."

"Correct."

She blinked.

Once.

Twice.

Then pointed toward the crutches beside him.

"You were discharged from intensive observation three days ago."

"Exactly."

"You're still recovering."

"I'm walking."

"You have stitches."

"I'm walking carefully."

Arya closed her eyes.

As if gathering patience.

Or possibly contemplating murder.

It was difficult to tell.
"Commander Sharma."
Aryan instantly knew he was in trouble.
Because she only used his title when she was annoyed.
"Doctor."
"Return to your room."
"No."
Arya opened her eyes.
"No?"
"No."
The answer arrived so quickly that she almost laughed.
Almost.
Instead she stepped closer.
"You realize I'm responsible for your recovery."
"You realize I'm not a prisoner."
"You're behaving like one."
"I'm behaving like a soldier."
Arya pointed toward his shoulder.
"The soldier currently held together by medical science."
Aryan looked down.
Then back at her.
"That's slightly dramatic."
"You're slightly dramatic."
The argument would've continued indefinitely.
Fortunately—or unfortunately—the elevator doors opened.
Ridhi stepped out.
One look at the scene and she immediately understood.
Aryan trying to leave.
Arya trying to stop him.
Business as usual.
The smile on her face appeared instantly.
"Oh good."
Arya groaned.
"No."
Ridhi ignored her completely.
"Perfect timing."
Both Aryan and Arya became suspicious.
For entirely different reasons.
"What did you do?"
The question escaped from both of them simultaneously.
Ridhi's smile somehow became wider.
"Nothing."
That answer worried everyone.
Especially because nobody believed it.
Two hours later.
A black SUV rolled through the city.
Inside sat four people.
Three unhappy.
One extremely satisfied.
Ridhi.
The architect behind today's disaster.
Aryan sat beside the window.
Arms crossed.

Expression blank.
Across from him sat Arya.
Doing exactly the same thing.
Neither had spoken since entering the vehicle.
Not once.
Rudra sat between them.
And was rapidly losing hope.
"This is painful."
Nobody responded.
Rudra looked at Ridhi.
"They've said three words in twenty minutes."
"That's progress."
"It isn't."
"It is."
Aryan looked outside.
Pretending the conversation didn't exist.
Arya did the same.
Unfortunately, Ridhi had no intention of allowing that strategy to succeed.
"So."
Silence.
"How's recovery?"
Aryan answered.
"Fine."
"Great."
Ridhi turned toward Arya.
"How's work?"
"Fine."
Rudra stared at both of them.
In disbelief.
"That's all?"
"Yes."
"Yes."
Again.
At the same time.
Ridhi immediately started laughing.
Arya looked away.
Aryan looked out the window.
Neither acknowledged what had happened.
Neither intended to.
The vehicle eventually stopped near a large lakeside café on the edge of the city.
Unlike the crowded restaurants downtown, this place was peaceful.
Open air seating.
Calm water.
Gentle wind.
The kind of location people visited when they wanted quiet conversations.
Unfortunately, quiet conversations required cooperative participants.
Something Ridhi had failed to consider.
The four of them took a table near the water.
For several minutes nobody spoke.
The silence became so severe that even the waiter looked uncomfortable.
Finally he approached.
"Would you like to order?"
"Coffee."

Arya answered immediately.
The waiter nodded.
Then looked toward Aryan.
"Sir?"
"Tea."
Arya frowned.
Aryan noticed.
Unfortunately.
"What?"
"Nothing."
"Clearly something."
Arya shook her head.
"Nothing."
Aryan leaned back.
"No, tell me."
Arya sighed.
"You drink tea?"
The question sounded almost offensive.
Aryan looked confused.
"Yes."
"Voluntarily?"
Rudra immediately covered his face.
Because he already knew where this conversation was going.
Aryan raised an eyebrow.
"Is there a problem?"
Arya looked toward the waiter.
Then back at him.
"No."
Pause.
Then—
"It's just disappointing."
The waiter nearly laughed.
Ridhi actually did laugh.
Aryan stared at Arya.
Disbelief visible on his face.
"You find my beverage choices disappointing?"
"Deeply."
"That's absurd."
"So is drinking tea at a café famous for coffee."
Aryan looked genuinely offended.
And for some reason...
That made everyone else's day significantly better.
For the first time since arriving, Ridhi noticed something interesting.
Neither of them looked angry.
Annoyed?
Absolutely.
Irritated?
Without question.
But not angry.
And strangely enough...
That felt like progress.
Because for the first time, their arguments didn't feel like enemies fighting.
They felt like two stubborn people refusing to admit they were actually enjoying the conversation.

Neither Aryan nor Arya realized it yet.
But everyone else at the table did.
And both Rudra and Ridhi shared the exact same thought.
This was going to be fun.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 19

A Day Off

Part II

For the next thirty minutes, things remained surprisingly peaceful.

Which, according to Rudra, was suspicious.

Very suspicious.

Because whenever Aryan and Arya stopped arguing, it usually meant something worse was coming.

Unfortunately, he was right.

The drinks arrived.

Arya's coffee.

Aryan's tea.

Ridhi's iced latte.

Rudra's black coffee.

Everything looked normal.

Then Arya took a sip of her coffee and immediately smiled.

The kind of smile people got when they knew they were right.

Aryan noticed.

Unfortunately.

"What?"

Arya placed the cup down.

"Nothing."

"You have the same expression you get before insulting someone."

Ridhi nearly choked on her drink.

Arya looked genuinely offended.

"I do not."

"You absolutely do."

"You're imagining things."

"No, I'm not."

A brief silence followed.

Then Aryan glanced at her coffee.

Realization struck.

"Oh."

Arya already knew where this was heading.

"No."

"You're judging my tea again."

"Maybe."

"Why?"

Arya looked toward the lake.

"Because coffee is objectively superior."

Aryan blinked.

"Objectively?"

"Yes."

"That's not how opinions work."

"It isn't an opinion."

Rudra immediately stood up.

"I'm going for a walk."

Ridhi nodded.

"Smart."

Neither Aryan nor Arya noticed.

They were too busy preparing for battle.

Ten minutes later.

Rudra and Ridhi sat at another table several meters away.

A strategic retreat.

From here they could still see everything.

More importantly...

They were safely outside the blast radius.

Ridhi sipped her drink.

"They've been arguing about beverages for ten minutes."

Rudra looked impressed.

"New record."

"Think they'll notice we left?"

"No."

"Good."

They watched the ongoing debate.

Surprisingly, neither Aryan nor Arya looked annoyed anymore.

In fact...

Both seemed unusually engaged.

Which was dangerous.

Because stubborn people often mistook enjoyment for irritation.

Back at the original table, the argument had somehow evolved.

Nobody knew how.

Not even them.

One moment they were discussing coffee.

The next moment they were discussing careers.

"Doctors save lives."

Arya folded her arms confidently.

Aryan nodded.

"True."

"Military creates situations where doctors become necessary."

The smile immediately vanished.

"There it is."

"There what is?"

"The military arrogance."

Aryan sighed.

"The military realism."

Arya leaned forward.

"No. Arrogance."

"And what's the difference?"

"The fact that you think you're right."

Aryan raised an eyebrow.

"You think you're right too."

"Because I am."

"That's exactly what I mean."

The realization hit both of them simultaneously.

They sounded identical.

Neither appreciated it.

The waiter arrived with a second round of drinks.

This time he looked far more relaxed.

Mostly because listening to their arguments had become unexpectedly entertaining.

After placing the order, he hesitated.

Then spoke carefully.
"Can I ask something?"
Arya and Aryan both looked at him.
The poor man suddenly seemed nervous.
"Are you two..."
He paused.
"...siblings?"
Silence.
Complete silence.
Then—
"No."
The answer arrived from both of them at the exact same time.
The waiter jumped.
Actually jumped.
Nearby customers looked over.
Even Rudra spit out his coffee.
Ridhi laughed so hard she nearly fell out of her chair.
The waiter apologized and escaped immediately.
Aryan rubbed his forehead.
Arya looked away.
Neither knew why that question had annoyed them so much.
As the afternoon continued, the atmosphere gradually changed.
Not dramatically.
Not enough for either of them to notice.
But enough.
The arguments became less hostile.
The silences became less awkward.
And for the first time, actual conversations began slipping through the cracks.
Small things.
Unexpected things.
Arya discovered that Aryan read far more than she expected.
History.
Strategy.
Biographies.
Military theory.
Anything that challenged his thinking.
"You voluntarily read six-hundred-page books?"
Arya looked horrified.
Aryan looked confused.
"Yes."
"Why?"
"Because they're interesting."
"No."
"Yes."
"No normal person does that."
Aryan pointed toward her.
"You spent ten years studying medicine."
"That's different."
"It really isn't."
For the first time that day...
Arya laughed.
A real laugh.
Brief.

Unplanned.
Gone almost immediately.
Yet it happened.
And Aryan noticed.
The realization surprised him.
Because it was the first time he had seen her laugh without trying to win an argument.
For a second, she looked completely different.
Less guarded.
Less defensive.
More human.
The thought disappeared almost as quickly as it arrived.
But it stayed somewhere in the back of his mind.
Later, as they walked beside the lake, the conversation unexpectedly shifted.
The afternoon crowd had grown.
Children played nearby.
Couples walked along the waterfront.
The atmosphere felt strangely normal.
A feeling neither Aryan nor Arya experienced often.
For several minutes, nobody spoke.
Then Arya broke the silence.
"Why did you join?"
Aryan glanced toward her.
The question wasn't what surprised him.
The tone did.
For the first time...
There was no challenge behind it.
No accusation.
Just curiosity.
Aryan looked toward the water.
Thinking.
"My father."
Arya remained quiet.
Aryan continued walking.
"He believed service mattered."
A pause.
"He was the best man I've ever known."
The words were simple.
Yet something about them felt heavy.
Personal.
Real.
For a moment, Arya didn't know what to say.
Because she understood that feeling.
More than he realized.
And suddenly...
The conversation felt far more dangerous than any argument.
Because arguments were easy.
Understanding someone was harder.
Much harder.
As they continued walking beside the lake, neither noticed Rudra and Ridhi watching from a distance.
Both wearing identical expressions.
Ridhi smiled.
"See it?"
Rudra nodded.

"Yeah."

"They've stopped fighting."

Rudra looked toward the two figures walking ahead.

Then smiled slightly.

"No."

Ridhi frowned.

"No?"

Rudra shook his head.

"They're still fighting."

A pause.

Then he added:

"They've just started listening."

And somehow...

That was far more important.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 19

A Day Off

Part III

The sun was beginning to set.

Golden light reflected across the lake, painting the water in shades of orange and gold. The afternoon crowd had started thinning, and the noise around them slowly faded into the background.

For the first time since arriving, nobody was arguing.

At least not openly.

Rudra and Ridhi had disappeared somewhere behind them, leaving Aryan and Arya alone on the lakeside pathway.

A decision both had definitely planned.

And neither Aryan nor Arya believed that for a second.

"They did this intentionally."

Arya spoke while staring ahead.

"Obviously."

Aryan's answer came immediately.

"They think they're subtle."

"They're not."

"Not even slightly."

A brief silence followed.

Then both continued walking.

For some reason, it wasn't awkward anymore.

Strange.

Very strange.

A small bookstore appeared ahead.

Nestled beside the lake.

Old-fashioned.

Quiet.

The kind of place most people walked past without noticing.

Arya would've continued walking.

Aryan didn't.

He stopped.

Arya noticed.

"You read that much?"

Aryan glanced toward the shop.

"Sometimes."

"Six-hundred-page military books aren't enough?"

"No."

She shook her head.

"Genuinely concerning."

Aryan ignored her and stepped inside.

Still muttering something about doctors having no appreciation for literature.

Arya rolled her eyes and followed.

Someone had to make sure he didn't injure himself.

Again.

Inside, rows of books stretched across wooden shelves.

The atmosphere felt peaceful.

Calm.

A welcome change from hospitals and military briefings.
For several minutes, they wandered through different sections.
Without speaking.
Then Arya stopped.
A particular shelf had caught her attention.
Medical memoirs.
Research journals.
Biographies.
Before she could reach for one, another hand grabbed the same book.
Aryan.
Both froze.
The book remained suspended between them.
Neither let go.
Neither moved.
The elderly shopkeeper looked up from his desk.
Smiled.
Then delivered the worst possible sentence.
"You two make a lovely couple."
Silence.
Dead silence.
Aryan blinked.
Arya stared.
The old man smiled proudly.
Clearly convinced he had said something wonderful.
Then—
"No."
The answer arrived simultaneously.
Again.
The shopkeeper jumped.
Actually jumped.
A customer nearby started laughing.
Arya immediately released the book.
Aryan handed it over without another word.
Both looked horrified.
The shopkeeper looked confused.
Very confused.
Twenty minutes later, they were back outside.
Walking along the waterfront again.
Neither mentioned the bookstore incident.
Neither intended to.
Some things were better left buried.
Far buried.
Eventually they found a quiet section overlooking the lake.
A wooden railing separated the pathway from the water below.
The evening breeze felt cooler now.
Comfortable.
For a while, neither spoke.
Then unexpectedly, Arya broke the silence.
"My father hated the military."
Aryan looked toward her.
The statement surprised him.
Mostly because it came out of nowhere.
Arya continued staring at the water.

"He thought wars only created more pain."
Her voice was calm.
Too calm.
The kind of calm people used when discussing something that still hurt.
Aryan remained silent.
Listening.
"My mother used to argue with him about it."
A faint smile appeared.
Brief.
Melancholic.
"He never changed his mind."
The smile disappeared.
Just as quickly.
For several moments, only the sound of water filled the air.
Then Aryan quietly asked,
"Was he a doctor too?"
Arya nodded.
"Cardiologist."
The answer was simple.
Yet something about it felt unfinished.
Like an entire story existed behind those few words.
Aryan didn't push further.
For once.
He simply nodded.
And strangely enough...
Arya appreciated that.
Meanwhile, several meters away, Rudra and Ridhi watched from a distance.
Like professional spies.
Terrible professional spies.
Ridhi lowered her sunglasses.
"It's working."
Rudra looked unconvinced.
"Maybe."
"No maybe."
She pointed toward Aryan and Arya.
"They haven't argued in fifteen minutes."
Rudra frowned.
"That's actually worrying."
Ridhi laughed.
Before she could reply, her phone buzzed.
The smile instantly vanished.
Rudra noticed immediately.
"What happened?"
Ridhi stared at the screen.
Then handed him the phone.
His expression changed too.
Fast.
Very fast.
The message contained only a few words.
A secure military notification.
Urgent.
Priority One.
Aryan Sharma.

Immediate briefing required.
Rudra's jaw tightened.
The timing couldn't have been worse.
Not after the last week.
Not after Project Sentinel.
Not after the temporary peace everyone had finally found.
Ridhi looked toward Aryan.
"So much for a day off."
Rudra nodded grimly.
"Yeah."
Because in their world...
Peace never lasted long.
A few moments later, Aryan's own phone vibrated.
He checked the screen.
The moment he read the message, the calm expression disappeared.
Arya noticed instantly.
"What happened?"
Aryan didn't answer.
His eyes remained fixed on the notification.
A second message arrived.
Then a third.
Classified.
Emergency.
Mandatory attendance.
The feeling in Aryan's stomach immediately returned.
The same feeling he'd experienced before missions.
Before disasters.
Before everything went wrong.
Slowly, he locked the phone.
His gaze shifted toward the horizon.
Toward the fading sunlight.
Toward the peaceful evening that had just ended.
Arya watched him carefully.
Then quietly asked again,
"What happened?"
This time he answered.
His voice was calm.
Too calm.
"The war just moved."
The words sent a chill down her spine.
Because for the first time since meeting him...
She realized something.
Whenever Aryan Sharma looked worried...
Something bad usually followed.
And somewhere, far away...
Someone had just made their first move.

End of Chapter 19

Chapter 20

Fault Lines

Part I

The emergency briefing started at 22:00 hours.
Outside, the city slept peacefully.
Inside Conference Room B, nobody even considered sleep.
The atmosphere felt heavier than it had during the previous briefing.
More guards.
More intelligence officers.
More classified files.
Which usually meant only one thing.
Bad news.
Aryan entered the room alongside Rudra and the rest of Alpha Team.
The conversations immediately died.
Not because of rank.
Because everyone present wanted answers.
And right now, Aryan was the closest thing they had to one.
General Vikram Sharma stood near the digital display.
His expression alone told the room that something had changed.
Something significant.
The moment everyone settled, the lights dimmed.
A satellite image appeared on the screen.
Then another.
Then another.
Different locations.
Different cities.
Different timestamps.
At first glance they seemed unrelated.
But nobody in the room was stupid enough to believe that.
"Four hours ago," General Vikram began, "we intercepted another Sentinel transmission."
Silence.
Every eye moved toward the screen.
A communication log appeared.
Then the route it had taken.
Then the servers through which it had passed.
And immediately something felt wrong.
Very wrong.
The transmission wasn't hidden.
It wasn't encrypted beyond recovery.
It wasn't buried beneath multiple security layers.
In fact...
It looked almost easy to find.
The realization unsettled everyone.
One intelligence officer spoke first.
"That's impossible."
Another nodded.
"No organization this sophisticated would make a mistake like that."

A third officer added,
"Unless they wanted us to find it."
The room became silent.
Because nobody liked that possibility.
General Vikram looked toward Aryan.
"What do you think?"
Aryan didn't answer immediately.
He studied the screen.
Every detail.
Every route.
Every timestamp.
Every relay point.
The room waited.
Five seconds.
Ten seconds.
Fifteen.
Then Aryan stood.
Ignoring the sharp pain in his shoulder.
Ignoring the warning look Arya immediately gave him.
Ignoring everything except the data.
He walked toward the screen.
Picked up a marker.
And drew a circle around the transmission route.
"Tell me something."
Nobody spoke.
Aryan looked at the intelligence analysts.
"How many people worked on decrypting this?"
"Twenty-three."
"How long?"
"Almost three hours."
Aryan nodded.
Then looked around the room.
"That's the problem."
Confusion spread instantly.
One analyst frowned.
"Problem?"
Aryan tapped the screen.
"If I spend years building a covert network..."
Another tap.
"...I don't allow twenty-three analysts to find my communications in three hours."
Silence.
The statement hit hard.
Because it was true.
Painfully true.
Aryan drew another line.
Then another.
Slowly a pattern emerged.
A pattern nobody had noticed.
Several officers leaned forward.
General Arjun's eyes narrowed.
"What are we looking at?"
Aryan finally turned toward them.
And for the first time since entering the room, his expression looked genuinely dangerous.

"They aren't hiding."

The room froze.

An analyst immediately shook his head.

"That's impossible."

"No."

Aryan pointed at the map.

"What's impossible is believing this was an accident."

The screen changed.

New data appeared.

Communication routes.

Movement records.

Financial transfers.

Dozens of different locations.

And suddenly everyone saw it.

The routes weren't protecting something.

They were advertising something.

Like breadcrumbs.

Like a trail.

Like bait.

A cold feeling settled over the room.

General Vikram folded his arms.

"A distraction."

Aryan nodded.

"Exactly."

Nobody liked that answer.

Because distractions only existed when someone wanted you looking away from the real objective.

General Arjun stepped closer.

"Then what are we missing?"

Aryan stared at the map.

For several seconds he said nothing.

Then his eyes stopped at a specific cluster of cities.

Delhi.

Jaipur.

Lucknow.

Chandigarh.

His expression changed instantly.

Rudra noticed first.

Then General Vikram.

Then everyone else.

Because they all knew that look.

Aryan had found something.

The kind of something nobody wanted him to find.

Slowly...

Very slowly...

He zoomed out.

The room watched.

The map expanded.

More locations appeared.

Then suddenly the pattern became visible.

A collective silence fell over the room.

One intelligence officer actually stood up.

"No..."

Another officer whispered,

"Dear God..."

General Vikram's jaw tightened.

Because the network wasn't positioning resources near military installations.

It wasn't positioning resources near government facilities.

It wasn't preparing battlefields.

It was positioning itself around universities.

Research institutes.

Technical colleges.

Cybersecurity academies.

The realization hit everyone simultaneously.

Aryan spoke the words nobody wanted to hear.

"They aren't preparing an attack."

The room remained frozen.

His voice became even quieter.

Which somehow made it worse.

"They're preparing recruitment."

No one spoke.

No one moved.

Because suddenly the threat became far more dangerous.

Bombs could be stopped.

Weapons could be seized.

Cells could be dismantled.

But ideas?

Ideas spread.

And if Sentinel was recruiting bright young minds instead of fighters...

Then they weren't building a terrorist network.

They were building a future.

And that was infinitely more dangerous.

The silence lasted several seconds.

Then General Vikram asked the question everyone was thinking.

"How long?"

Aryan's eyes remained on the screen.

His answer came quietly.

Too quietly.

"If we're seeing it now..."

A pause.

Then—

"We're already late."

And for the first time that night...

Nobody in the room had a response.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 20

Fault Lines

Part II

The briefing ended nearly an hour later.

Nobody left the conference room feeling relieved.

If anything, the situation looked worse than before.

Sentinel wasn't preparing a conventional attack. They weren't moving weapons, gathering explosives, or establishing strike teams. Instead, they were building influence. Quietly. Patiently. Across multiple cities.

And that made them far more dangerous.

As the officers filed out of the room, discussions continued in hushed voices. Analysts were already revising reports.

Intelligence teams were preparing new investigations. Fresh task forces would likely be formed before sunrise.

For everyone else, the war had become more complicated.

For Aryan, it had become personal.

He remained standing near the digital map long after the meeting ended, studying the highlighted cities. Looking for something everyone else had missed.

Rudra approached first.

"You've been staring at that map for ten minutes."

Aryan didn't look away.

"Eight."

Rudra rolled his eyes.

"Of course."

Silence followed.

Then Rudra's expression became serious.

"You think we're missing something."

It wasn't a question.

Aryan finally nodded.

"Sentinel wants us focused on recruitment."

"Because?"

"Because they know we'll stop looking elsewhere."

Rudra frowned.

"You really think there's another objective?"

Aryan's eyes narrowed slightly.

"I don't think."

A pause.

"I know."

That answer wasn't reassuring.

Not even a little.

Before Rudra could ask another question, a familiar voice interrupted them.

"Commander Sharma."

Both turned.

Arya stood near the doorway with a tablet in her hands.

The expression on her face immediately told Aryan he wasn't going to enjoy this conversation.

"What now?"

Arya folded her arms.

"Medical observation."

"No."

"That's not a request."

Aryan sighed.
Rudra immediately stepped backward.
Experience had taught him an important lesson.
Whenever these two started arguing, survival depended on maintaining a safe distance.
Arya looked directly at Aryan.
"You've been active for almost five hours."
"I'm sitting in meetings."
"You're recovering from life-threatening injuries."
"I'm fine."
"No, you're stubborn."
Aryan considered that.
Then shrugged.
"Also true."
Arya looked genuinely annoyed that he agreed.
Rudra almost laughed.
Almost.
Twenty minutes later, Aryan found himself back in his hospital room.
Against his will.
A fact Arya seemed unusually satisfied about.
She reviewed his latest reports while Aryan sat near the window.
Neither spoke for several minutes.
The silence would've been peaceful if they weren't both waiting for the other to start an argument.
Arya won.
"You ignored three recovery protocols today."
Aryan didn't even turn around.
"I attended a briefing."
"You ignored recovery protocols."
"The country won't stop having problems because I'm injured."
Arya looked up from the file.
"The country survived before you."
Aryan smirked slightly.
"There it is."
"There what is?"
"The unnecessary aggression."
Arya closed the file.
"The irony of you saying that is incredible."
Aryan finally looked toward her.
"And yet accurate."
For a moment they simply stared at each other.
Neither willing to back down.
Neither willing to admit the other occasionally had a point.
Then Arya sighed.
Something Aryan immediately noticed.
Because she rarely sighed.
Usually she argued.
"What's wrong?"
The question surprised both of them.
Arya especially.
For a second she almost answered honestly.
Then she remembered who she was talking to.
"Nothing."
Aryan raised an eyebrow.
"Terrible lie."

Arya looked away.
"Focus on your recovery."
"You changed the subject."
"Yes."
"Why?"
"Because I wanted to."
Aryan opened his mouth.
Arya pointed toward him immediately.
"Don't."
He closed it again.
Mostly because he had no response.
Later that evening, the hospital grew quiet. Most visitors had left. The corridors were nearly empty. Outside, city lights stretched across the darkness.
Aryan sat alone, reviewing the Sentinel files once more.
Something still bothered him.
The recruitment theory made sense.
Too much sense.
And that was exactly the problem.
Sentinel had spent years avoiding attention.
Organizations like that didn't suddenly become careless.
Which meant the recruitment trail was probably another layer.
Another distraction.
Another trap.
The thought refused to leave his mind.
A soft knock interrupted his concentration.
Before he could respond, the door opened.
Arya entered.
Two coffee cups in her hands.
Aryan immediately looked suspicious.
"You poisoned it?"
Arya stared at him.
"For the hundredth time, no."
"Just checking."
"I genuinely understand why people find you exhausting."
Aryan accepted the cup anyway.
After a brief hesitation.
The coffee wasn't terrible.
He would never admit that.
Arya sat near the window.
For several moments neither spoke.
The city lights reflected across the glass.
The room remained unusually calm.
Then Arya quietly asked,
"Do you ever stop thinking about work?"
Aryan looked outside.
"No."
The answer came instantly.
Without hesitation.
Without consideration.
Arya wasn't surprised.
For some reason, that made her sad.
"You should."
Aryan shook his head.

"Can't."

"Why?"

For the first time, he didn't answer immediately.

His gaze remained fixed on the city below.

Thousands of people.

Thousands of lives.

Completely unaware of the dangers surrounding them.

When he finally spoke, his voice was quieter than usual.

"Because if I stop..."

A pause.

Then—

"Someone else pays the price."

Arya didn't respond.

Because for the first time, she understood something important.

Aryan wasn't obsessed with responsibility because he enjoyed it.

He carried it because he believed he had to.

And sometimes...

The heaviest burdens were the ones people placed on themselves.

Outside the room, unseen by either of them, a nurse smiled while walking past.

Inside, neither Aryan nor Arya realized it.

But for the first time since they met...

They had spent nearly ten minutes together without a single argument.

And somehow, that felt stranger than any fight.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 20

Fault Lines

Part III

The hospital rooftop was empty.

Almost midnight.

The city below still glowed with life, but from this height everything looked distant. Smaller. Quieter.

Aryan preferred it that way.

No doctors.

No officers.

No reports.

No expectations.

Just silence.

For the past hour he had been sitting alone near the edge of the rooftop, staring at the sea of lights stretching across the city.

His coffee had long gone cold.

He hadn't noticed.

Or maybe he had.

He simply didn't care.

His mind kept returning to Sentinel.

To the briefing.

To the cities marked on the map.

To the feeling that something terrible was approaching and nobody could see it yet.

The worst part wasn't the uncertainty.

It was the waiting.

Waiting had always been the hardest part.

Because waiting gave memories room to breathe.

And Aryan had more memories than he cared to revisit.

The rooftop door suddenly opened.

He didn't need to turn around.

Only one person in the entire hospital entered a room with that much confidence.

Arya.

"You know normal people sleep at this hour."

Aryan continued staring at the city.

"You know normal people don't spend their nights searching hospital rooftops."

Arya walked over.

"Took me twenty minutes."

"Skill issue."

Arya rolled her eyes and sat beside him.

For a few moments neither spoke.

The wind moved softly around them.

Far below, traffic lights blinked like distant stars.

The silence wasn't uncomfortable anymore.

Which was strange.

Very strange.

Aryan hated admitting it.

But sitting beside Arya had become easier lately.

Not because he was less annoying.

He wasn't.
If anything, he had become more annoying.
But she had started understanding him.
And that made things complicated.
"You look tired."
Aryan laughed quietly.
A short, humorless sound.
"I almost died two weeks ago."
"Fair point."
Silence returned.
Then Arya spoke again.
"You never answer honestly."
Aryan glanced toward her.
"What?"
"When people ask if you're okay."
Aryan looked away.
"Because it's a stupid question."
"No."
Arya's voice softened.
"It's a normal question."
He didn't answer.
The city lights reflected in his eyes.
For the first time all day, he looked exhausted.
Not physically.
Something deeper.
The kind of exhaustion sleep couldn't fix.
Arya noticed.
And for some reason, that bothered her.
A lot.
"Why do you carry everything alone?"
The question escaped before she could stop it.
Aryan froze.
Only briefly.
But she noticed.
His jaw tightened.
His gaze dropped.
And suddenly the air felt heavier.
For several seconds he said nothing.
Then finally—
"Because that's the job."
Arya shook her head.
"No."
"What do you mean no?"
"I mean that's not the answer."
Aryan looked annoyed.
Good.
At least annoyed was familiar territory.
Arya continued.
"Your job is leading missions."
She pointed toward him.
"Your job is not carrying the entire world's weight on your shoulders."
A faint smile appeared.
"Tried telling the world that?"

"I'm serious."
"So am I."
The smile vanished.
Immediately.
Because he was serious.
Completely serious.
Arya suddenly realized something.
Aryan genuinely believed it.
Every death.
Every failure.
Every mission.
Every mistake.
He carried all of it.
As if it belonged to him.
As if he was personally responsible.
The realization made her chest tighten.
Because nobody should live like that.
Nobody.
"You can't save everyone."
Her voice was quiet.
Almost a whisper.
Aryan didn't respond.
"You know that, right?"
Still nothing.
Arya stared at him.
Waiting.
Then finally he laughed again.
That same empty laugh.
The one she was beginning to hate.
"Tell that to the families."
The words hit harder than she expected.
His eyes never left the city.
"Tell that to the parents waiting for their sons to come home."
A pause.
"Tell that to the wives."
Another pause.
"The children."
His voice grew quieter.
"And the men who trusted me."
Arya suddenly understood.
This wasn't about responsibility.
It was guilt.
Years of it.
Buried so deep that even Aryan probably couldn't separate the two anymore.
The wind passed between them.
Neither moved.
Then Aryan spoke again.
"I've lost people."
The words were simple.
Yet somehow they carried more weight than anything else.
"I remember every single one."
Arya's throat tightened.
Because she believed him.

Without question.
He remembered all of them.
Every name.
Every face.
Every funeral.
Every promise.
The burden must have been unbearable.
Yet he carried it anyway.
Every day.
Alone.
For the first time since meeting him...
She didn't see a soldier.
Or a commander.
Or the man everyone called a hero.
She saw someone tired.
Someone hurting.
Someone who had spent years convincing himself that pain was just another responsibility to manage.
And suddenly...
She felt angry.
Not at him.
At the fact that nobody seemed to notice.
Or maybe nobody knew how to help.
"That's not all on you."
Aryan's expression remained unchanged.
"It is."
"No."
"It is."
"No."
The answer came instantly.
Firmly.
Emotionally.
Enough to finally make him look at her.
Aryan's eyes glistened slightly.
Not with tears.
Not yet.
But close.
Very close.
"You keep acting like you're responsible for everything."
Her voice trembled.
Only a little.
"You're not."
Aryan looked away.
The conversation was becoming dangerous.
Too personal.
Too real.
He didn't like that.
"You don't understand."
The words escaped before he could stop them.
Immediately, Arya's expression changed.
Something flashed across her face.
Pain.
Raw and sudden.
"Don't do that."

Aryan frowned.
"What?"
"Don't decide what I understand."
Silence.
Arya stood.
Her hands clenched tightly.
For a second it looked like she wanted to say something.
Something important.
Something she had buried for years.
But she stopped herself.
Barely.
The words never came out.
Instead she took a slow breath.
Then another.
Trying to regain control.
Trying to stop old wounds from reopening.
Aryan watched quietly.
Confused.
Because for the first time...
He realized this conversation wasn't only about him.
It never had been.
Arya looked toward the city lights.
Her voice barely above a whisper.
"Some people know exactly what it feels like to lose someone."
The words hung in the air.
Heavy.
Painful.
Honest.
Aryan froze.
Because suddenly...
Everything clicked.
Her anger.
Her resentment toward the military.
The walls she kept around herself.
The way she reacted whenever death entered a conversation.
It wasn't hatred.
It was grief.
Old grief.
Unhealed grief.
The kind that stayed with a person for years.
Neither spoke after that.
There was nothing left to say.
Only silence.
And understanding.
For the first time since they met, neither of them won the argument.
Neither lost.
Because some battles weren't meant to be won.
Only understood.
Far below, the city continued moving.
Unaware of the war quietly approaching.
Unaware of Sentinel.
Unaware of the choices waiting ahead.
But on that rooftop...

Two people finally caught a glimpse of the scars the other carried.
And neither of them would forget it.

End of Chapter 20

Chapter 21

Breaking Point

Part I

Three days later.

Aryan hated hospitals.

Not because of the pain.

Not because of the tests.

Not because of the endless recovery sessions.

He hated them because hospitals forced him to do the one thing he could never tolerate.

Nothing.

Outside those walls, Sentinel was moving. Intelligence teams were working around the clock. Field agents were chasing leads.

Operations were being planned. People were risking their lives.

And he was stuck counting ceiling tiles.

It was torture.

The morning began with what Aryan assumed would be another routine evaluation. Unfortunately, this one involved every doctor responsible for his recovery.

Which was never a good sign.

Especially when Arya was present.

She sat at the end of the conference table reviewing reports while several specialists discussed his condition.

Scans.

Muscle recovery.

Neurological assessments.

Physical rehabilitation.

Words Aryan had stopped caring about days ago.

Finally, the lead physician closed the file.

"We've reached a decision."

Aryan immediately looked up.

Good.

Finally.

He was getting discharged.

About time.

The doctor adjusted his glasses.

"Your recovery is progressing exceptionally well."

Aryan nodded.

Obviously.

"However..."

And there it was.

The word every patient hated.

However.

The doctor's expression remained professional.

"We are not clearing you for active field deployment."

Silence.

Aryan blinked once.

Then twice.

Certain he had misheard.

"I'm sorry?"

The doctor repeated himself.

"You are medically stable."

A pause.

"But not operationally fit."
The room became very quiet.
Aryan slowly looked toward Arya.
She didn't look surprised.
Which told him everything.
"You knew."
Arya met his gaze.
"Yes."
The answer arrived without hesitation.
His jaw tightened.
"How long?"
"Two days."
Aryan laughed.
A short, humorless laugh.
The kind that usually appeared right before things went badly.
"So everyone knew except me."
"No."
Arya's voice remained calm.
"You knew exactly what the answer would be."
The statement hit harder than she intended.
Because deep down...
She was right.
Aryan had known.
He simply hadn't wanted to hear it.
The lead physician continued.
"We recommend another three weeks."
Aryan stared at him.
Three weeks.
To most people, that sounded reasonable.
To Aryan, it sounded impossible.
Three weeks was an eternity.
Three weeks was enough time for a network like Sentinel to disappear.
Enough time for leads to go cold.
Enough time for mistakes to happen.
Enough time for people to die.
"No."
The word escaped before he could stop it.
Several doctors exchanged glances.
The lead physician sighed.
"Commander Sharma—"
"No."
This time his voice was firmer.
Sharper.
More dangerous.
"I've already lost enough time."
"Your injuries disagree."
"I didn't ask my injuries."
Arya immediately closed her file.
Bad sign.
Very bad sign.
"Aryan."
He looked toward her.
"What?"
For several seconds she simply stared at him.
Then quietly asked,

"Do you honestly hear yourself?"
The room froze.
Because her tone wasn't angry.
It was disappointed.
And somehow that felt worse.
Aryan looked away.
He didn't want disappointment.
Disappointment implied concern.
Concern implied vulnerability.
And vulnerability was something he had spent years avoiding.
The lead physician finally stood.
"The decision is final."
No negotiation.
No discussion.
No appeal.
Final.
Aryan hated that word almost as much as "however."
The meeting ended shortly afterward.
Doctors left.
Specialists left.
Reports disappeared.
Eventually only Aryan and Arya remained.
The silence stretched between them.
Heavy.
Uncomfortable.
Aryan grabbed the medical clearance papers from the table.
Then threw them back down.
Hard.
"They have no idea what's coming."
Arya crossed her arms.
"No."
Her voice remained calm.
"They have every idea."
Aryan laughed bitterly.
"You really think three extra weeks matters?"
"No."
She looked directly at him.
"I think being alive matters."
The words landed harder than either of them expected.
For a brief moment, neither spoke.
Then Aryan looked away.
Toward the window.
Toward the city.
Toward the world he felt trapped away from.
And quietly said,
"You don't understand."
The moment the words left his mouth...
Something changed in Arya's expression.
Not anger.
Not frustration.
Something deeper.
Something older.
Pain.
Raw.
Instant.

Gone almost as quickly as it appeared.
But Aryan noticed it.
For the first time...
He noticed it.
Arya picked up her file.
Her voice suddenly much colder than before.
"Maybe."
She turned toward the door.
Then stopped.
Without looking back.
"And maybe you're not the only person who's ever lost someone."
The door closed behind her.
Leaving Aryan alone.
Staring at the empty room.
For reasons he couldn't explain...
Those words bothered him far more than the medical decision ever had.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 21

Breaking Point

Part II

The next two days were terrible.

At least according to Aryan.

Doctors called it recovery.

Nurses called it progress.

Arya called it common sense.

Aryan called it imprisonment.

Sentinel investigations continued across the country. New reports arrived daily. Intelligence teams worked around the clock.

Alpha Team attended briefings without him.

And every single update made his frustration worse.

By the third day, he had completely stopped pretending to cooperate.

Which was exactly how Arya found him at eleven-thirty that night.

The lights inside his room were off.

The only illumination came from the laptop screen sitting on the table.

Classified documents.

Intelligence reports.

Satellite imagery.

Encrypted communication records.

Arya froze in the doorway.

Then slowly closed the door behind her.

Very slowly.

Very quietly.

The kind of quiet that usually meant danger.

Aryan looked up.

Immediately realizing he had been caught.

Neither spoke for several seconds.

Arya stared at the screen.

Then at him.

Then back at the screen.

"Aryan."

That was all she said.

Just his name.

Somehow it sounded worse than shouting.

Aryan calmly closed the laptop.

Unfortunately for him, she had already seen everything.

"How did you even get access to those files?"

"I'm military."

"You are a patient."

"I'm both."

Arya closed her eyes.

Counted to three.

Opened them again.

"You promised."

"I never promised anything."

"You literally promised."

"I said I'd rest."

"You said you'd stay away from work."

"I rested while working."
Arya stared at him.
For a full five seconds.
"Aryan."
"No, hear me out."
"I'm trying very hard not to throw that laptop out the window."
"That's not a reasonable response."
"Neither is secretly reviewing classified intelligence reports after midnight."
For once...
Aryan didn't have a comeback.
Which only annoyed her more.
She walked over and grabbed the laptop.
Immediately.
Without warning.
"What are you doing?"
"What I should've done days ago."
"Arya."
"No."
"Arya."
"No."
"Arya."
"No."
She shut the laptop.
Completely.
Then placed it inside a drawer.
Locked it.
And put the key in her pocket.
Aryan looked genuinely offended.
"You can't do that."
"I just did."
"That's military property."
"Good."
She crossed her arms.
"File a complaint."
The room fell silent.
Neither willing to surrender.
Neither willing to back down.
Eventually Aryan leaned back in his chair.
"You think this is a joke."
Arya's expression immediately changed.
"No."
The answer came instantly.
"No, Aryan. That's the problem."
Her voice wasn't angry.
It was tired.
Completely exhausted.
"You think this is all on you."
Aryan looked away.
"There are people out there risking their lives."
"There are always people risking their lives."
"They need me."
The words escaped before he could stop them.
The moment they did, Arya laughed.
A short laugh.
Bitter.

Disbelieving.

Almost painful.

"No."

Aryan frowned.

"No?"

"No."

She stepped closer.

"They don't need you."

His jaw tightened.

"They do."

"No."

Her voice rose slightly.

"The military survived before you."

"It isn't about me."

"Then what is it about?"

Aryan stood.

Ignoring the sharp pain shooting through his shoulder.

Ignoring everything.

His patience was running dangerously thin.

"It's about responsibility."

Arya shook her head.

"No."

"Yes."

"No."

"Yes."

For the first time in days, genuine anger appeared in both of their voices.

The tension in the room became suffocating.

Arya pointed toward him.

"You know what your problem is?"

Aryan laughed.

"Please. Enlighten me."

"You think carrying everything alone makes you strong."

His expression hardened.

"You have no idea what you're talking about."

"Then tell me."

Silence.

Arya stepped forward again.

Closer this time.

"Tell me."

Nothing.

"You don't trust anyone."

"I trust my team."

"That's not what I mean."

"Then what do you mean?"

Arya's voice softened.

Only slightly.

"I mean you don't let anyone in."

The words hit somewhere deeper than she intended.

Deep enough that Aryan immediately looked away.

Deep enough that he didn't answer.

And that silence gave her the answer she needed.

For a moment, neither spoke.

The room felt smaller now.

Heavier.

Then Arya asked the question she probably shouldn't have.

The question that finally pushed him too far.
"Are you really that afraid of depending on someone?"
Aryan's head snapped toward her.
Something dark flashed across his face.
Not anger.
Something older.
Something buried.
Something he hadn't allowed himself to feel in years.
And when he finally spoke...
His voice was cold.
Dangerously cold.
"You don't know anything about me."
The words hit harder than shouting ever could.
Arya froze.
Aryan immediately regretted it.
Not because it wasn't true.
Because of the look on her face.
For the first time since meeting her...
She looked hurt.
Actually hurt.
Not annoyed.
Not angry.
Hurt.
But neither of them backed down.
Neither of them knew how.
And somewhere deep inside, both could feel it.
This argument was no longer about recovery.
No longer about hospitals.
No longer about Sentinel.
It had become something else.
Something personal.
Something neither of them could stop anymore.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 21

Breaking Point

Part III

The room fell silent.
Arya stood frozen beside the table.
Aryan stood near the window.
Neither moved.
Neither spoke.
The tension hanging between them felt suffocating.
"You don't know anything about me."
The words echoed in Arya's head.
Again.
And again.
And again.
For several seconds she simply stared at him.
As if trying to understand whether he actually meant what he had said.
The worst part?
He did.
Aryan looked away first.
Not because he wanted to.
Because a part of him already regretted it.
The look on her face was unfamiliar.
He had seen her angry.
Annoyed.
Frustrated.
Sarcastic.
But not this.
Not hurt.
Never hurt.
And somehow that felt worse than any argument they had ever had.
Arya took a slow breath.
Then another.
Trying to calm herself.
Trying to stop years of buried emotions from surfacing.
Trying and failing.
"You know what?"
Her voice was quiet.
Too quiet.
Aryan immediately knew something was wrong.
"You're right."
He looked up.
Arya laughed softly.
A broken laugh.
The kind people make when they're trying not to cry.
"You're absolutely right."
Something twisted inside Aryan's chest.
For the first time since meeting her...
She wasn't arguing.
And that scared him more than shouting ever could.

"Arya..."

"No."

She shook her head.

"No, let's do this."

The calmness in her voice was dangerous.

Far more dangerous than anger.

"You don't want help."

She looked directly at him.

"You don't want support."

A step forward.

"You don't want people worrying about you."

Another step.

"You don't want people caring about you."

Aryan remained silent.

Because every word was landing exactly where she intended.

"And do you know what's funny?"

Her voice cracked slightly.

Just slightly.

But Aryan heard it.

Every single crack.

"You act like that's strength."

Silence.

"It isn't."

Aryan clenched his fists.

"Arya—"

"No."

This time her voice rose.

Not much.

Just enough.

"You know what I see?"

Her eyes were shining now.

Dangerously close.

"I see someone so terrified of losing people..."

Her voice broke.

"...that he'd rather push them away first."

The words hit like a punch.

Direct.

Accurate.

Merciless.

And Aryan hated how much they sounded true.

The room became silent again.

Neither looked away.

Then finally—

Aryan spoke.

Cold.

Defensive.

Instinctive.

"I don't need anyone."

The moment the sentence left his mouth...

Everything stopped.

Even Aryan knew it.

The second he said it.

The second he saw her expression.

He knew.

He had gone too far.

Arya froze.
Completely.
For a moment she simply stared at him.
Disbelief.
Shock.
Pain.
All mixed together.
Then she laughed.
A small laugh.
Broken.
Almost heartbreaking.
"Fine."
Aryan immediately regretted everything.
But it was too late.
Far too late.
"Fine."
This time her voice shook.
"Stay alone."
Silence.
"Keep pushing everyone away."
Her eyes glistened.
"Keep pretending nobody matters."
Aryan opened his mouth.
Nothing came out.
Not a single word.
Because for the first time...
He didn't know what to say.
Arya took another shaky breath.
Then another.
Trying desperately to hold herself together.
Failing.
"Keep pretending losing people doesn't affect you."
The tears finally appeared.
Not many.
Just enough.
And somehow that made it worse.
Much worse.
"Arya..."
His voice sounded weak.
Pathetic.
Useless.
She ignored him.
Completely.
Because years of grief had finally cracked open.
Years.
Not days.
Not months.
Years.
"You know what?"
Her voice trembled.
"I would've given anything..."
A tear rolled down her cheek.
"...anything..."
Another.
"...to have one more day."

Aryan froze.
The room disappeared.
The hospital disappeared.
Everything disappeared.
Only her words remained.
One more day.
Arya looked away.
Unable to meet his eyes anymore.
As if saying the words hurt too much.
"Asking for help isn't weakness."
Her voice dropped to a whisper.
"Needing people isn't weakness."
Another tear.
"Having people who care about you isn't weakness."
Then finally...
The truth she had carried for years escaped.
Raw.
Unfiltered.
Painful.
"One day they're there."
Silence.
"And the next day..."
Her voice shattered completely.
"...they're gone."
Aryan's breath caught.
Because suddenly he understood.
Not fully.
Not completely.
But enough.
Enough to finally see the wound she carried.
Enough to finally understand why every conversation about death affected her.
Enough to understand why she reacted the way she did after the bombing.
Why she got angry.
Why she kept fighting him.
Why she kept trying to stop him from destroying himself.
She wasn't afraid of soldiers.
She wasn't angry at the military.
She was terrified of loss.
Because she had already lived through it.
And she never wanted to watch it happen again.
Not to someone else.
Not in front of her.
Not twice.
The realization hit harder than any bullet ever could.
Aryan stood motionless.
No strategy.
No comeback.
No argument.
Nothing.
For the first time in years...
He had absolutely no defense.
Arya wiped her eyes angrily.
As if she hated the fact that she had cried.
Especially in front of him.
Then she moved toward the door.

Slowly.
Without looking back.
Without saying another word.
The door opened.
Then—
"Arya."
She stopped.
But didn't turn around.
Aryan stared at the floor.
His chest felt unbearably heavy.
Because there was something he wanted to say.
Something he needed to say.
But for the first time in his life...
The words refused to come.
An apology.
A comfort.
Anything.
Nothing came out.
And that silence said more than words ever could.
A second later, the door closed.
Leaving Aryan alone.
Completely alone.
The room suddenly felt much larger.
Much emptier.
Much colder.
For several minutes he didn't move.
Didn't think.
Didn't speak.
Then slowly he sat down.
The same sentence echoing inside his head.
Not his own.
Hers.
"One day they're there..."
"And the next day..."
"They're gone."
For the first time in a very long time...
Aryan understood something.
The people who carried grief weren't always the ones who talked about it.
Sometimes...
They were the ones smiling the hardest.
Fighting the hardest.
Pretending the hardest.
And somewhere down the hallway, behind a closed door, Arya was crying for someone she had lost years ago.
While inside Room 703...
Aryan Sharma sat awake until sunrise.
Thinking about someone other than himself.
For the very first time.
End of Chapter 21

Chapter 22

Aftermath

Part II

Rudra's words stayed with Aryan long after their conversation ended.

You might actually be the dumbest intelligent person I've ever met.

Normally, he would've ignored a comment like that.

Normally.

But for some reason, this time he couldn't.

Maybe because Rudra wasn't entirely wrong.

The next few days passed in an uncomfortable routine. Physical therapy in the morning. Medical evaluations in the afternoon.

Endless reports about recovery progress. The kind of schedule that would've driven Aryan insane even under normal circumstances.

Now it was worse.

Because every corridor reminded him of someone.

Every nurses' station.

Every cafeteria visit.

Every elevator ride.

Somewhere in the hospital, Arya was always there.

And somehow nowhere at all.

Whenever he entered a room, she had already left.

Whenever he passed a department, she was busy elsewhere.

Whenever their paths crossed, she acknowledged him with the same professional nod she gave complete strangers before continuing on her way.

No arguments.

No sarcastic comments.

No lectures.

Nothing.

And Aryan was beginning to realize something he never thought possible.

He preferred the arguments.

At least when they fought, she talked to him.

Three days later, Alpha Team gathered in a private lounge near the rehabilitation wing.

Officially, they were there for a team meeting.

Unofficially, they were there because every single one of them was bored out of their minds.

"Six months leave," Kabir complained while scrolling through his phone. "I used to dream about this."

"You've complained about it every day for two weeks."

"Because I was wrong."

Across the room, Aditya nodded solemnly.

"We all were."

Rudra looked genuinely offended.

"Do you people understand how many soldiers would kill for six months off?"

"Exactly," Kabir replied. "And now I understand why."

The room erupted into laughter.

Even Aryan managed a small smile.

A rare achievement these days.

Rudra immediately noticed.

And unfortunately for Aryan, that was all the invitation he needed.

"Look at that."

Aryan already knew where this was going.

"Don't."

"We got a smile."

"Rudra."

"We should document this historical event."

Kabir immediately joined in.

"Get a camera."

Aditya nodded.

"The nation must know."

Aryan considered leaving.

Unfortunately, the idiots were his family.

And family had a tendency to be impossible.

For several minutes the conversation drifted toward old missions and embarrassing stories. The atmosphere gradually became lighter, more familiar. It reminded Aryan why Alpha Team worked so well.

Because they weren't just soldiers.

They were brothers.

Then, inevitably, Rudra ruined everything.

"So."

Aryan narrowed his eyes.

"No."

"I haven't asked anything yet."

"You don't have to."

The grin on Rudra's face immediately put everyone on alert.

Kabir sat forward.

"Oh no."

Aditya looked interested.

"What's happening?"

Rudra ignored them both.

Instead, he focused entirely on Aryan.

"Have you apologized?"

The room became silent.

Dead silent.

Then every pair of eyes turned toward Aryan.

Slowly.

Simultaneously.

Like a pack of predators spotting prey.

Aryan immediately regretted coming here.

"What are you talking about?"

The lie was terrible.

Everyone knew it.

Especially Rudra.

"Oh, we're pretending now."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

Kabir nearly laughed himself off the couch.

Aditya looked delighted.

For perhaps the first time in years, Alpha Team had discovered something capable of making Aryan uncomfortable.

And they intended to enjoy every second of it.

Rudra folded his arms.

"Fine."

Aryan relaxed slightly.

Then Rudra continued.

"Doctor Arya."

The relaxation vanished immediately.

The room exploded.

Kabir actually stood up.

"No way."

Aditya looked between them.

"Wait."

His eyes widened.

"WAIT."

Aryan closed his eyes.

This was a nightmare.

An actual nightmare.

"Nothing happened."

The statement only made things worse.

Because everyone knew that when someone said *nothing happened*, something had absolutely happened.

Rudra looked almost proud.

"She made him miserable."

Kabir pointed dramatically.

"I knew it."

Aditya nodded.

"I've never seen him this irritated before."

Aryan seriously considered requesting a transfer.

To another city.

Possibly another country.

The laughter eventually died down, but Rudra's expression grew more serious.

The shift was immediate enough that everyone noticed.

"So what are you going to do?"

Aryan looked away.

The answer should've been simple.

Apologize.

Except it wasn't.

Because apologies required admitting fault.

And admitting fault required vulnerability.

Neither had ever been easy for him.

Especially not after years of military life.

In combat, hesitation got people killed.

In leadership, uncertainty spread fear.

Over time, he'd learned to suppress anything that looked remotely like weakness.

The problem was that life outside missions didn't follow the same rules.

And Arya wasn't one of his soldiers.

She wasn't someone he could protect through strategy or planning.

For perhaps the first time in his life, Aryan found himself facing a problem he couldn't solve through discipline, intelligence, or force of will.

Rudra studied him quietly.

Then sighed.

"You know what's funny?"

Aryan didn't answer.

"You've stared down terrorists, survived firefights, infiltrated enemy territory, and walked into situations most people wouldn't survive for five minutes."

A small smile appeared on Rudra's face.

"But saying two words terrifies you."

Aryan frowned.

"What two words?"

Rudra looked genuinely offended.

"I'm sorry, you idiot."

The room erupted again.

This time even Aryan couldn't stop a reluctant smile from appearing.

A small one.

Brief.

Gone almost immediately.

But it was there.

And for the first time in days, the weight in his chest felt slightly lighter.

Only slightly.

Unfortunately, life rarely allowed peace to last.

Because at that exact moment, the television mounted on the wall switched to a breaking news broadcast.

Every smile disappeared.

Every conversation stopped.

And within seconds, the atmosphere in the room changed completely.

Something had happened.

Something serious.

And judging by the look on Aryan's face...

The peaceful days were about to end.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 22

Aftermath

Part III

The laughter disappeared almost instantly.

Every member of Alpha Team turned toward the television mounted on the wall as the regular program was interrupted by a breaking news broadcast.

The red banner at the bottom of the screen immediately caught Aryan's attention.

BREAKING NEWS

Mass Cyberattack Disrupts Multiple Research Networks Across Northern India

The room fell silent.

The news anchor continued speaking while images flashed across the screen.

Universities.

Research institutes.

Technology centers.

Government-funded laboratories.

Servers were down.

Communication systems had been compromised.

Several classified research databases had reportedly been accessed.

No organization had claimed responsibility.

Not yet.

But Aryan already knew.

His expression hardened.

Rudra noticed immediately.

"So it's them."

It wasn't a question.

Aryan nodded.

Slowly.

"They've started moving."

The joking atmosphere from minutes earlier vanished completely.

Everyone straightened.

Instinct taking over.

Soldiers again.

Always soldiers.

Twenty minutes later, a secure military vehicle arrived outside the hospital.

Official summons.

Priority One.

The same message was waiting on every Alpha Team member's phone.

Aryan read it twice.

Then looked toward the hospital building.

A strange feeling settled in his chest.

Because this was the first time since the explosion that he was being called back into something important.

Back into the fight.

And yet...

His thoughts weren't focused on Sentinel.

Or the cyberattacks.

Or the investigation.

They were focused on someone else.

Someone he still hadn't spoken to.

Someone he still hadn't apologized to.
Someone who was probably avoiding him right now.
The realization irritated him.
Mostly because it refused to go away.

Military Headquarters.
One hour later.
The briefing room looked far more crowded than usual.
Senior intelligence officers.
Cyber warfare specialists.
Counter-intelligence divisions.
Even representatives from several civilian agencies had been called in.
Whatever happened was serious.
General Vikram stood at the center of the room.
His expression alone told everyone enough.
"This wasn't an attack."
The statement immediately confused several officers.
One analyst frowned.
"Sir?"

General Vikram changed the display.
The room froze.
Rows of names appeared across the screen.
Hundreds of them.
Students.
Researchers.
Software engineers.
Cybersecurity specialists.
Artificial intelligence developers.
The youngest was nineteen.
The oldest barely thirty-five.
A cold feeling settled over the room.
"What you're looking at," General Vikram said quietly, "is a list of individuals connected to Sentinel."
Silence.
Complete silence.
Then someone finally asked the obvious question.
"Connected how?"
The answer came from another officer.
His voice sounded grim.
"Not recruits."
The screen changed again.
Photographs appeared.
Documents.
Encrypted communications.
Financial transactions.
Years of records.
Years.
The realization slowly spread across the room.
These weren't future recruits.
These weren't potential members.
These people were already inside the system.
Already employed.
Already positioned.
Already waiting.
Aryan felt his stomach tighten.
Because suddenly the puzzle pieces fit together.

The universities.
The research centers.
The recruitment network.
The communications.
Everything.
Sentinel hadn't been building a future.
They had built it years ago.
Nobody had noticed.
General Vikram's next words sent a chill through the room.
"They've spent nearly a decade placing people exactly where they wanted them."
No one spoke.
No one moved.
Because for the first time, everyone understood the scale of the threat.
This wasn't a terrorist organization.
This wasn't a criminal network.
This wasn't even an insurgency.
This was infiltration.
Patient.
Methodical.
Brilliant.
Terrifying.

The briefing continued for another hour.
By the end, every officer in the room looked exhausted.
Not physically.
Mentally.
Because the enemy they were facing wasn't hiding in mountains.
Or forests.
Or abandoned warehouses.
They were sitting inside offices.
Laboratories.
Research centers.
Government institutions.
Blending in.
Waiting.
Watching.
And nobody knew how many existed.

As the meeting finally ended, people began leaving in silence.
Aryan remained seated.
Staring at the final slide on the screen.
Something still bothered him.
Something wasn't adding up.
Sentinel had revealed itself intentionally.
Why?
Organizations this intelligent didn't make mistakes.
Every move served a purpose.
Every action had a goal.
So why now?
Why expose part of their network?
His eyes narrowed.
And suddenly...
A possibility appeared.
A terrible possibility.
His pulse quickened.

Because if he was right...
Then today's cyberattack wasn't the operation.
It was another distraction.
The exact same conclusion he had reached weeks ago.
The exact same pattern.
The exact same strategy.
Someone was making the military look in one direction.
Again.
Which meant—
His phone vibrated.
The sudden interruption broke his concentration.
Aryan glanced down.
Then froze.
The message wasn't from Intelligence.
Or Alpha Team.
Or Headquarters.
It was from an unknown number.
Only a single line.
No greeting.
No signature.
No explanation.
Just seven words.

"Tell me, Commander... was she worth it?"

Aryan's blood ran cold.
For the first time in years...
Someone had reached him directly.
Not the military.
Not Alpha Team.
Him.
Personally.
The message vanished seconds later.
Automatically deleted.
Leaving only a blank screen.
A warning.
Or a challenge.
Maybe both.
And somewhere far away...
Someone was watching.
Someone who knew his name.
Someone who knew about the explosion.
Someone who knew enough to make this personal.
Aryan slowly looked up.
His expression darker than before.
Because he understood something now.
Sentinel wasn't just aware of Alpha Team.
They were aware of him.
And if they knew about him...
Then sooner or later...
They would learn about the people around him too.

Chapter 23

Personal

Part I

The message disappeared before Aryan could even process it.

One moment the words were on his screen.

The next, they were gone.

No notification history. No trace. No record that it had ever existed.

For several seconds he remained seated in the briefing room, staring at the blank display of his phone. Around him, officers were gathering their files and leaving after what had already been one of the most disturbing intelligence briefings in recent months.

Nobody noticed the subtle change in his expression.

But General Vikram did.

The old soldier had spent years reading people in high-pressure situations. He noticed immediately when Aryan stopped paying attention to his surroundings.

"What happened?" he asked.

Without a word, Aryan handed him the phone.

The General read the message once.

Then again.

The color drained from his face.

Within minutes, the briefing room that had nearly emptied was operational once more. Intelligence officers returned. Cyber specialists were called in. Laptops appeared across the conference table. Secure channels were activated. Whatever plans people had for the evening were immediately forgotten.

Because one fact had become painfully clear.

Someone had reached Aryan Sharma directly.

Not through military systems.

Not through government channels.

Directly.

And nobody knew how.

The investigation lasted nearly two hours.

By the end of it, nobody was happy.

The Cyber Operations Division had examined every possible route. Every communication log. Every network connection. Every active process on Aryan's device. They traced incoming traffic, reviewed encrypted packets, reconstructed system activity, and analyzed every digital footprint they could find.

The result?

Nothing.

Absolutely nothing.

The message might as well have never existed.

"This doesn't make sense," one analyst muttered, frustration evident in his voice. "Messages don't just appear out of nowhere."

"They do if someone wants to send a message," Aryan replied quietly.

The room fell silent.

Several analysts looked toward him.

Aryan stood and walked toward the display screen showing the forensic reconstruction of his phone's activity. He studied the data for nearly a minute before pointing toward a cluster of corrupted system logs.

"There."

The lead analyst frowned.

"What about it?"

"That's where you're looking for a sender."

The analyst nodded.

"Because that's where the sender should be."

Aryan shook his head.

"No. That's where they wanted you to look."

A heavy silence settled across the room.

Slowly, the implications became clear.

The message wasn't meant to communicate information.

It wasn't meant to threaten.

It wasn't even meant to stay.

The message itself was irrelevant.

The real objective was proving that they could reach him whenever they wanted.

General Arjun leaned forward in his chair.

"You think this was intentional?"

Aryan almost laughed.

"Everything Sentinel does is intentional."

Nobody argued.

Because deep down, everyone knew he was right.

For months they had been chasing shadows. Every move made by Sentinel had been calculated. Every clue had been placed deliberately. Every leak had served a purpose.

And now they had escalated.

They had moved from manipulating military intelligence to manipulating people.

Specifically him.

The realization unsettled even Aryan.

Not because he was afraid.

Fear had stopped controlling him years ago.

What unsettled him was the precision.

The sender knew exactly what to write.

Not a threat.

Not a warning.

A question.

Seven words.

"Tell me, Commander... was she worth it?"

That was what bothered him.

The word *she*.

Who?

Arya?

Impossible.

Nothing had happened between them.

At least nothing Sentinel should know about.

Then why did the question feel so personal?

Why did it feel targeted?

Why did it refuse to leave his mind?

By the time the investigation finally ended, Aryan had more questions than answers.

And that was something he hated.

Outside headquarters, the city was quiet. Midnight traffic moved through the streets below while distant lights stretched across the horizon. Normally, he would've used the drive back to analyze reports or review mission data.

Tonight he found himself staring out the window.

Thinking about a doctor.

Thinking about an argument.

Thinking about tears.

Thinking about words he wished he could take back.

The realization irritated him.

Sentinel had somehow managed to occupy less space in his thoughts than Arya.

And that was probably the most frustrating part of all.

The following morning, Aryan returned to St. Thomas Hospital. The building was exactly as he remembered it—busy corridors, rushing nurses, doctors moving between departments, patients beginning another ordinary day.

For the first time in years, Aryan found himself hoping to see someone.

Unfortunately, that someone was Arya.

And judging by the way she'd avoided him for nearly a week...
He suspected facing Sentinel might actually be the easier mission.

Chapter 23

Personal

Part II

Aryan spent the next two days trying to convince himself that the conversation could wait.
It was a strategy that worked surprisingly well.
At least until he saw her.
Then it stopped working completely.
The problem wasn't finding Arya.
The problem was finding the courage to walk over and start a conversation he wasn't prepared for.
Which was ridiculous.
Aryan Sharma had led hostage rescue operations.
He had negotiated under gunfire.
Faced terrorists, warlords, and death more times than he could count.
Yet somehow a five-foot-four doctor was causing him more stress than any mission in recent memory.
Rudra found the situation endlessly entertaining.
"Still haven't done it?"
Aryan looked up from the report he was pretending to read.
"Done what?"
Rudra nearly choked.
"Oh, we're still acting?"
"I'm reading."
"No, you're hiding."
Aryan threw a folder at him.
Unfortunately, Rudra caught it.
"That would've been cooler if I didn't see it coming."
"Leave."
"No."
Rudra leaned back comfortably.
"You know what your problem is?"
Aryan sighed.
"I regret asking."
"You think apologies need to be perfect."
Aryan frowned.
"What?"
Rudra shrugged.
"You keep overthinking it."
"I'm not overthinking anything."
"You're literally overthinking right now."
The annoying part was that Rudra was right.
Again.
Aryan hated when that happened.
The truth was simple.
He knew he had crossed a line.
He knew he had hurt her.
He knew she deserved an apology.
The problem was that he had absolutely no idea how to give one.
Years in the military had taught him how to lead men.
How to make impossible decisions.
How to survive.

Nobody had ever taught him how to fix a broken conversation.

The opportunity arrived later that evening.

The hospital cafeteria was nearly empty. Most visitors had already left, and the few remaining patients sat quietly in distant corners.

Aryan had come for coffee.

Or at least that was the excuse he gave himself.

The moment he entered, he spotted her.

Arya sat alone near the window, reviewing patient files while absentmindedly stirring a cup of coffee that had probably gone cold twenty minutes ago.

For several seconds he simply stood there.

Watching.

Thinking.

Trying to decide whether this was a good idea.

It wasn't.

He walked over anyway.

The chair opposite her scraped lightly against the floor.

Arya looked up.

The moment she saw him, her expression became unreadable.

Not angry.

Not sad.

Not annoyed.

Just distant.

Somehow that hurt more.

"Can I help you?" she asked.

Professional.

Polite.

Cold.

Aryan suddenly missed the arguments.

At least arguments meant she cared enough to react.

He sat down.

For a few moments neither spoke.

The silence stretched awkwardly between them.

Finally Arya closed her file.

"What do you need?"

Direct.

Efficient.

Exactly like her.

Aryan stared at the coffee cup in front of him.

For perhaps the first time in years, he genuinely didn't know what to say.

Which was a terrifying feeling.

Arya waited.

When no answer came, she reached for her file again.

"I'll take that as—"

"I shouldn't have said it."

The words left before he could second-guess them.

Arya froze.

Her hand stopped midway.

The file remained untouched.

Neither moved.

Neither spoke.

The noise of the cafeteria seemed to disappear entirely.

Aryan exhaled slowly.

"I shouldn't have said you didn't understand."

Arya continued looking at him.

Silent.
Waiting.
For once, there was nowhere to hide.
No mission.
No distraction.
No escape.
Just honesty.
Painfully uncomfortable honesty.
"I was angry."
A pause.
"That doesn't excuse it."
Another pause.
"But it's the truth."
Arya lowered her eyes.
Not because she forgave him.
Because she hadn't expected this.
Not from him.
Especially not from him.
Aryan looked away briefly.
Almost embarrassed.
Which was probably the strangest thing she'd ever seen.
"I know I hurt you."
The admission felt heavier than any confession he'd ever made.
Because it was easier to face bullets than guilt.
Much easier.
For a long moment Arya said nothing.
Then she quietly asked,
"Do you even know why?"
Aryan opened his mouth.
Stopped.
Then slowly shook his head.
"No."
The honesty surprised her.
It surprised him too.
Arya stared out the window for several seconds before speaking.
"When my father died, everyone kept saying the same thing."
Her voice was calm.
Too calm.
The kind of calm that usually hid old wounds.
"They told me to be strong."
Aryan remained silent.
"They told me time would make it easier."
A faint smile appeared.
A sad one.
"It didn't."
The smile disappeared almost immediately.
"I learned how to live with it."
The words settled heavily between them.
Aryan listened carefully.
Not because he felt obligated.
Because for the first time he genuinely wanted to understand.
"My father believed in service."
Arya continued staring outside.
"He believed some things were worth sacrificing for."
A short laugh escaped her.

"He would've liked you."

That statement caught Aryan completely off guard.

"What?"

Arya finally looked at him.

"You're both equally stubborn."

Against all logic, a small smile appeared on his face.

The first real smile in days.

It vanished quickly.

But she noticed.

And for the first time since their argument...

The distance between them felt slightly smaller.

Not gone.

Just smaller.

Arya looked down at her coffee.

"I know why you do what you do."

Her voice softened.

"I know why you keep carrying everything."

Then her eyes met his again.

"But that doesn't mean you have to carry it alone."

The words hit harder than they should have.

Because deep down...

A part of Aryan had always known she was right.

The problem was that accepting help felt far more frightening than facing danger.

For several moments neither spoke.

The silence wasn't hostile anymore.

Just complicated.

Then Arya checked the time and stood.

Duty called.

As it always did.

She gathered her files and moved toward the exit.

Halfway there, she stopped.

Turned back.

And for the first time in nearly a week, the coldness in her eyes was gone.

Not completely.

But enough.

"Aryan."

He looked up.

The corner of her mouth lifted slightly.

A tiny smile.

Barely visible.

"You still owe me a coffee."

Then she walked away.

Leaving Aryan staring after her.

Confused.

Relieved.

And for the first time in several days...

Hopeful.

Unfortunately for him, the peaceful moment lasted exactly thirty seconds.

Because his phone vibrated.

One new message.

Unknown sender.

No number.

No trace.

Aryan's expression darkened immediately.

The message contained only four words.

"Round one is over."

And suddenly he knew.

Sentinel wasn't watching from a distance anymore.

They were playing a game.

And somehow...

He had already become part of it.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 23

Personal

Part III

Aryan stared at the message for several seconds.

Round one is over.

That was it.

No threat.

No explanation.

No demand.

Just four words.

Yet somehow they unsettled him more than the previous message.

Because threats were predictable.

This wasn't.

The message disappeared before he could forward it to anyone.

One moment it was there.

The next, the screen was blank again.

As if someone was standing over his shoulder, watching.

Waiting.

Smiling.

Aryan's jaw tightened.

For the first time since Sentinel entered his life, he felt something he rarely experienced.

Not fear.

Frustration.

Someone was playing with him.

And he hated being manipulated.

The following morning, the message had already reached military intelligence.

The hospital conference room had been temporarily converted into a secure operations center. Several cyber specialists had arrived overnight. Screens covered the walls. Analysts moved between workstations while officers discussed possible explanations.

The result was exactly the same as before.

Nothing.

No trace.

No source.

No identifiable signature.

General Vikram stood near the central display, listening to another analyst explain why the message couldn't be tracked.

The man's voice carried equal parts embarrassment and disbelief.

"Whoever is doing this is operating several levels beyond conventional cyber capabilities."

General Arjun looked unimpressed.

"Meaning?"

The analyst hesitated.

"Meaning if they don't want to be found..."

A pause.

"We won't find them."

The room fell silent.

Nobody liked hearing that.

Especially Aryan.

He sat quietly at the end of the table, reviewing the information in front of him. The messages themselves weren't the problem.

The timing was.

The first message had arrived after the briefing.
The second had arrived immediately after his conversation with Arya.
That wasn't coincidence.
Someone was monitoring him.
Closely.
Far too closely.
And that meant Sentinel either possessed an alarming level of surveillance capability...
Or they had access to information they should never have had.
Neither possibility was acceptable.

Later that evening, Aryan found himself back on the hospital rooftop.
The city stretched endlessly beneath him, glowing beneath the fading light of sunset. Cars moved through distant roads.
Buildings shimmered against the horizon. Somewhere among millions of ordinary people, Sentinel's network was hiding.
The thought irritated him.
Every answer led to more questions.
Every clue revealed another layer.
It was like chasing a ghost.
"You always come here when you're thinking."
Aryan didn't need to turn around.
He recognized the voice immediately.
Rudra walked over carrying two cups of coffee and handed one to him.
Neither spoke for several moments.
The silence between them had never been uncomfortable.
Years of friendship made words unnecessary.
Eventually Rudra leaned against the railing.
"You look terrible."
Aryan accepted the coffee.
"Thank you."
"You're welcome."
Another silence.
Then Rudra's expression grew serious.
"The messages?"
Aryan nodded.
Rudra exhaled slowly.
"Think it's Sentinel?"
"Without question."
"Think they're bluffing?"
Aryan stared toward the city lights.
"No."
The answer came immediately.
Too immediately.
Because deep down he already knew.
Sentinel wasn't bluffing.
Whoever was behind those messages wanted him to know exactly how vulnerable he was.
Not physically.
Personally.
That was the dangerous part.

"What worries you?"
The question surprised Aryan.
Not because Rudra asked it.
Because he already knew the answer.
Aryan remained silent for several seconds.
Then finally spoke.
"They know too much."

Rudra nodded.

"Agreed."

"They shouldn't know anything about the hospital."

"Agreed."

"They definitely shouldn't know about Arya."

That made Rudra look at him.

Carefully.

For the first time since the conversation started.

Because that was the first genuinely personal thing Aryan had said.

A small smile appeared on Rudra's face.

"There he is."

Aryan frowned.

"What?"

"The guy who's pretending he doesn't care."

Aryan rolled his eyes.

Unfortunately, Rudra wasn't wrong.

Again.

The realization annoyed him more than he cared to admit.

Because a month ago, none of this would've mattered.

A month ago, Arya had simply been a doctor.

An irritating doctor.

An infuriating doctor.

A doctor who somehow managed to challenge every decision he made.

Now?

Now the idea of Sentinel knowing her name made something dark twist inside his chest.

And he didn't like it.

Not one bit.

The sun disappeared completely, leaving only city lights beneath the night sky.

Neither man noticed how much time had passed.

Eventually Rudra finished his coffee and stood.

Before leaving, he paused.

"There are two possibilities."

Aryan looked toward him.

Rudra's expression had become unusually serious.

"Either Sentinel is stronger than we thought."

A pause.

"Or they've been preparing for this much longer than we realized."

Neither option sounded good.

In fact, both sounded terrible.

Aryan watched his friend disappear through the rooftop door before returning his attention to the city below.

His instincts screamed that something was coming.

Something bigger than the cyberattacks.

Bigger than recruitment networks.

Bigger than anything they'd uncovered so far.

The messages weren't the operation.

They were preparation.

A distraction.

A psychological attack.

The same pattern repeated once again.

Which meant somewhere behind the scenes, Sentinel was moving pieces into position.

And nobody knew where the final move would land.

Hundreds of kilometers away, inside a dimly lit room, a man stood before a wall of screens.

Some displayed news broadcasts.

Others showed intelligence reports.
Several contained surveillance photographs.
Military officers.
Government officials.
Researchers.
Politicians.
Every screen represented a piece of a much larger puzzle.
At the center of the room stood a single photograph.
Aryan Sharma.
The image had been taken years ago during an operation that officially didn't exist.
The man studied it quietly.
Patiently.
Like a chess player studying his opponent's king.
A younger operative stepped forward.
"Sir."
The older man didn't look away from the photograph.
"Report."
"The cyberattack succeeded."
"Expected."
"The military has redirected resources exactly as predicted."
The older man nodded.
Still watching Aryan's picture.
"And Commander Sharma?"
A faint smile appeared.
Cold.
Calculating.
Dangerous.
The kind of smile that never reached the eyes.
"He's responding exactly as expected."
The younger operative hesitated.
Then asked the question carefully.
"Should we proceed to the next phase?"
The room became silent.
For several moments, only the hum of electronic equipment filled the darkness.
Then the older man finally spoke.
"Not yet."
His gaze shifted toward another photograph pinned beside Aryan's.
This one showed Alpha Team.
Rudra.
Kabir.
Aditya.
Every important connection.
Every important weakness.
The smile deepened.
"The strongest soldiers are never defeated on the battlefield."
The younger operative listened carefully.
The older man folded his hands behind his back.
"They're defeated through the people they protect."
A chill ran through the room.
Because suddenly the objective became clear.
This was never about killing Aryan.
Never about defeating Alpha Team.
It was about breaking them.
Slowly.
Carefully.

Completely.

And somewhere in the darkness, far beyond the reach of military intelligence, the next move had already begun.

End of Chapter 23

Chapter 24

The Watchers

Part I

The discharge papers arrived three days later.

Officially, Commander Aryan Sharma was no longer a patient.

The doctors were happy.

The military was relieved.

Alpha Team celebrated like they had won a war.

Aryan simply wanted to leave.

Unfortunately, hospitals had a habit of turning even the simplest process into a full-day operation.

"You know," Kabir said while watching another nurse hand Aryan a stack of instructions, "for a guy who survived explosions, gunfights, and military operations, paperwork seems to be your greatest enemy."

Aryan gave him a look.

Kabir immediately raised both hands.

"I stand by my statement."

The room burst into laughter.

Even Aryan couldn't stop a small smile.

For the first time in weeks, things felt normal.

Almost peaceful.

And that was exactly what worried him.

Because Sentinel wasn't the kind of enemy that disappeared.

Not after everything they'd uncovered.

Not after the messages.

Not after the cyberattacks.

An enemy that patient never stopped moving.

The question was simple.

What were they planning?

That evening, Alpha Team gathered at a café a few blocks away from the hospital.

The six-month leave still felt strange.

For nearly two years their lives had revolved around missions, operations, and deployments.

Now suddenly they had time.

Actual free time.

None of them knew what to do with it.

"Maybe we should travel."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because the last time you planned a vacation, three people got arrested."

Kabir looked offended.

"That wasn't my fault."

"It absolutely was."

The argument continued while everyone laughed.

Across the table, Aryan remained mostly silent, listening more than speaking.

His gaze occasionally drifted toward the street outside.

Old habits.

Years of military service made it impossible to completely relax.

Every passing face.

Every parked vehicle.

Every unusual movement.

His brain automatically noticed everything.
Usually it meant nothing.
Tonight something felt different.
A black sedan sat across the road.
Nothing suspicious about that.
Except it had been there for almost forty minutes.
The same vehicle.
The same position.
The same tinted windows.
Aryan's expression hardened slightly.
No one else noticed.
Half an hour later, the team finally left.
As they stepped outside, Aryan glanced toward the sedan again.
The parking spot was empty.
The vehicle was gone.
No headlights.
No engine noise.
Nothing.
Just gone.
A strange feeling settled in his chest.
Not enough for alarm.
But enough to remember.
And Aryan had learned long ago that instincts existed for a reason.
Nearly five kilometers away, inside a moving vehicle, a man lowered a camera.
Several photographs appeared on the screen.
Aryan.
Rudra.
Kabir.
The entire Alpha Team.
The man pressed a button.
The images uploaded instantly.
A few seconds later, a response arrived.
Continue observation.
Nothing more.
No explanation.
No further instructions.
The operative smiled faintly.
Because that was all he needed.
The hunt was continuing.
And the targets had no idea.

Chapter 24

The Watchers

Part II

Two days later, Arya finally finished her shift a little after midnight.

It had been one of those exhausting days that seemed determined to test every doctor's patience. Three surgeries had run longer than expected, an emergency trauma case had arrived during her lunch break, and half the junior residents somehow managed to find her every time something went wrong. By the time she signed the last report, her head was pounding and all she wanted was a hot shower and six uninterrupted hours of sleep.

The hospital corridors had grown noticeably quieter by then. Most visitors were gone, only a handful of staff members remained on duty, and the constant rush that usually filled the building had settled into an eerie calm.

Arya grabbed her bag and headed toward the parking structure.

As the elevator descended, she leaned against the wall and closed her eyes for a moment. The events of the last few weeks flashed through her mind.

Aryan's recovery.

Their argument.

His apology.

The strange change in their relationship.

Nothing was simple anymore.

And that irritated her more than she cared to admit.

The elevator doors opened with a soft chime.

The parking structure stretched before her, mostly empty except for a few scattered vehicles sitting beneath rows of fluorescent lights. Shadows filled the spaces between pillars, creating long dark patches across the concrete floor.

Normally she wouldn't have paid attention.

Tonight she did.

Maybe it was instinct.

Maybe exhaustion.

Maybe something else.

But the moment she stepped forward, she felt it.

That uncomfortable sensation.

The feeling that someone was watching.

Arya frowned slightly and continued walking.

Her footsteps echoed softly through the nearly deserted level. The sound bounced off concrete walls before fading into silence.

Then another sound appeared.

A second set of footsteps.

Faint.

Barely audible.

Yet definitely there.

Arya slowed.

The sound slowed too.

Her heart skipped once.

She stopped completely.

Instantly, the footsteps vanished.

Silence.

Total silence.

The parking structure suddenly felt much larger than before.

Arya slowly turned around.

Nothing.

No movement.

No people.

No shadows shifting between the parked cars.
Just empty space.
For several seconds she remained still, scanning every corner of the level.
Nothing.
A laugh escaped her lips.
A nervous one.
"You're tired," she muttered to herself.
It was the logical explanation.
She had worked nearly fourteen hours straight.
Her brain was probably creating problems where none existed.
Satisfied with that conclusion, she continued toward her car.
Even then, however, the feeling refused to disappear completely.

Halfway across the parking level, her phone vibrated.
The sudden sound made her jump.
Immediately she felt ridiculous.
Pulling out the device, she saw Ridhi's name on the screen.
A small smile appeared automatically.

Still alive?

Arya rolled her eyes.
Only Ridhi could ask that as a greeting.

Barely.

The response arrived almost instantly.

Good. Need coffee tomorrow.

You need therapy.

A few seconds later:

Coffee is cheaper.

Despite herself, Arya laughed.

The conversation helped.

The uncomfortable feeling faded slightly.

By the time she reached her vehicle, she had almost convinced herself that the entire thing was a product of exhaustion.

She unlocked the car and climbed inside.

The engine started.

Headlights illuminated the concrete walls ahead.

Within moments she was driving toward the exit ramp.

Completely unaware that she had been right the first time.

One level above her, hidden behind a support pillar, a man lowered a camera equipped with a powerful zoom lens.

His expression remained emotionless as he reviewed the photographs displayed on the screen.

Every image was clear.

Every image was usable.

Every image showed exactly what he needed.

Arya entering the elevator.

Arya walking through the parking structure.

Arya reading messages on her phone.

Arya getting into her vehicle.

The operative selected several photographs and uploaded them through an encrypted channel.

The process took less than ten seconds.

A response arrived almost immediately.

Target confirmed. Continue observation.

The man deleted every local file without hesitation.

Years of training had made the process automatic.

No evidence.

No mistakes.

No trail.

He slipped the camera into a bag and disappeared into the darkness of the parking structure.

Silent.

Patient.

Invisible.

And as Arya's car disappeared into the city beyond the hospital grounds, another notification arrived on his device.

This one contained two photographs.

The first was Arya.

The second was Ridhi.

Beneath them appeared a single line.

Priority status upgraded.

For the first time all night, the operative smiled.

Because that could mean only one thing.

The next phase was getting closer.

Very close.

And neither woman had any idea they had just become part of a much larger game.

To Be Continued...

Chapter 24

The Watchers

Part III

Three nights later, Aryan couldn't sleep.

The city stretched endlessly beyond the balcony of his apartment, glowing beneath thousands of lights. Cars moved like streams of gold through distant roads while the skyline shimmered against the darkness. Normally, moments like these helped him think. Tonight they only made him restless.

A stack of Sentinel reports lay open on the table beside him. He had read most of them twice already, yet the same feeling refused to leave.

Something was wrong.

Not wrong in a way he could explain.

Not wrong in a way intelligence reports could prove.

Just wrong.

His instincts had kept him alive for years, and right now every instinct he possessed was screaming that something was coming.

The problem was that he had no idea what.

The cyberattacks had stopped.

No new threats had appeared.

No new intelligence had surfaced.

Yet Sentinel had suddenly become quiet.

And enemies like Sentinel didn't become quiet without a reason.

They became quiet when they were preparing something.

The thought lingered in his mind as he picked up another report. Before he could read more than a few lines, his phone vibrated against the table.

The sound instantly pulled him from his thoughts.

A secure military notification.

Aryan frowned.

At this hour, notifications from Intelligence usually meant bad news.

Opening the file, he immediately noticed something strange.

There was no accompanying message.

Only photographs.

His expression hardened.

The first image showed Alpha Team leaving the café from several nights earlier.

The second showed Rudra entering his apartment complex.

The third showed Ridhi walking toward her car outside the hospital.

Then Aryan reached the fourth photograph.

And froze.

It was Arya.

The image had clearly been taken from a distance. She was walking through the hospital parking structure after finishing a late shift, completely unaware that someone was watching her.

For several seconds Aryan simply stared at the picture.

Then he looked at the remaining images.

More photographs.

Different locations.

Different times.

Always the same people.

Alpha Team.

Ridhi.

Arya.

A cold feeling settled deep inside his chest.

Because these weren't intelligence photographs.

The military hadn't taken them.

Someone else had.

Someone who wanted him to see them.

His eyes moved toward the bottom of the file.

A single sentence waited there.

They see more than you think.

Aryan immediately stood.

The chair behind him nearly fell over.

Within seconds he was already dialing a secure number.

The call connected almost instantly.

General Vikram answered on the first ring.

"Tell me you received the file."

"I received it."

The General sounded grim.

"We're already investigating."

Aryan's jaw tightened.

"Who sent it?"

"We don't know."

"Where did it come from?"

"We don't know."

The answer only made his mood darker.

For several moments neither man spoke.

Finally the General sighed.

"They wanted you to see it."

Aryan already knew that.

The photographs weren't surveillance.

They were a message.

A demonstration.

A reminder that Sentinel could reach far closer than anyone had realized.

The realization disturbed him more than he wanted to admit.

Not because he was worried about himself.

Because he wasn't.

The people in those photographs weren't random targets.

They were people connected to him.

People Sentinel had intentionally selected.

And that made everything personal.

The following morning, military intelligence launched an internal investigation.

Additional security teams were assigned.

Surveillance detection units reviewed camera footage.

Cyber divisions worked nonstop.

The result was exactly the same as before.

Nothing.

No faces.

No license plates.

No identifiable suspects.

It was as if the people responsible existed only when they wanted to.

And disappeared the moment anyone looked too closely.

By midday, frustration was spreading throughout every department involved.

Sentinel was always one step ahead.

Always.

Aryan hated that.

That evening he found himself standing outside St. Thomas Hospital.

The photographs remained fresh in his mind.

Especially one.

Arya.

For reasons he couldn't explain, that image bothered him more than the others.

Maybe because she had no idea.

Maybe because she would probably dismiss the danger entirely if he told her.

Or maybe because somewhere along the way, protecting her had stopped feeling like an obligation.

The thought annoyed him immediately.

Yet it refused to leave.

As he entered the hospital lobby, his eyes instinctively searched the crowd.

Doctors rushed between departments.

Patients filled waiting areas.

Visitors moved through the building.

Everything looked normal.

Completely normal.

And somehow that made him even more uneasy.

Because if Sentinel had taught him anything, it was this:

The most dangerous threats never announced themselves.

They waited.

They watched.

And they struck when people felt safest.

Hundreds of kilometers away, inside a dark operations center hidden far from public view, a large screen displayed dozens of surveillance photographs.

Aryan.

Rudra.

Arya.

Ridhi.

Each image connected by lines and notes that only a handful of people could understand.

A younger operative entered quietly.

"The military has reacted."

The man standing before the screen nodded.

"Expected."

"They've increased security."

"Expected."

The operative hesitated before asking his next question.

"Should we move forward?"

The room fell silent.

For several moments the older man studied the photographs without speaking.

His gaze eventually settled on Aryan's image.

Then shifted toward Arya's.

A slow smile appeared.

Cold.

Patient.

Dangerous.

The kind of smile that belonged to someone who already knew the outcome of the game.

"Not yet."

The operative frowned.

"Sir?"

The older man folded his hands behind his back.

"The strongest traps are never sprung immediately."

His eyes never left the screen.

"First, you make them comfortable."

A pause.

"Then you make them careless."

Another pause.

"And only then..."

His smile widened slightly.

"...do you take away something they can't afford to lose."

A chill ran through the room.

Because everyone understood exactly what he meant.

The next phase had already begun.

And somewhere in the city, completely unaware, the people in those photographs were continuing their lives as if nothing had changed.

Unfortunately for them...

Everything had already changed.

End of Chapter 24

Chapter 25

First Strike

Part I

The first argument happened less than twenty-four hours after the photographs were discovered.

Aryan wasn't surprised.

In fact, he had expected it.

What he hadn't expected was how quickly it escalated.

"Absolutely not."

Arya crossed her arms and stared at him from across her office.

The expression on her face was one he had become painfully familiar with over the past few weeks.

It was the same look she gave him whenever she believed he was being unreasonable.

Unfortunately for both of them, Aryan believed the exact same thing about her.

"The security team stays."

"No."

"The security team stays."

"No."

For several seconds neither moved.

Neither blinked.

Neither backed down.

A junior doctor passing by the office door took one look inside and immediately walked away.

Experience had taught the hospital staff an important lesson.

When Aryan Sharma and Arya Mehra started arguing, survival meant leaving the area.

Three hours earlier, military intelligence had officially classified the Sentinel photographs as a direct threat.

Additional resources were immediately approved.

Security assessments were conducted.

Protective details were assigned.

And at the top of the protection list sat exactly two names.

Dr. Arya Mehra.

Dr. Ridhi Kapoor.

Neither woman was happy about it.

Especially Arya.

"You cannot assign military personnel to follow doctors around a hospital."

Aryan looked completely unimpressed.

"I can."

"You shouldn't."

"Different conversation."

"Aryan."

"Arya."

She closed her eyes.

Took a deep breath.

Then immediately regretted it.

Because somehow his calm attitude made the situation even more frustrating.

"Do you honestly think I'm going to let armed soldiers follow me through surgery?"

"Yes."

The answer came so quickly that she almost threw a file at him.

Almost.

"What if I say no?"

Aryan didn't even hesitate.

"I'll ignore you."

For a moment Arya genuinely considered violence.

The office door suddenly opened.

Ridhi walked inside carrying a coffee cup.

One look at their expressions told her everything.

"Oh."

She immediately turned around.

"Nope."

Arya pointed toward her.

"Don't you dare leave."

Ridhi sighed dramatically and entered anyway.

"What's the problem now?"

Arya looked offended.

""Now'?"

Ridhi sat down.

"The word was chosen very carefully."

Aryan almost smiled.

Almost.

Arya noticed.

Which somehow annoyed her even more.

"The military wants to assign security."

Ridhi blinked.

"That's it?"

Arya stared at her.

"That's it?"

"Considering the usual arguments, yes."

Aryan actually looked grateful for the support.

That alone should've been a warning sign.

Unfortunately, Ridhi continued.

"Honestly, Arya, after those photographs..."

"They were just photographs."

The second the words left her mouth, Aryan's expression changed.

Not anger.

Something worse.

Concern.

Real concern.

The kind he usually reserved for operational briefings.

"They weren't just photographs."

The room grew quieter.

Arya frowned slightly.

Because his tone had changed.

Completely.

No sarcasm.

No irritation.

No arguing.

Just seriousness.

Aryan leaned forward.

"When those pictures were taken, nobody knew they were being watched."

Neither woman spoke.

"That's the problem."

Still silence.

"Someone followed all of you for days. Maybe weeks."

His eyes moved between Arya and Ridhi.

"They knew schedules."

A pause.

"Locations."

Another pause.

"Habits."

The room felt noticeably colder.

Because hearing it spoken aloud made the situation sound far more dangerous than it had on paper.

Arya looked away briefly.

The photographs had bothered her.

Of course they had.

She simply didn't want to admit it.

Especially to him.

Later that evening, Aryan stood inside the hospital security office reviewing surveillance footage.

Dozens of monitors displayed every entrance, hallway, parking structure, and access point throughout the building.

Nothing unusual.

At least on the surface.

The security chief looked exhausted.

"We checked everything."

Aryan nodded.

"Check again."

The man sighed.

"We already reviewed seventy-two hours."

"Make it ninety-six."

The chief looked like he wanted to protest.

Then remembered who he was talking to.

And wisely remained silent.

Years of military service had sharpened Aryan's instincts into something almost unnatural.

Right now those instincts refused to quiet down.

The photographs.

The messages.

The surveillance.

Every piece fit together too perfectly.

Which meant one thing.

Sentinel wasn't preparing.

They had already prepared.

Now they were waiting.

Outside the hospital, evening traffic moved through the city as usual.

Thousands of people continued their routines completely unaware of the invisible war unfolding around them.

Doctors finished shifts.

Students attended classes.

Families ate dinner.

Life continued normally.

And that was exactly why Sentinel was dangerous.

Because ordinary people never saw them coming.

Several kilometers away, a black SUV sat parked beneath the shadows of an abandoned construction site.

The vehicle's engine remained off.

No lights.

No movement.

Inside, four individuals silently watched a digital map displayed on a tablet.

Colored markers blinked across the screen.

One marker displayed the hospital.

Another displayed Ridhi's apartment.

A third displayed Arya's route home.

The oldest operative studied the information carefully before looking toward the driver.

"Any changes?"

The man shook his head.

"No."

The operative nodded.

As expected.

Then his gaze settled on two photographs clipped beside the display.

Arya.

Ridhi.

For several moments he studied them.

Calculating.

Patient.

Waiting.

Finally he picked up a secure phone and sent a single message.

Observation complete. Awaiting authorization.

The reply arrived less than a minute later.

Only three words.

Proceed to Phase Two.

The operative smiled.

Slowly.

Coldly.

Because somewhere across the city, completely unaware of what had just been decided...

Someone's life was about to become much more dangerous.

Chapter 25

First Strike

Part III

For a few seconds, the deserted road became pure chaos.

The operatives had expected fear.

They had expected panic.

What they had not expected was Rudra.

The motorcycle still skidded across the asphalt behind him, throwing sparks into the darkness as it crashed into a roadside barrier. One operative lay unconscious several meters away while another struggled to recover after taking a brutal strike to the ribs.

The third man finally managed to raise his weapon.

Rudra moved instantly.

Years of combat experience took over.

He grabbed the attacker's wrist before the gun could fully align, twisted sharply, and drove his shoulder forward. The operative lost balance and stumbled backward. The weapon discharged harmlessly into the night sky.

The sound of gunfire echoed across the empty road.

Inside her car, Ridhi froze.

Until that moment, she had only heard stories.

Military reports.

Mission summaries.

News articles.

None of them had prepared her for the reality of watching someone fight.

Especially Rudra.

The man she remembered from years ago had always smiled too much.

Always joked too much.

Always acted like nothing could bother him.

The person standing outside now looked completely different.

Focused.

Cold.

Dangerous.

For the first time, she was seeing the soldier instead of the man.

And it terrified her.

The fight lasted less than a minute.

By the time reinforcements arrived, it was already over.

Or at least it should have been.

Because something strange happened.

The operatives retreated.

Not one of them fought to the end.

Not one of them continued the attack.

The moment they realized Rudra had arrived, they immediately disengaged.

One threw a smoke device onto the road.

Another dragged the injured operative toward the SUV.

Within seconds, the vehicle accelerated away into the darkness.

Gone.

Just like that.

Rudra stood motionless in the middle of the road, breathing heavily.

His eyes remained fixed on the disappearing taillights.

Something wasn't right.

He knew it.
Soldiers developed instincts for these situations.
And his instincts were screaming.
This attack had been too clean.
Too controlled.
Too short.
Almost as if...
They had never intended to succeed.

Five minutes later, military vehicles arrived.
Then local police.
Then intelligence officers.
The entire area transformed into a crime scene.
Ridhi sat inside an ambulance while a medic checked her vitals.
Physically, she was unharmed.
Emotionally was another matter.
Across the road, Aryan finally arrived.
The moment he stepped out of the vehicle, his eyes immediately found Rudra.
One look was enough.
Neither man needed explanations.
Neither needed reports.
Years of friendship had made words unnecessary.
Something was wrong.
Both knew it.

"What happened?"
Rudra briefly explained everything.
The blocked road.
The SUV.
The operatives.
The fight.
The retreat.
Aryan listened without interrupting.
When the explanation ended, he remained silent for several moments.
Thinking.
Analyzing.
Reconstructing.
Then he asked a single question.
"How many?"
"Three."
Aryan nodded slowly.
"Too few."
Rudra's eyes narrowed.
Because he had reached the same conclusion.
If Sentinel truly wanted Ridhi, three operatives weren't enough.
Not against a target under military observation.
Not against someone connected to Alpha Team.
The operation made no sense.
Unless...
"They wanted us to stop them."
Rudra finished the thought.
Aryan nodded.
Exactly.
The realization settled heavily between them.
This had never been a kidnapping attempt.

Not really.
It had been a demonstration.
A warning.
A message.
Sentinel wanted them to know that they could reach Ridhi whenever they wanted.
And if they could reach Ridhi...
They could reach anyone.

A short distance away, Arya arrived after receiving an emergency call from the hospital.
The moment she saw the police vehicles and military personnel surrounding the road, her stomach tightened.
Then she spotted Ridhi.
Safe.
Alive.
Relief flooded through her immediately.
She practically ran across the scene.
Ridhi stood and embraced her before either said a word.
For several seconds neither moved.
Neither needed to.
The fear in that moment said everything.
When they finally pulled apart, Arya looked toward Aryan.
For the first time since meeting him, she didn't argue.
Didn't challenge him.
Didn't tell him he was overreacting.
Because now she had seen the consequences herself.
The danger wasn't theoretical anymore.
It was real.
Painfully real.
Aryan walked toward them carrying a tablet.
His expression remained unreadable.
"Look."
The screen displayed security footage recovered from nearby cameras.
Several images flashed by.
The truck.
The SUV.
The masked operatives.
Everything had been recorded.
Arya stared at the footage.
Her heartbeat quickened.
Because the attack looked organized.
Professional.
Planned.
Nothing about it felt random.
Nothing about it felt normal.
Finally she looked up.
"Who are these people?"
The question hung in the air.
Nobody answered immediately.
Because the truth was far more frightening than any explanation.
Eventually Aryan spoke.
His voice was calm.
Too calm.
The kind of calm that appeared right before a storm.
"People we've been trying to find for months."
Arya felt a chill run down her spine.
For the first time since this entire situation began...

She was afraid.

Not for herself.

Not even for Ridhi.

For what came next.

Because if Sentinel was willing to come this close once...

Then sooner or later they would come closer.

Much closer.

And deep down, everyone standing on that road understood the same thing.

Tonight wasn't the attack.

Tonight was only the warning.

End of Chapter 25

Chapter 26

Protective Custody

Part I

By the next morning, St. Thomas Hospital no longer looked like a hospital.

It looked like a military installation.

Security checkpoints had appeared at every entrance. Additional cameras were being installed across the building. Access restrictions had been updated overnight, and armed personnel were positioned throughout the premises.

Patients were confused.

Doctors were annoyed.

Hospital management was having collective panic attacks.

And in the center of it all stood Commander Aryan Sharma.

As usual.

Aryan was reviewing security layouts near the main entrance when a black military SUV rolled into the hospital grounds.

Moments later, four familiar figures stepped out.

Rudra.

Kabir.

Aditya.

Veer.

All wearing full tactical gear.

Combat vests.

Sidearms.

Communication earpieces.

The entire Alpha Team looked ready to launch a military operation instead of guarding a hospital.

Several nurses immediately stopped walking.

A few interns openly stared.

One receptionist nearly dropped her coffee.

Kabir looked around proudly.

"I like this."

Aditya raised an eyebrow.

"The terrified civilians?"

"The respect."

"That's fear."

"Still counts."

Rudra sighed.

"I miss deployments."

Veer shook his head.

"No, you miss causing problems."

"Also true."

For the first time in days, the atmosphere felt almost normal.

Almost.

On the second floor, Arya stepped out of the elevator carrying a stack of patient files.

She had been informed about the increased security measures earlier that morning.

She had not been informed that Alpha Team had apparently decided to occupy the entire hospital.

The moment she entered the corridor, her eyes landed on Aryan.

And unfortunately...

The sight caught her off guard.

The military uniform fit him perfectly.

The tactical vest.

The rolled sleeves.
The radio clipped to his shoulder.
The focused expression as he issued instructions.
For one brief moment, Arya completely forgot what she had been about to say.
Which was embarrassing.
Extremely embarrassing.
Because the first thing she noticed was that he looked...
Good.
Ridiculously good.
Annoyingly good.
Arya immediately hated herself for thinking that.
Beside her, Ridhi noticed everything.
Every single thing.
A slow grin appeared on her face.
"Oh."
Arya immediately knew that tone.
"No."
Ridhi's smile widened.
"Oh yes."
"No."
"You were staring."
"I was not."
"You absolutely were."
Arya started walking faster.
Unfortunately, Ridhi followed.
"You blushed."
"I did not."
"You literally did."
"I will push you down the stairs."
Ridhi laughed.
"Doctor sahiba..."
"Don't."
"The uniform looks nice, doesn't it?"
Arya stopped walking.
Turned around.
And pointed a finger directly at her.
"One more word."
Ridhi looked completely unafraid.
"Commander sahab is handsome."
Arya looked genuinely ready to commit murder.
Ridhi wisely retreated while laughing.

Unfortunately for Arya, her problems were only beginning.
Because the moment she reached the security station, she discovered what Aryan had been doing all morning.
New checkpoints.
New restrictions.
New patrol schedules.
New security procedures.
Arya stared at the documents in disbelief.
Then slowly looked up.
"Aryan."
The warning in her voice immediately caught everyone's attention.
Several soldiers quietly disappeared.
Years of experience had taught them survival instincts.
Aryan looked up calmly.

"Good morning."

"Why is there a security checkpoint outside the operating wing?"

"Security."

"Why are armed soldiers inside my hospital?"

"Security."

Arya narrowed her eyes.

"Why is everything suddenly security?"

"Because someone tried to kidnap Ridhi three nights ago."

The answer instantly removed all humor from the conversation.

For a moment, silence settled between them.

Then Arya recovered.

Barely.

"This is still excessive."

"No."

"Yes."

"No."

"Aryan."

"Arya."

The nearby officers immediately pretended to be busy.

Nobody wanted to get involved.

Unfortunately, Kabir decided to get involved.

Which was always a terrible idea.

Kabir walked over with a coffee in hand and looked between them.

Then shook his head dramatically.

"You know, Commander."

Aryan already looked concerned.

"What?"

Kabir pointed toward Arya.

"The amount of confidence required to argue with you this much should be studied scientifically."

Arya folded her arms.

Kabir continued.

"In fact, I'm pretty sure insulting a commanding officer violates at least seventeen military regulations."

Aditya joined immediately.

"Possibly twenty."

Veer nodded.

"Minimum."

Rudra looked thoughtful.

"Maybe twenty-five."

Arya slowly turned toward them.

The entire Alpha Team suddenly became very interested in the floor.

A dangerous smile appeared on her face.

"Oh really?"

Nobody liked that smile.

Not even a little.

Arya took one step forward.

"Interesting."

Another step.

"Because I was just discussing volunteer assistance programs."

The smiles vanished instantly.

Kabir looked nervous.

"What kind of assistance?"

Arya's smile somehow became even sweeter.

Which made it infinitely more terrifying.

"The surgical department is short-staffed."

Silence.

"You four can help."
The corridor froze.
Aditya blinked.
Veer blinked.
Kabir looked horrified.
Rudra looked personally betrayed.
Arya continued calmly.
"Twelve-hour shifts."
Nobody spoke.
"Emergency trauma cases."
Still silence.
"And since all of you seem so brave..."
Her smile widened.
"You can observe surgeries."
The entire Alpha Team immediately surrendered.
Kabir raised both hands.
"Commander is right."
Aditya nodded.
"National security first."
Veer agreed.
"Hospital security is extremely important."
Rudra pointed at Aryan.
"I've supported this plan from the beginning."
Aryan almost smiled.
Almost.
For the first time all morning, even he looked entertained.
Arya noticed.
And for a brief moment, their eyes met.
Neither looked away immediately.
The world around them seemed quieter somehow.
Smaller.
Simpler.
Then Ridhi appeared from nowhere.
Unfortunately.
She looked between them.
Then grinned.
"Oh."
Arya immediately groaned.
"Not again."
Ridhi ignored her completely.
Because after months of denial, arguments, and absolute nonsense...
She had finally seen something.
And judging by the way Arya instantly looked away when Aryan glanced at her...
She wasn't the only one.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 26

Protective Custody

Part II

The arguments continued for the rest of the day.

Not because Aryan wanted them to.

Because Arya refused to let them end.

Every new security measure somehow became another reason for a debate.

Every new restriction became another opportunity to remind him that hospitals weren't military compounds.

And every single time, Aryan responded with the same level of stubbornness.

Which only made things worse.

Or better.

Depending on who was watching.

Unfortunately, the entire Alpha Team was watching.

And enjoying every second of it.

By late afternoon, Arya was heading toward the cardiology wing when she noticed an elderly man sitting alone near one of the waiting areas.

The patient looked familiar.

Very familiar.

Then she remembered.

Colonel Arvind Rathore.

Retired.

Former military officer.

One of the long-term patients she had been treating for months.

The old man smiled the moment he saw her.

"Doctor."

Arya smiled back.

"How are you feeling today, Colonel?"

"Old."

She laughed softly.

"That wasn't the medical answer."

"It's the honest one."

The old officer slowly adjusted his position before gesturing toward the empty chair beside him.

"Sit."

Arya checked her watch.

Technically she should've been working.

Then again, she was always working.

A few minutes wouldn't hurt.

She sat down.

For a while they discussed routine medical matters.

Recovery.

Medication.

Physical therapy.

Nothing unusual.

Eventually, however, the conversation drifted elsewhere.

Specifically toward the growing military presence inside the hospital.

The Colonel watched several Alpha Team members pass through the corridor.

A faint smile appeared on his face.

"Good soldiers."

Arya followed his gaze.
"They're driving me insane."
The old man chuckled.
"That means they're doing their job."
"Is being impossible part of military training?"
"Absolutely."
Arya immediately thought of Aryan.
The Colonel noticed.
And laughed again.
"Ah."
Arya frowned.
"What?"
"You're thinking about Commander Sharma."
"No."
The answer came far too quickly.
The old man looked unconvinced.
For good reason.

A few moments later, Aryan himself appeared at the far end of the corridor.
He was speaking into a radio while reviewing security reports.
Focused.
Professional.
Completely unaware that he was being discussed.
The Colonel watched him quietly.
Then his expression changed.
The amusement disappeared.
Respect replaced it.
The kind of respect soldiers reserved for very few people.
Arya noticed immediately.
"You know him?"
The old officer nodded.
"Not personally."
A pause.
"But I know of him."
Arya looked surprised.
The Colonel continued watching Aryan.
"Most soldiers do."
Something about the answer caught her attention.
Because it wasn't admiration.
It wasn't hero worship.
It was something deeper.

"What kind of reputation does he have?"
The old man remained silent for several seconds.
As though carefully choosing his words.
Finally he spoke.
"The kind that isn't written in newspapers."
Arya frowned.
"I don't understand."
The Colonel smiled sadly.
"That's because newspapers write about medals."
A pause.
"They don't write about sacrifices."
The words lingered between them.
Arya found herself listening more carefully.

For reasons she couldn't explain.

"When people look at men like Aryan Sharma, they see decorated officers."

The old man leaned back in his chair.

"They see achievements."

Another pause.

"They see success."

Then he slowly shook his head.

"What they don't see is the cost."

Arya remained silent.

The Colonel's eyes drifted toward the window.

Lost somewhere in memories.

"I spent thirty-two years in uniform."

His voice had become quieter.

"Heard countless stories."

Another pause.

"Lost countless friends."

Arya noticed the sadness immediately.

The kind that never truly disappeared.

The old officer looked toward Aryan again.

"Do you know how many operations he's participated in?"

"No."

"Neither do I."

The answer surprised her.

"But I know enough."

The Colonel folded his hands together.

"I know he's spent years away from home."

A pause.

"I know he's missed birthdays."

Another pause.

"Missed funerals."

The next words landed much harder.

"Missed saying goodbye."

Arya's expression softened slightly.

The old officer noticed.

But continued.

"Most people think soldiers become strong because they stop feeling things."

He smiled sadly.

"The truth is exactly the opposite."

Arya listened carefully.

"Soldiers become strong because they keep moving despite feeling everything."

Silence followed.

Heavy silence.

The kind that forced people to think.

For some reason, Aryan's words from weeks ago suddenly returned to her.

The anger.

The frustration.

The grief he carried.

The walls he had built around himself.

For the first time, she wondered how much of that came from experience.

How much came from loss.

How much came from things he never spoke about.

Things nobody knew.

The realization felt uncomfortable.

Because it forced her to see him differently.
Not as the arrogant commander who constantly argued with her.
Not as the stubborn man who irritated her daily.
But as someone carrying far more weight than he ever allowed anyone to see.

A movement across the corridor pulled her from her thoughts.
Aryan was still there.
Reviewing reports.
Giving instructions.
Working.
Always working.
For a brief moment, she found herself studying him.
Really studying him.
The exhaustion hidden behind the confidence.
The scars visible along his hands.
The permanent alertness in his posture.
The way he constantly monitored everything around him.
As though danger could appear at any second.
Maybe that wasn't paranoia.
Maybe it was experience.
Maybe it was survival.

The Colonel smiled knowingly
"You see it now."
Arya looked away immediately.
Embarrassed.
"I don't know what you're talking about."
"Of course not."
The old man chuckled.
Then slowly stood.
Before leaving, he placed a hand on her shoulder.
"Just remember something, Doctor."
Arya looked up.
The Colonel's expression had become surprisingly serious.
"Some people spend so long protecting everyone else..."
A pause.
"...that they forget how to let others protect them."
Then he walked away.
Leaving Arya sitting alone with her thoughts.
Unfortunately for her, those thoughts kept drifting toward the same person.
And for the first time since they met...
She wasn't entirely sure she hated that.
To Be Continued...

Chapter 26

Protective Custody

Part III

By evening, the hospital had finally started settling into its new routine.

Doctors continued working.

Patients continued recovering.

The additional security presence had become part of the background.

At least on the surface.

Beneath that normalcy, however, military intelligence was working nonstop.

The attempted abduction of Ridhi had triggered alarms across multiple departments. What initially appeared to be a failed kidnapping was now being examined from every possible angle.

And the deeper they looked...

The worse things became.

At approximately 7:15 PM, Aryan received an urgent call from headquarters.

The moment he answered, General Vikram's voice came through.

"Conference room. Immediately."

No greeting.

No explanation.

Just an order.

Which meant something had gone wrong.

Very wrong.

Within ten minutes, the entire Alpha Team was gathered inside one of the hospital's secured meeting rooms.

Large monitors covered the walls.

Intelligence analysts appeared through encrypted video links.

The atmosphere was tense.

Aryan immediately noticed it.

General Vikram looked exhausted.

General Arjun looked angry.

Neither was a good sign.

"What happened?"

The room fell silent.

One of the analysts pulled up several files.

Then spoke.

"We finished analyzing the events from three nights ago."

Rudra folded his arms.

"And?"

The analyst hesitated.

Then displayed a series of timestamps.

"The attack on Dr. Ridhi Kapoor started at exactly 11:43 PM."

Another screen appeared.

Hospital server activity.

"At 11:44 PM..."

A pause.

"...someone breached the hospital network."

The room instantly became silent.

Kabir straightened.

"What?"

The analyst clicked another slide.
More data appeared.
Firewalls.
Security logs.
Access records.
"The kidnapping attempt was a distraction."
Those words changed everything.
Immediately.
Aryan's expression darkened.
Because he had already suspected something similar.
Now he had confirmation.
The analyst continued.
"While everyone focused on the attack, another team entered the hospital network."
Another screen appeared.
Dozens of folders.
Thousands of files.
Patient databases.
Staff records.
Security systems.
Floor plans.
Emergency procedures.
Every major hospital system.
"They copied everything."
Nobody spoke.
Nobody moved.
Because everyone understood what that meant.

Rudra broke the silence first.
"How much is everything?"
The analyst looked uncomfortable.
"Everything."
The answer landed like a bomb.
For several moments, nobody said a word.
Then Aryan finally spoke.
"What specifically were they looking for?"
The analyst clicked another file.
The answer appeared instantly.
Aryan's jaw tightened.
Rudra cursed.
Kabir's expression lost all humor.
Because on the screen were only a handful of names.
Highlighted.
Prioritized.
Targeted.
Dr. Arya Mehra.
Dr. Ridhi Kapoor.
Commander Aryan Sharma.
Major Rudra Singh.
Alpha Team.
The room felt colder.
Much colder.

"They have schedules."
The analyst continued.
"Shift timings."

Another file appeared.
"Building access records."
Another.
"Vehicle registrations."
Another.
"Visitor logs."
The final screen appeared.
Hospital blueprints.
Every floor.
Every emergency exit.
Every access route.
Every blind spot.
For the first time since the meeting began, General Arjun spoke.
His voice was dangerously calm.
"Meaning?"
The analyst swallowed.
"They know exactly where everyone is supposed to be."
Silence.
Absolute silence.
Because that changed everything.
This wasn't surveillance anymore.
This was preparation.

Several floors above, completely unaware of the briefing, Arya and Ridhi were finishing paperwork in the doctors' lounge.
The mood was significantly lighter than it had been in days.
Mostly because Ridhi refused to stop smiling.
Arya immediately noticed.
"What?"
Ridhi looked innocent.
Nothing good ever followed that look.
"Nothing."
"Ridhi."
"Nothing."
Arya narrowed her eyes.
Ridhi lasted approximately three seconds.
Then burst out laughing.
"You like him."
Arya nearly dropped her pen.
"What?!"
"Oh my God."
Ridhi pointed dramatically.
"That reaction!"
"There is no reaction."
"There was absolutely a reaction."
Arya groaned.
"Can we please discuss literally anything else?"
"No."
"Why?"
"Because this is more entertaining."
Arya looked genuinely offended.
Which only encouraged Ridhi further.
"You were staring today."
"I was not."
"You absolutely were."
"I hate you."

"I know."
Ridhi smiled.
"And yet I'm still right."
Arya threw a file at her.
Unfortunately, Ridhi dodged.
Years of friendship had made her highly skilled at survival.

The door suddenly opened.
Aryan walked inside.
Immediately followed by the entire Alpha Team.
The room became awkward instantly.
Especially for Arya.
Because the last thing she needed right now was for everyone to enter while Ridhi was busy embarrassing her.
Kabir looked between them.
Then toward the file lying on the floor.
Then back at Arya.
"...Should we come back later?"
"No."
Arya answered far too quickly.
Kabir immediately became suspicious.
"Interesting."
"Don't."
"Very interesting."
Aryan looked confused.
Rudra looked amused.
Ridhi looked delighted.
The situation was rapidly becoming a disaster.

Unfortunately, the humor disappeared the moment Aryan spoke.
"We have a problem."
Every smile vanished.
Immediately.
The change in his tone was impossible to miss.
Arya stood.
"What happened?"
Aryan exchanged a look with Rudra.
Then handed her a tablet.
Several documents appeared on the screen.
Security reports.
Server logs.
Access records.
The more Arya read, the paler she became.
By the time she finished, the room had fallen completely silent.
"They have all of this?"
Aryan nodded.
"Yes."
The answer was enough.
For the first time since this entire nightmare began, Arya fully understood the scale of what they were facing.
This wasn't stalking.
This wasn't intimidation.
This was planning.
Careful.
Methodical.
Dangerous planning.
And suddenly every security measure Aryan had implemented no longer seemed excessive.

If anything...
They weren't enough.

Hundreds of kilometers away, inside a dark operations center, a massive digital blueprint filled an entire wall.
St. Thomas Hospital.

Every floor.

Every room.

Every corridor.

A man stood silently before it.

Watching.

Studying.

Preparing.

A younger operative approached.

"The breach was successful."

The man nodded.

"Expected."

"We have everything."

A faint smile appeared.

Cold.

Patient.

Satisfied.

His gaze moved toward two highlighted names on the screen.

Dr. Arya Mehra.

Dr. Ridhi Kapoor.

For several moments, he said nothing.

Then finally spoke.

"Good."

The operative waited.

The older man folded his hands behind his back.

"The game is over."

A pause.

His eyes remained fixed on the hospital blueprint.

"Now the hunt begins."

And somewhere far away, completely unaware of the decision that had just been made...

The people inside St. Thomas Hospital continued living their lives.

Not realizing that Sentinel had finally stopped watching.

And started moving.

End of Chapter 26